TEDDY ROOK BOOK · VOCABULARY LADDER

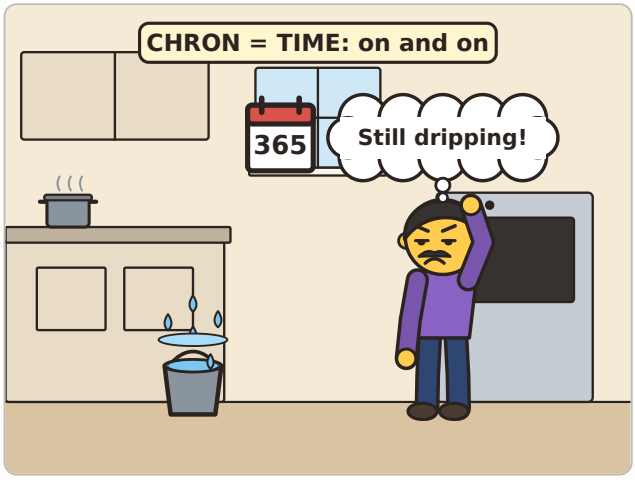
1,000 Words, Pictured

Volume 3 of 4 · Topics 51–75

Each card gives a word, how to say it (the capital letters are stressed), its meaning, a memory hook with a picture, an example and its Greek or Latin parts. To learn a word: say the hook out loud, picture the scene, then cover the card and try to recall the meaning. Come back to it tomorrow and again next week.

51. Words of Time: chron, temp and ann
52. Friendly and Aloof
53. Models and Examples
54. Clear and Unclear
55. Puzzled
56. Dreamers and Doers
57. Growing and Shrinking
58. Stirring Things Up
59. Giving In
60. Important and Trivial
61. Not: in-, im- and ir-
62. Stubborn and Yielding
63. Self-Control and Indulgence
64. Joking and Mocking
65. Bored and Interested
66. Strong and Weak Arguments
67. Before and After
68. Stopping and Holding Back
69. Judging Fairly
70. Hard and Easy
71. Feeling, Loving and Humankind: path, phil and anthrop
72. Wise and Foolish
73. Insults and Slights
74. Loud and Angry Words
75. Lazy and Sleepy

chronic KRON-ik *adjective*



MEANING lasting a long time, or coming back again and again

MEMORY HOOK **CHRON = TIME: trouble that lasts a long TIME.** The kitchen faucet has dripped every day for a whole year: drip, drip, drip. The leak is **chronic**.

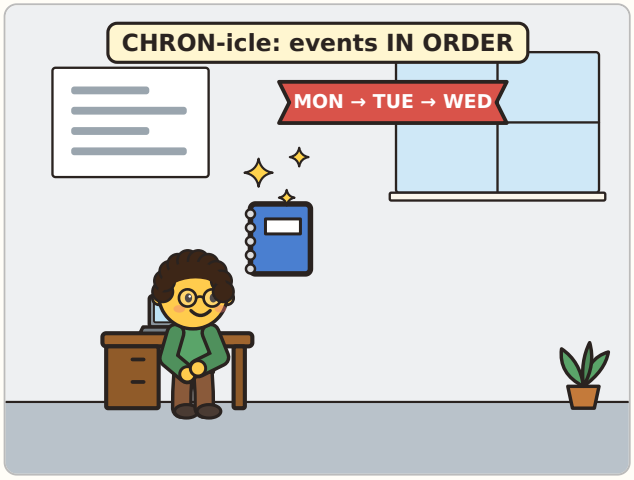
*Kai is a **chronic** latecomer: he has missed the first bell every day this month.*

PARTS **chron** time + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR long-lasting, persistent, recurring, habitual

OPPOSITE brief, temporary, occasional

chronicle KRON-ih-kul *noun*



MEANING a record of events in the order they happened

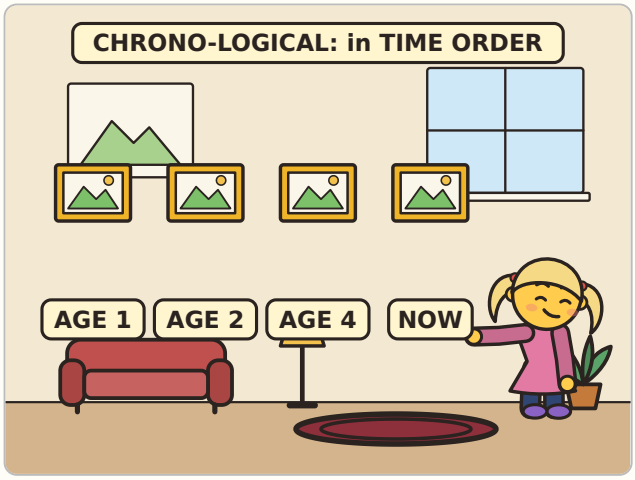
MEMORY HOOK **CHRON-icle: a TIME record, day by day.** Sami writes down each day of the class trip in order, Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, in his travel book: it is a **chronicle** of the trip.

*Nana Lou keeps a **chronicle** of every family trip in a fat green notebook.*

PARTS **chron** time

SIMILAR record, history, account, annals

chronological kron-uh-LOJ-ih-kul *adjective*



MEANING arranged in the order in which things happened

MEMORY HOOK **CHRONO-LOGICAL: TIME in LOGICAL order.** Ivy hangs her photos in order of time: baby, toddler, first grade, now. The row is **chronological**.

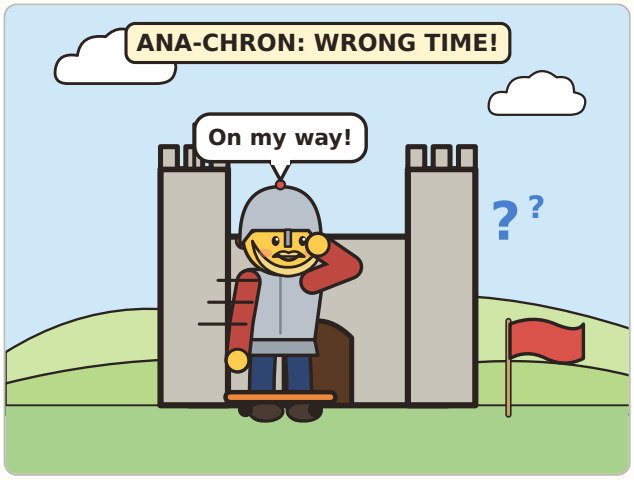
*Ivy lined up her baby pictures in **chronological** order, from her first day to her fifth birthday.*

PARTS **chron** time + **log** word, reason + **-ical** having to do with

SIMILAR sequential, in time order, ordered

OPPOSITE random, jumbled, out of order

anachronism uh-NAK-ruh-niz-um *noun*



MEANING something placed in the wrong time period

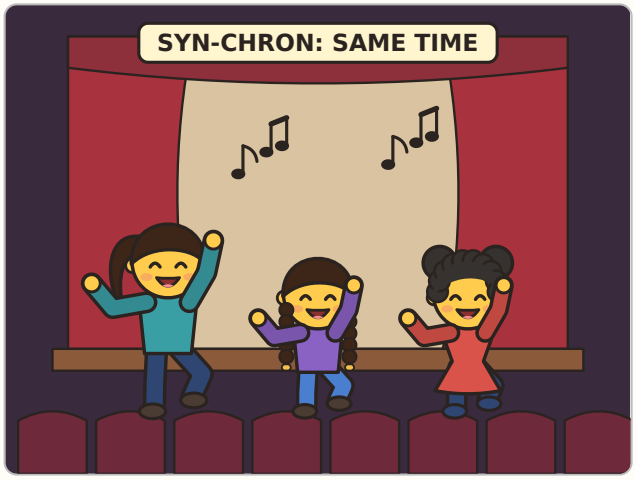
MEMORY HOOK **ANA-CHRON: AGAINST its TIME.** A knight in shining armor rolls up to the castle on a skateboard, chatting on his phone. Wrong time! He is an **anachronism**.

*A knight checking his phone would be a funny **anachronism** in a movie about castles.*

PARTS **ana-** back, against + **chron** time + **-ism** a thing or practice

SIMILAR time error, misdating, thing out of its time

synchronize SING-kruh-nize *verb*



MEANING to make things happen at the same time or at the same speed

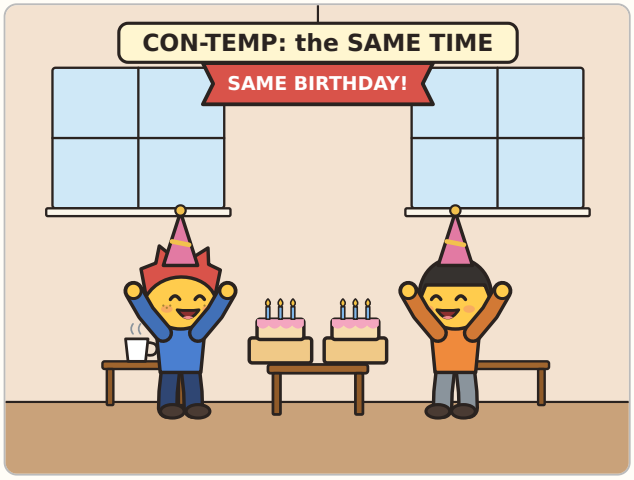
MEMORY HOOK **SYN-CHRON: SAME TIME, together.** Three dancers kick their legs at exactly the same moment, on the very same beat: they **synchronize** their moves.

Before the race, the timekeepers **synchronized** *their stopwatches.*

PARTS **syn-** together + **chron** time + **-ize** to make

SIMILAR coordinate, match, time together, align

contemporary kun-TEM-puh-rair-ee *adjective*



MEANING living or happening at the same time; also, modern

MEMORY HOOK **CON-TEMPOR: WITH the same TIME.** Pip and Kai were born on the very same day and have shared every birthday since: they are **contemporary**, two kids of the same time.

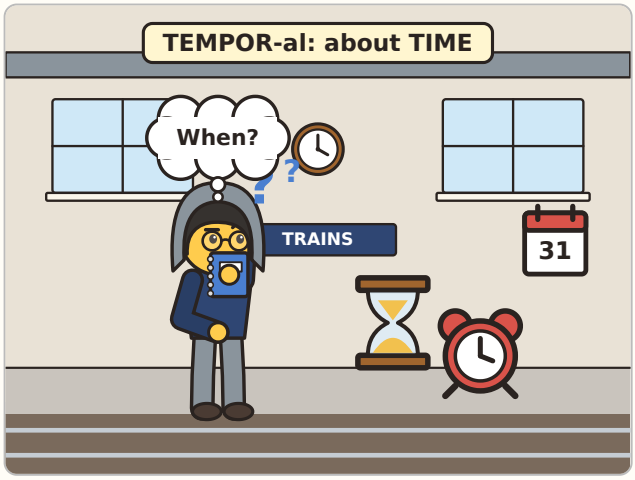
The museum's new wing shows **contemporary** *art, made in the last few years.*

PARTS **con-** with, together + **tempor** time

SIMILAR simultaneous, coexisting, modern, current

OPPOSITE old-fashioned, past, antique

temporal TEM-per-ul *adjective*



MEANING having to do with time

MEMORY HOOK **TEMPOR-al: a question of WHEN.** Detective Ada doesn't ask where the thief went; she asks when. Clock, calendar, timetable: her questions are **temporal**.

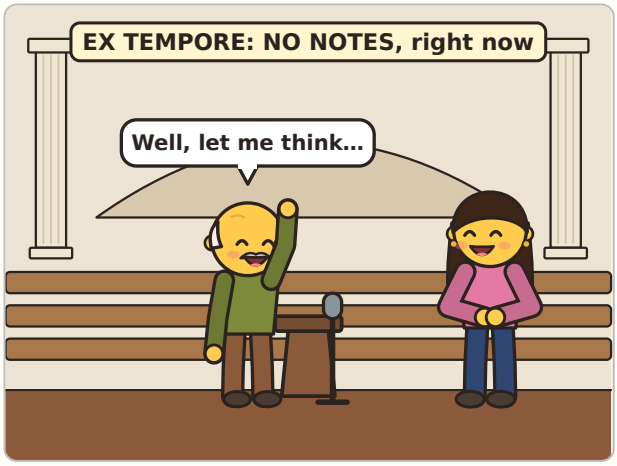
The story jumps back and forth, so readers must follow its **temporal** *clues: dates, seasons and ages.*

PARTS **tempor** time + **-al** having to do with

SIMILAR time-related, time-based

OPPOSITE spatial

extemporaneous ek-stem-puh-RAY-nee-us *adjective*



MEANING spoken or done without any preparation

MEMORY HOOK **EX TEMPOR: OUT of the moment.** Asked to speak with no warning, Grandpa Gus stands right up and talks with no notes at all, straight out of the moment. His speech is **extemporaneous**.

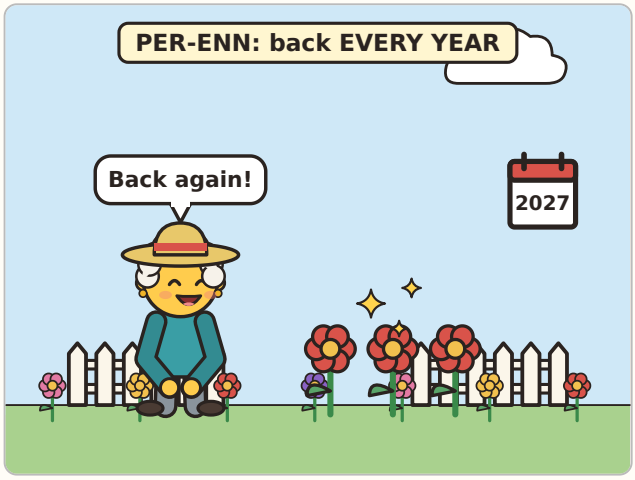
Called on without warning, Dev gave an **extemporaneous** *talk about his favorite book.*

PARTS **ex-** out of + **tempor** time + **-aneous** having to do with

SIMILAR impromptu, unrehearsed, spontaneous, off-the-cuff

OPPOSITE rehearsed, prepared, planned

perennial puh-**REN**-ee-ul *adjective*



MEANING lasting or coming back year after year

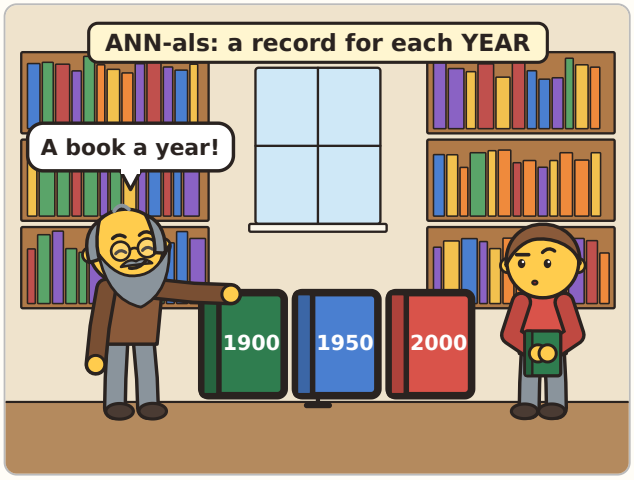
MEMORY HOOK **PER-ENN: THROUGH the YEARS.** Every spring, the same red tulips pop up in Nana Lou's garden, year after year after year: they are **perennial**.

Pizza is a **perennial** *favorite in our school cafeteria.*

PARTS **per-** through + **enn** year

SIMILAR lasting, enduring, recurring
OPPOSITE short-lived, fleeting, one-time

annals **AN**-ulz *noun*



MEANING a year-by-year record of events; history

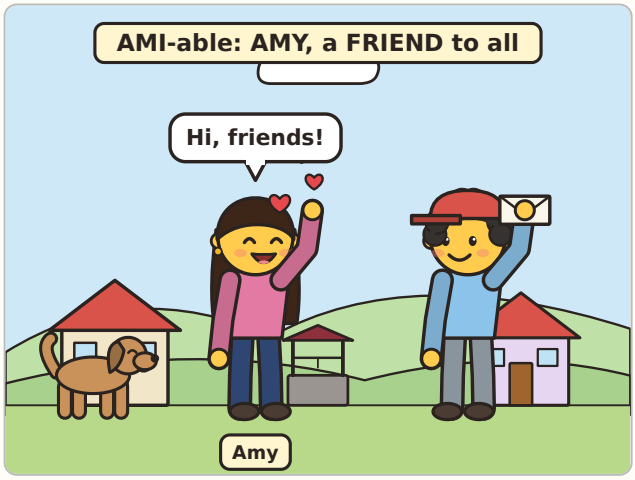
MEMORY HOOK **ANN = YEAR: a book for every YEAR.** The town library keeps one big book for every year since long ago, shelf after shelf. Together they are the town's **annals**.

The great flood is still remembered in the town's **annals**.

PARTS **ann** year

SIMILAR records, chronicles, history, archives

amiable **AY**-mee-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING friendly and pleasant to be around

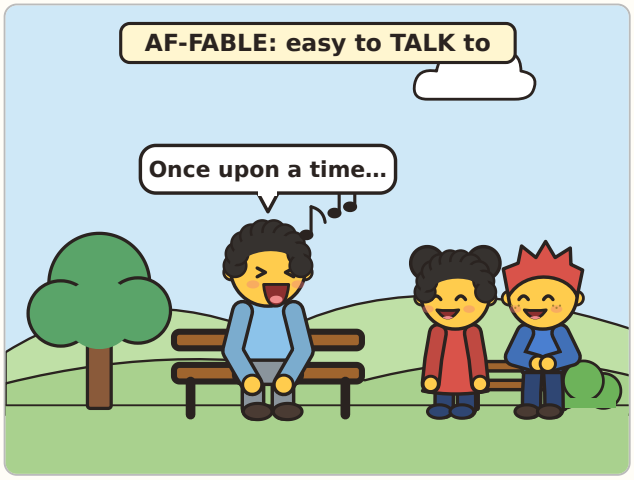
MEMORY HOOK **AMI-able: AMY, everyone's friend.** Amy smiles and says hello to everyone she passes, from the mail carrier to the dog next door. Amy is **amiable**.

The **amiable** *bus driver greeted every rider by name.*

PARTS **ami** friend, love + **-able** having the quality of

SIMILAR friendly, pleasant, good-natured, likable
OPPOSITE unfriendly, hostile, disagreeable

affable **AF**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING easy to talk to; friendly and good-natured

MEMORY HOOK **AF-FABLE: always has a FABLE for you.** Jamal always has a funny fable for anyone who sits beside him on the park bench. He is so easy to talk to: **affable**.

The **affable** *chef chatted with every diner who stopped by the kitchen window.*

PARTS **af-** to (a form of ad-) + **fa** speak + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR friendly, approachable, easygoing, cordial
OPPOSITE unapproachable, aloof, standoffish

genial JEEN-yul *adjective*



MEANING friendly, warm and cheerful

MEMORY HOOK **GENIE-al: as warm as a friendly GENIE.** Sven throws open his door with a grin as wide as a genie's: "Come in! Cocoa's hot!" He is **genial**.

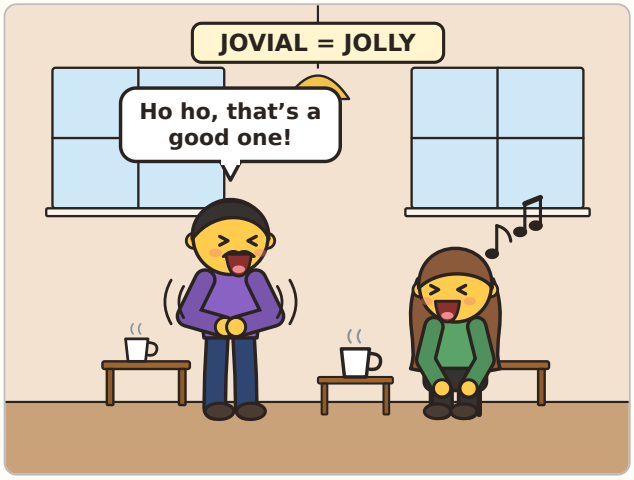
*Our **genial** host met us at the door with a big smile and mugs of hot cocoa.*

PARTS **geni** spirit (from Latin genius) + **-al** having to do with

SIMILAR friendly, warm, cordial, cheerful

OPPOSITE cold, unfriendly, surly

jovial JOH-vee-ul *adjective*



MEANING cheerful and full of good humor

MEMORY HOOK **JOVIAL = JOLLY.** Marcus laughs so hard at his own joke that his shoulders shake, and soon the whole café is laughing with him. He is **jovial**.

*The **jovial** mail carrier whistled and joked on every porch.*

SIMILAR jolly, merry, cheerful, friendly

OPPOSITE gloomy, glum, morose

convivial kun-VIV-ee-ul *adjective*



MEANING lively and friendly, enjoying feasts and good company

MEMORY HOOK **CON-VIV: LIVELY TOGETHER.** At the block party there's food on every table, music in the air and laughter all around, with everyone living it up together. The party is **convivial**.

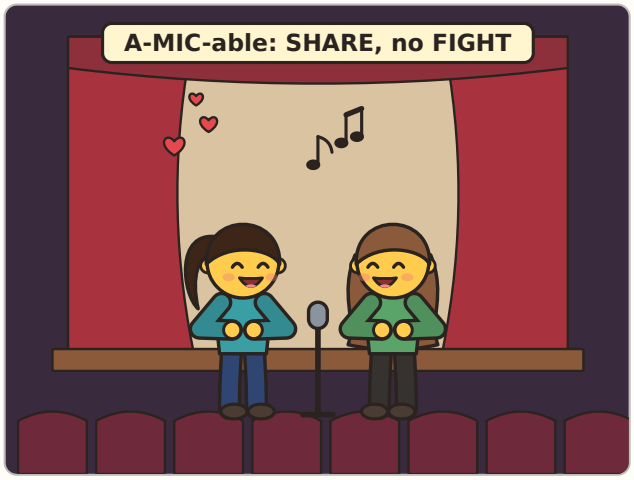
*The **convivial** picnic went on long after the sun went down.*

PARTS **con-** together + **viv** live

SIMILAR sociable, festive, lively, friendly

OPPOSITE unsociable, gloomy, solemn

amicable AM-ih-kuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING friendly and peaceful, without quarrels

MEMORY HOOK **A-MIC-able: share the MIC, no fight.** Maya and Rosa both want to sing, so instead of quarreling, they share the microphone and sing together. Their deal is **amicable**.

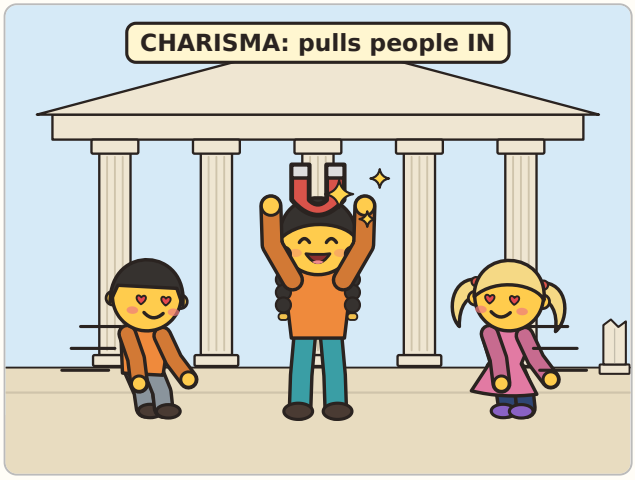
*After the game, the two teams shook hands and parted on **amicable** terms.*

PARTS **amic** friend + **-able** having the quality of

SIMILAR friendly, peaceful, cordial, harmonious

OPPOSITE hostile, bitter, quarrelsome

charismatic kair-iz-**MAT**-ik *adjective*



MEANING having a charm that draws people in

MEMORY HOOK **CHARISMA: CHARM like a MAGNET.** When Tia walks into the room, everyone turns and drifts toward her, as if she were holding a magnet. She is **charismatic**.

*The **charismatic** coach could fire up the whole team with a single smile.*

PARTS **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR charming, magnetic, captivating, appealing
OPPOSITE dull, uninspiring, bland

aloof uh-**LOOF** *adjective*



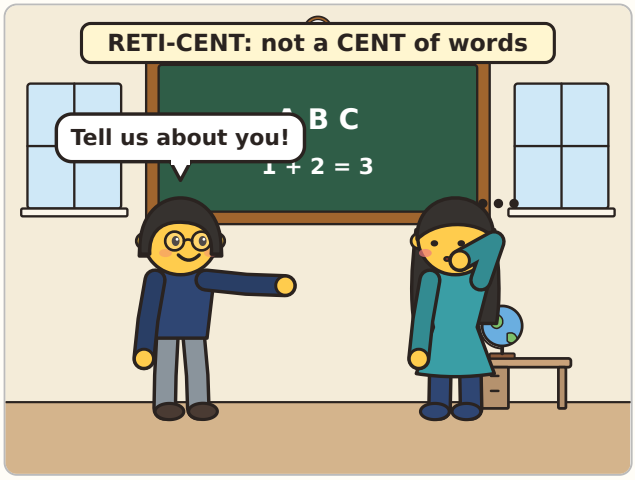
MEANING cool and distant; not friendly or involved

MEMORY HOOK **A-LOOF: alone up on the ROOF.** While the family plays in the yard below, the cat sits alone on the roof and won't come down. The cat is **aloof**.

*The **aloof** cat watched the party from the top of the bookshelf.*

SIMILAR distant, reserved, standoffish, withdrawn
OPPOSITE friendly, warm, sociable

reticent **RET**-ih-sunt *adjective*



MEANING not willing to say much or to share thoughts and feelings

MEMORY HOOK **RETI-CENT: not one CENT's worth of words.** Ask Lin about her weekend, and you won't get one cent's worth of words: just a smile and a shrug. She is **reticent**.

*Usually **reticent**, Sami surprised everyone with a long, funny speech at his sister's graduation.*

PARTS **re-** back + **tic** be silent

SIMILAR reserved, quiet, tight-lipped, taciturn
OPPOSITE talkative, outspoken, forthcoming

reclusive rih-**KLOO**-siv *adjective*



MEANING avoiding the company of other people; living alone and apart

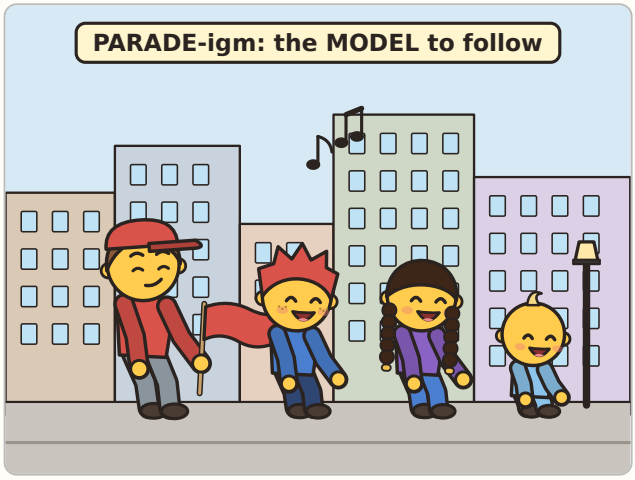
MEMORY HOOK **RE-CLUSE: CLOSED away from everyone.** Omar lives alone in a cabin deep in the woods, with the door closed and a sign out front. He is **reclusive**.

*The **reclusive** painter rarely left her cabin in the woods.*

PARTS **re-** back, away + **clus** shut + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR solitary, withdrawn, secluded, isolated
OPPOSITE sociable, outgoing, gregarious

paradigm PAIR-uh-dime *noun*



MEANING a typical example or model; also, a widely accepted way of thinking

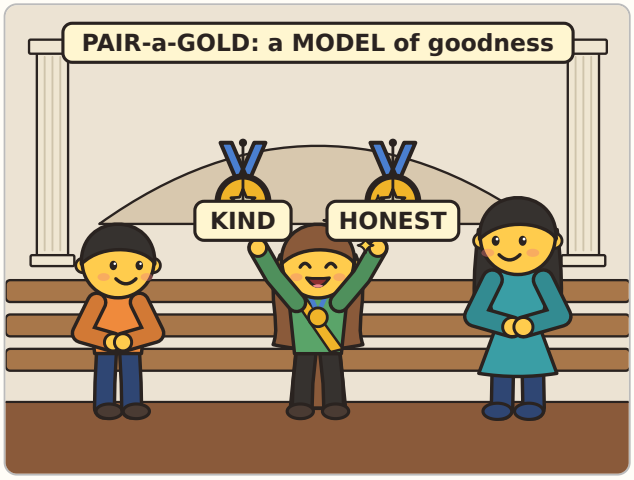
MEMORY HOOK **PARADE-igm: the leader everyone copies.** Jonah leads the parade with a high-stepping march, and every child behind him copies each step. His march is the **paradigm**.

Her neat, colorful notes became the **paradigm** *for the whole study group.*

PARTS **para-** beside + **digm** show

SIMILAR model, pattern, framework, standard

paragon PAIR-uh-gon *noun*



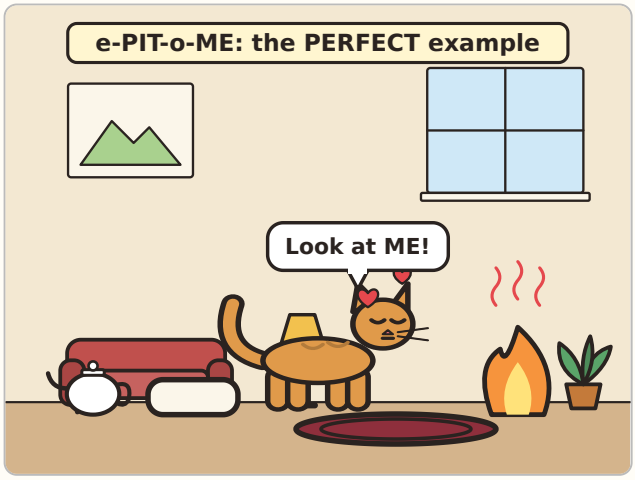
MEANING a model of excellence; a perfect example of a good quality

MEMORY HOOK **a PAIR of GOLD medals: a model of goodness.** Rosa wins a pair of gold medals at school, one for kindness and one for honesty. She is a **paragon** of good character.

Granny Mae is a **paragon** *of patience; no one has ever heard her raise her voice.*

SIMILAR model, ideal, exemplar, epitome

epitome ih-PIT-uh-mee *noun*



MEANING a perfect example of a quality or a type

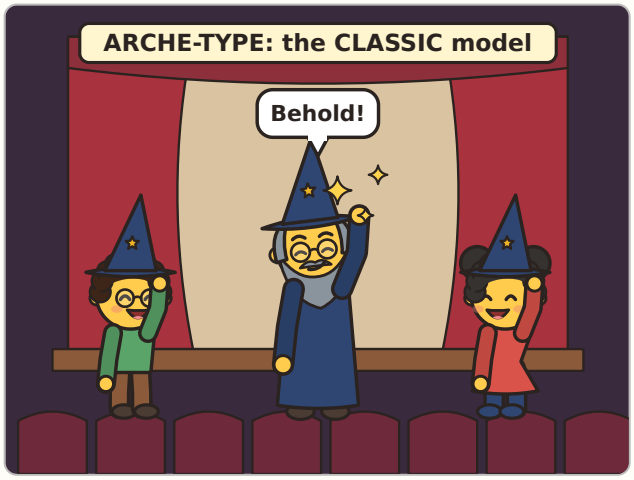
MEMORY HOOK **e-PIT-o-ME: “Look at ME: perfectly cozy!”.** Curled on a soft rug by the warm fire, the cat purrs: “Look at me!” She is the **epitome** of coziness.

With his top hat and gold watch chain, Victor looked like the **epitome** *of an old-fashioned gentleman.*

PARTS **epi-** upon + **tome** cut

SIMILAR embodiment, perfect example, essence, model

archetype AR-kih-type *noun*



MEANING an original model; a classic example of a type that others follow

MEMORY HOOK **ARCHE-TYPE: the FIRST TYPE, copied in every tale.** Professor Edwin plays the wise old wizard in the school play, and every kid in a wizard hat copies him: the long beard, the staff, the deep voice. He is the **archetype**.

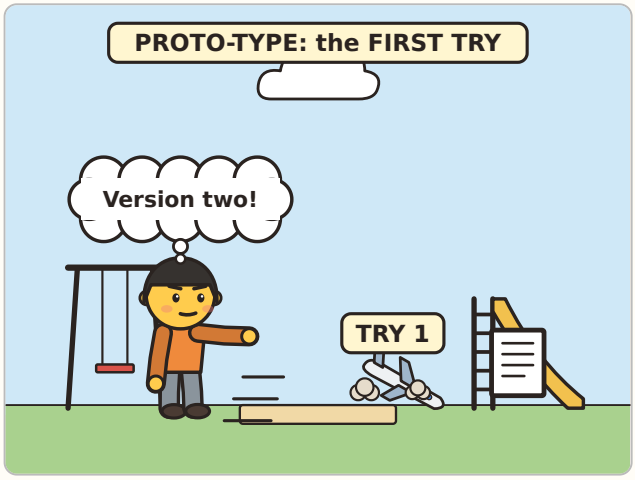
The wise old wizard is an **archetype** *found in stories all over the world.*

PARTS **arche-** first, original + **type** model, stamp

SIMILAR original, model, prototype, classic example

OPPOSITE copy, imitation

prototype **PROH**-tuh-type *noun*



MEANING a first, trial version of something, built to test it

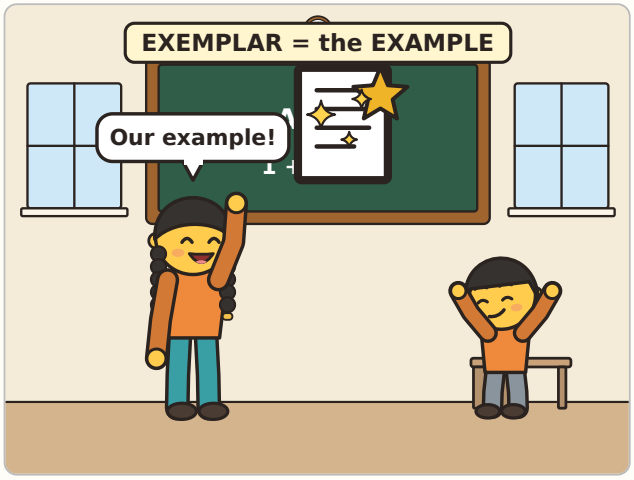
MEMORY HOOK **PROTO-TYPE: the FIRST TRY.** Kai's first paper plane flies three feet and nose-dives into the grass. It's only the **prototype**; version two will fly farther.

The engineers crashed the **prototype** *on purpose to test its seat belts.*

PARTS **proto-** first + **type** model

SIMILAR first version, test model, model, mock-up
OPPOSITE final version, copy

exemplar ig-**ZEM**-plar *noun*



MEANING a person or thing that serves as a model to copy

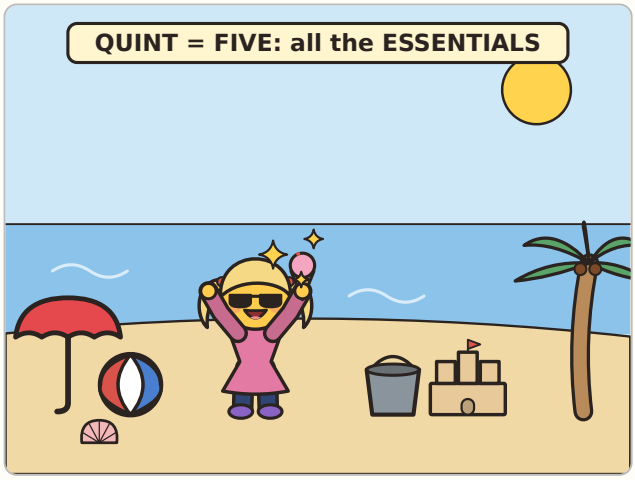
MEMORY HOOK **EXEMPLAR = EXAMPLE.** Ms. Tia pins Kai's perfect poster on the board with a gold star: "Use this as your example!" His poster is the **exemplar**.

The teacher posted Lila's essay as an **exemplar** *of clear writing.*

PARTS **ex-** out

SIMILAR model, example, standard, paragon

quintessential kwin-tuh-**SEN**-shul *adjective*



MEANING being the most perfect or typical example of something

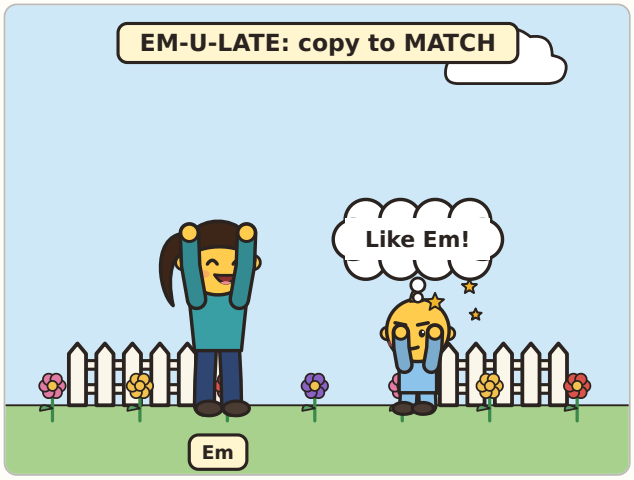
MEMORY HOOK **QUINT-ESSENTIAL: all FIVE ESSENTIALS.** Sun, sand, waves, a bucket and an ice cream cone: Ivy's beach day has all five essentials. It is the **quintessential** summer day.

A lemonade stand on a hot day is the **quintessential** *summer business.*

PARTS **quint** fifth + **essent** being, essence

SIMILAR typical, classic, ideal, archetypal
OPPOSITE atypical, unusual

emulate **EM**-yuh-layt *verb*



MEANING to imitate someone you admire, hoping to match or surpass them

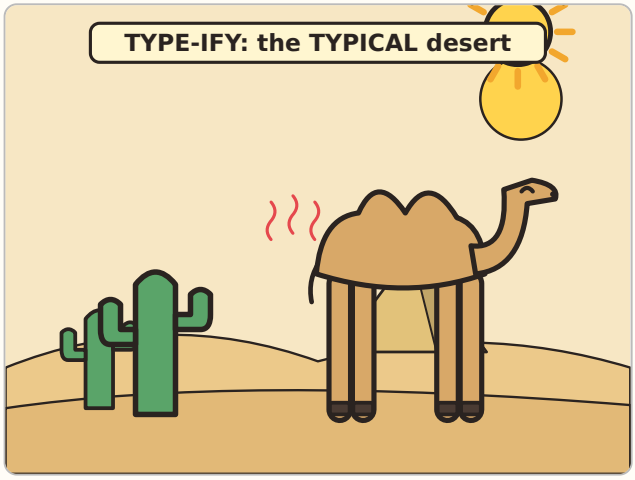
MEMORY HOOK **EM-U-LATE: "I'll be like EM, you'll see, LATEr!".** Little Theo watches his big sister Em stretch up tall before her dance, then copies her move exactly: one day he'll be as good as Em. He **emulates** her.

Little Theo **emulates** *his big sister, practicing her cartwheels every afternoon.*

PARTS **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR imitate, follow, match, rival

typify **TIP**-ih-fye *verb*



MEANING to be a typical example of; to show the usual features of

MEMORY HOOK **TYPE-ify: shows the TYPE.** A cactus, a camel and a blazing sun: these three **typify** the desert.

Long lines and loud music **typify** *the first day of the county fair.*

PARTS **typ** type, model + **-ify** to make, to be

SIMILAR represent, exemplify, characterize, embody

benchmark **BENCH**-mark *noun*



MEANING a standard that other things are measured against

MEMORY HOOK **BENCH-MARK: the MARK on the BENCH.** Every summer, Lila stands by the old park bench where Dad once marked her height. That mark is the **benchmark** she measures her growing against.

Her record time became the **benchmark** *for every runner on the team.*

SIMILAR standard, yardstick, touchstone, gauge

lucid **LOO**-sid *adjective*



MEANING clear and easy to understand

MEMORY HOOK **LUCY-d: Lucy's map is CLEAR as day.** Lucy's map is so clear that anyone can follow it: one big arrow, three landmarks and an X. Her map is **lucid**.

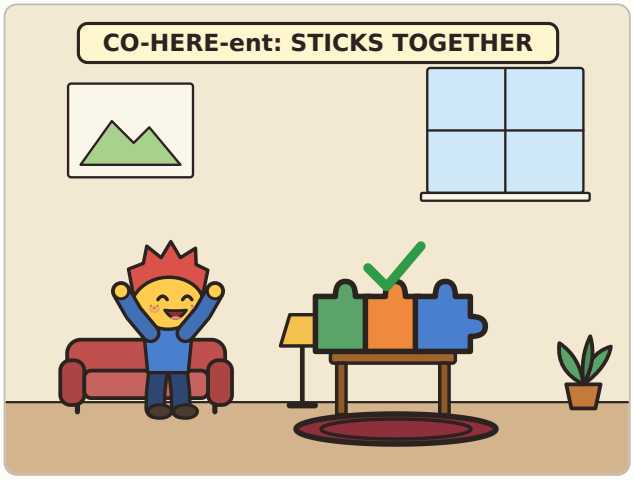
Ada gave a **lucid** *explanation of how rainbows form.*

PARTS **luc** light

SIMILAR clear, plain, understandable, coherent

OPPOSITE confusing, obscure, muddled

coherent koh-**HEER**-unt *adjective*



MEANING logical and consistent; holding together clearly

MEMORY HOOK **CO-HERE: the pieces STICK TOGETHER.** Every piece of Pip's puzzle fits and sticks to the next, making one clear picture. Like his puzzle, his story is **coherent**.

After a good night's sleep, Dev rewrote his messy essay until it was finally **coherent**.

PARTS **co-** together + **her** stick

SIMILAR logical, consistent, orderly, clear

OPPOSITE incoherent, jumbled, rambling

explicit ik-**SPLIS**-it *adjective*



MEANING stated clearly and fully, leaving nothing to guess

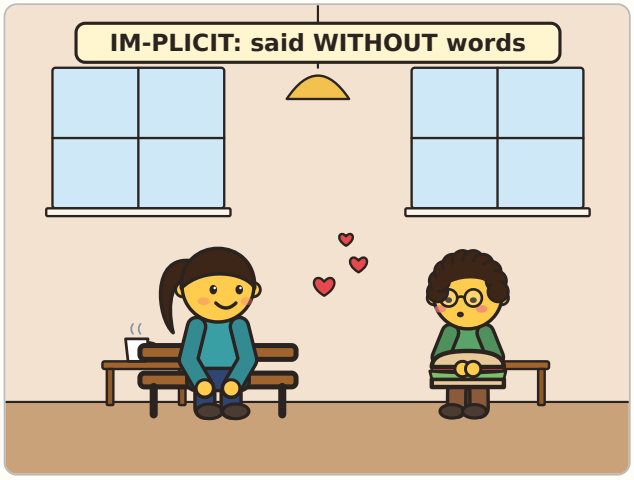
MEMORY HOOK **EX-PLIC-it: spelled OUT, unfolded.** The beach sign spells it out in big letters, NO DOGS!, so Ivy and her pup turn around. The rule is **explicit**.

Mom's rules were **explicit***: homework first, then one hour of games.*

PARTS **ex-** out + **plic** fold

SIMILAR clear, plain, direct, specific
OPPOSITE implicit, vague, unstated

implicit im-**PLIS**-it *adjective*



MEANING suggested but not said directly

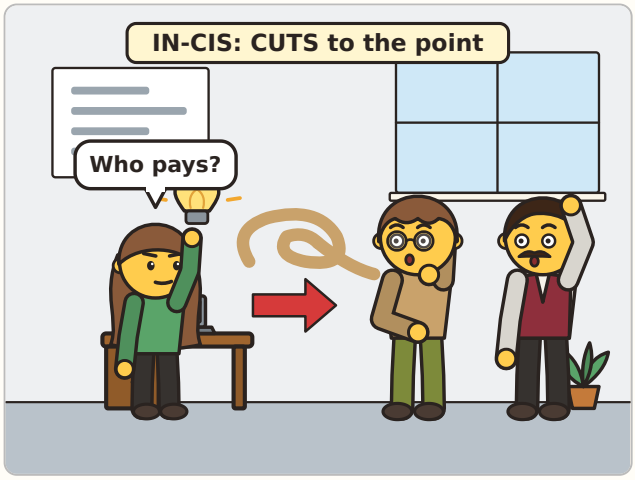
MEMORY HOOK **IM-PLIC-it: folded IN, not said.** Maya never says "Sit with me," but she scoots over and pats the bench. The invitation is **implicit**.

Her smile carried an **implicit** *invitation to join the game.*

PARTS **im-** in + **plic** fold

SIMILAR implied, unstated, unspoken, understood
OPPOSITE explicit, stated, spoken

incisive in-**SYE**-siv *adjective*



MEANING sharp and direct; going straight to the heart of the matter

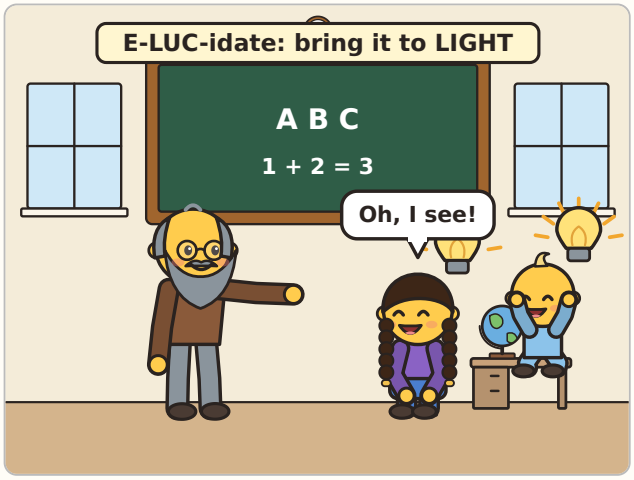
MEMORY HOOK **IN-CIS-ive: CUTS right IN to the point.** The meeting is a tangle of talk until Rosa's one sharp question cuts straight through it, like an arrow. She is **incisive**.

The coach's **incisive** *comment fixed Kai's swing in a single sentence.*

PARTS **in-** into + **cis** cut + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR sharp, keen, penetrating, to the point
OPPOSITE vague, rambling, dull

elucidate ih-**LOO**-sih-dayt *verb*



MEANING to make clear; to explain

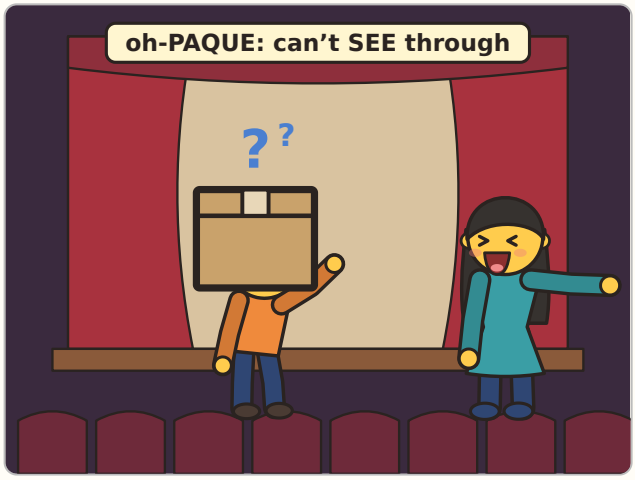
MEMORY HOOK **E-LUC-idate: bring it OUT into the LIGHT.** Professor Edwin draws a simple picture on the board, and one by one the puzzled faces light up: "Oh, I see!" He **elucidates** the idea.

The museum guide **elucidated** *how the ancient water clock kept time.*

PARTS **e-** out (a form of ex-) + **luc** light + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR explain, clarify, illuminate, spell out
OPPOSITE obscure, confuse, muddle

opaque oh-**PAKE** *adjective*



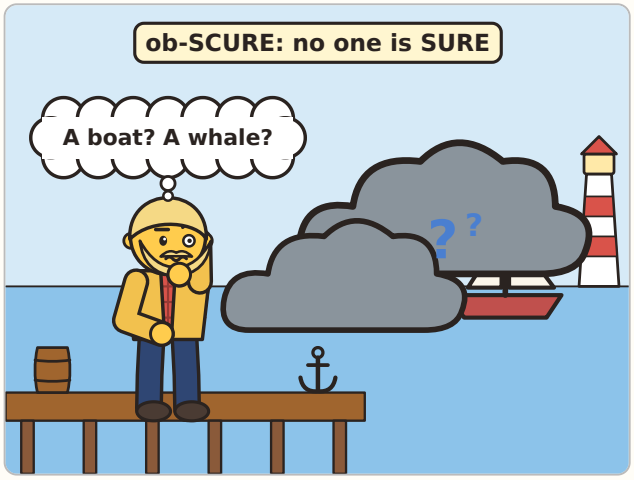
MEANING hard to understand; also, not letting light through

MEMORY HOOK **oh-PAQUE: a box on your head: no seeing through.** For the costume party, Dev wears a cardboard box over his head. No light gets through; he can't see out, and no one can see in. The box is **opaque**.

The **opaque** *curtains kept the bedroom dark even at noon.*

SIMILAR unclear, murky, cloudy, impenetrable
OPPOSITE clear, transparent, lucid

obscure ub-**SKYOOR** *adjective*



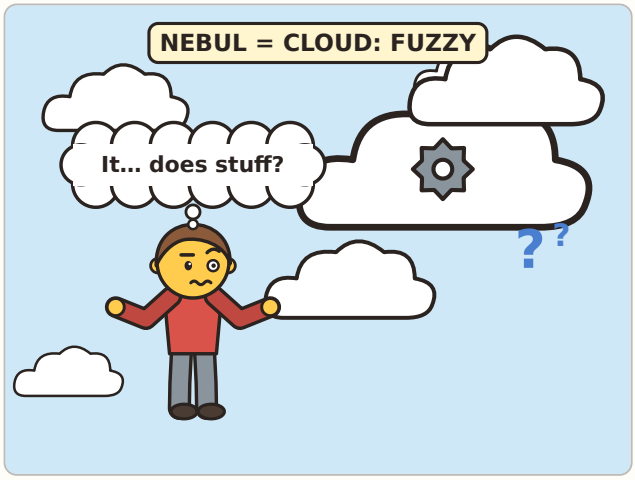
MEANING not clear or easy to understand; also, not well known

MEMORY HOOK **ob-SCURE: so dim, no one is SURE.** Through the thick fog, Sven can barely make out a shape on the water: a boat? a whale? No one is sure. It is **obscure**.

The joke was too **obscure** *for anyone at the table to get.*

SIMILAR unclear, vague, little-known, unknown
OPPOSITE clear, famous, well-known

nebulous **NEB**-yuh-lus *adjective*



MEANING vague and unclear in form or meaning; hazy

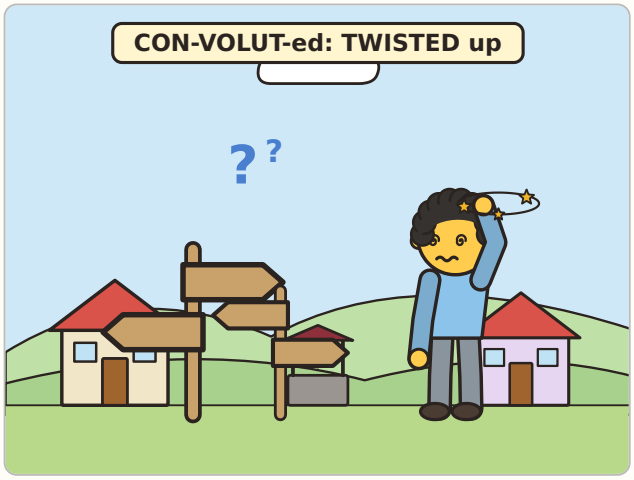
MEMORY HOOK **NEBUL = CLOUD: a FUZZY idea.** Ask Jonah what his new invention does, and his answer is as fuzzy as a cloud: "It… sort of… does stuff?" His idea is **nebulous**.

Kai had only a **nebulous** *plan for the weekend: "do something fun."*

PARTS **nebul** cloud, mist + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR vague, hazy, cloudy, fuzzy
OPPOSITE clear, definite, precise

convoluted **KON**-vuh-loo-tid *adjective*



MEANING so twisted and complicated that it is hard to follow

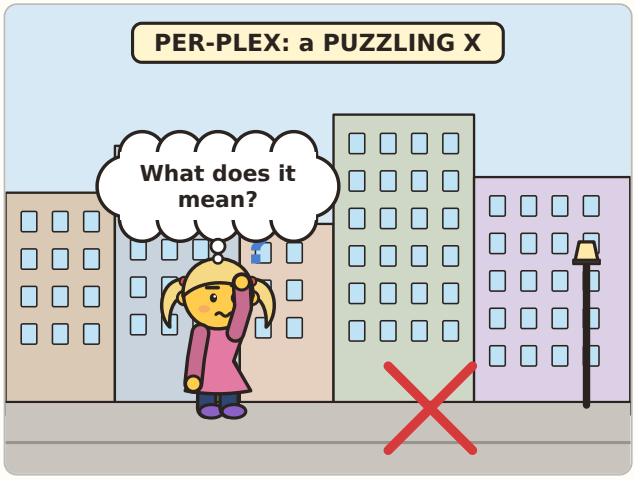
MEMORY HOOK **CON-VOLUTE: ROLLED up in knots.** The signposts at the crossroads point every which way, and the directions twist around and back. Jamal gives up: the route is **convoluted**.

The directions to the cabin were so **convoluted** *that we got lost twice.*

PARTS **con-** together + **volut** rolled, twisted

SIMILAR complicated, twisted, tangled, unclear
OPPOSITE simple, direct, clear

perplex per-**PLEKS** *verb*



MEANING to confuse and trouble someone with something hard to understand

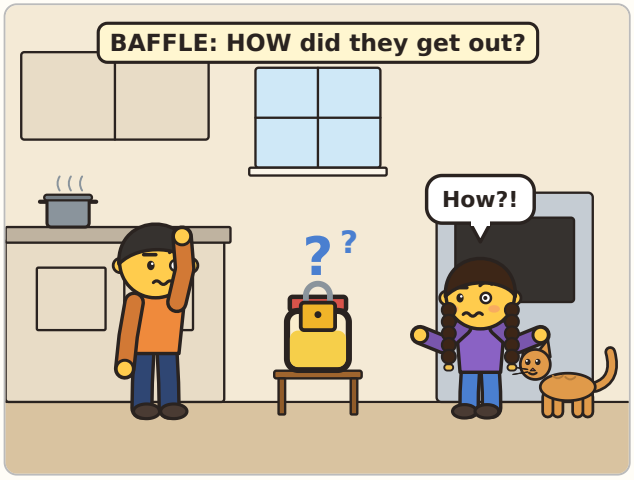
MEMORY HOOK **PER-PLEX: a PUZZLING X.** Ivy finds a big X painted on the sidewalk, with no note and no arrow. It **perplexes** her all week.

The strange thumping in the attic **perplexed** *the whole family.*

PARTS **per-** thoroughly + **plex** woven, tangled

SIMILAR puzzle, confuse, baffle, bewilder
OPPOSITE clarify, enlighten

baffle **BAF**-ul *verb*



MEANING to be too hard for someone to understand or solve

MEMORY HOOK **BAF-FLE: the cookies FLEW out of a locked jar?.** The cookie jar is still locked, but every cookie is gone! The mystery **baffles** Dev and Lila. (The cat isn't talking.)

The locked-room mystery **baffled** *every detective in the city.*

SIMILAR puzzle, stump, perplex, confuse
OPPOSITE enlighten, clarify

bewilder bih-**WIL**-der *verb*



MEANING to confuse completely, often with too many things at once

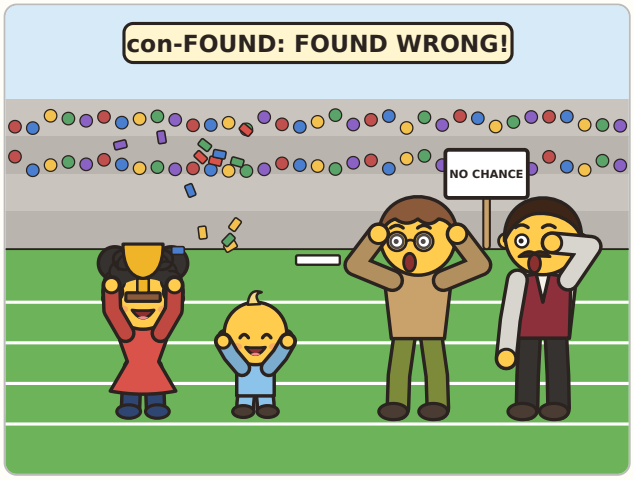
MEMORY HOOK **be-WILD-er: lost in the WILD.** Sami steps off the trail, and the jungle closes in around him: vines everywhere, paths in every direction. He is **bewildered**.

The huge airport, with its hundred gates and blinking signs, **bewildered** *Granny Mae.*

PARTS **be-** thoroughly

SIMILAR confuse, perplex, befuddle, disorient
OPPOSITE enlighten, orient

confound kun-**FOUND** *verb*



MEANING to confuse and surprise; also, to prove a prediction wrong

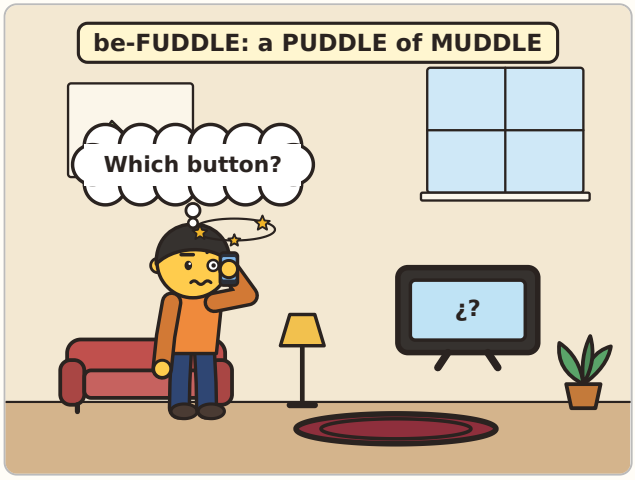
MEMORY HOOK **con-FOUND: the experts FOUND they were wrong.** Everyone said the little team couldn't win, but they did. The experts found they were wrong, and the surprise win **confounds** them.

The tiny team **confounded** *the experts by winning the whole tournament.*

PARTS **con-** together + **found** pour

SIMILAR confuse, baffle, astonish, contradict
OPPOSITE confirm, clarify

befuddle bih-**FUD**-ul *verb*



MEANING to muddle someone's thinking; to confuse

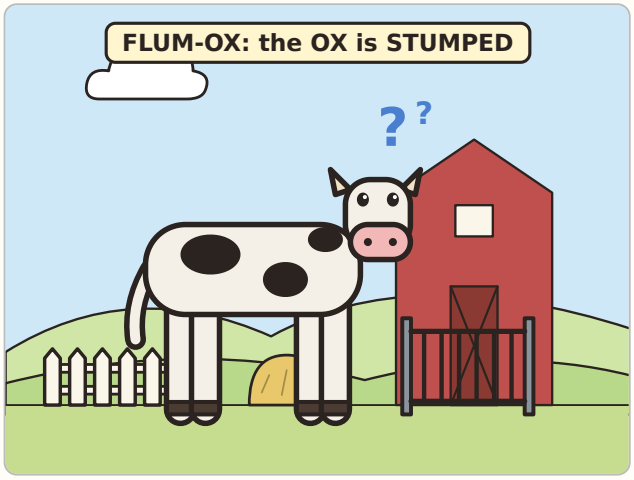
MEMORY HOOK **be-FUDDLE: a PUDDLE of MUDDLE.** Dev's new video game has a hundred rules. His thoughts turn into a puddle of muddle, and his player keeps walking into walls. The game **befuddles** him.

The long list of rules **befuddled** *the new players.*

PARTS **be-** thoroughly

SIMILAR confuse, muddle, bewilder, fog
OPPOSITE clarify, enlighten

flummox **FLUM**-uks *verb*



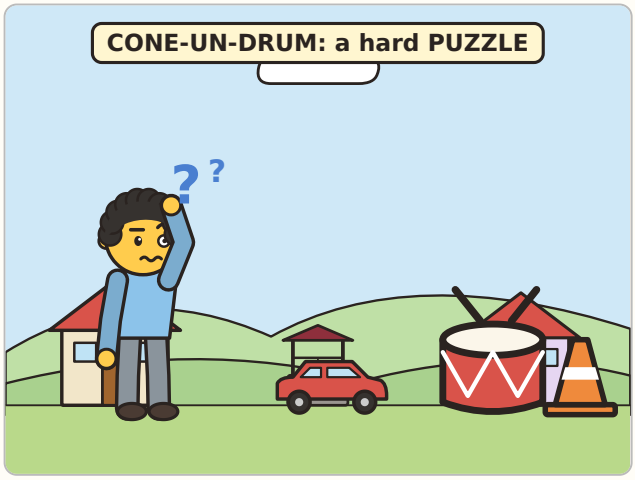
MEANING to confuse someone so completely that they don't know what to do

MEMORY HOOK **FLUM-OX: the OX is totally STUMPED.** The ox stares and stares at the gate latch, nudges it, then stares some more. He has no idea what to do: it **flummoxes** him.

The self-checkout machine **flummoxed** *Dad, who kept scanning the same banana.*

SIMILAR baffle, stump, bewilder, confuse

conundrum kuh-**NUN**-drum *noun*



MEANING a confusing and difficult problem; also, a riddle

MEMORY HOOK **CONE + DRUM: how do they fit?.** Jamal has to fit a giant drum, a traffic cone and a tuba into one tiny car. It's a real **conundrum**!

How to fit six bikes into a tiny garage was a real **conundrum**.

SIMILAR puzzle, riddle, problem, mystery
OPPOSITE solution, answer

quandary **KWON**-duh-ree *noun*



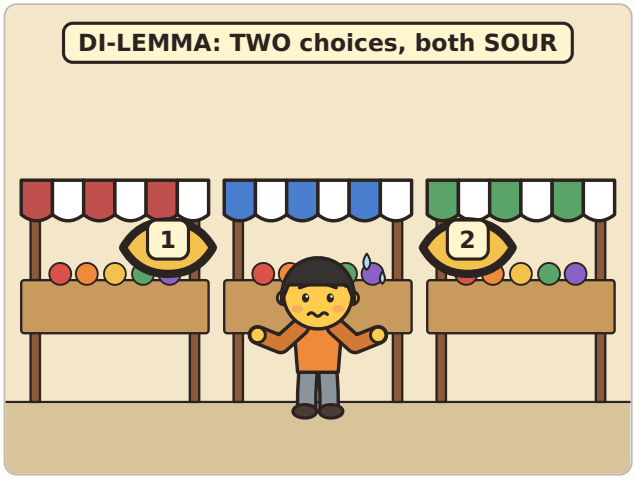
MEANING a state of not knowing what to do

MEMORY HOOK **QUAN-DARY: WANDERING, not knowing what to do.** Pip has one dollar to spend, and he wanders up and down the toy store, back and forth, unable to choose. He is in a **quandary**.

Invited to two parties on the same night, Rosa was in a **quandary**.

SIMILAR predicament, dilemma, plight, uncertainty
OPPOSITE certainty, confidence

dilemma dih-**LEM**-uh *noun*



MEANING a hard choice between two options, often both unpleasant

MEMORY HOOK **DI-LEMMA: TWO LEMONS, pick one.** Kai must eat one of two sour lemons; whichever he picks, he'll pucker. Two choices, both sour: that is a **dilemma**.

Lila faced a **dilemma***: her best friend's party and her cousin's recital were both on Saturday at noon.*

PARTS **di-** two + **lemma** premise, assumption

SIMILAR predicament, quandary, difficult choice, bind

enigma ih-**NIG**-muh *noun*



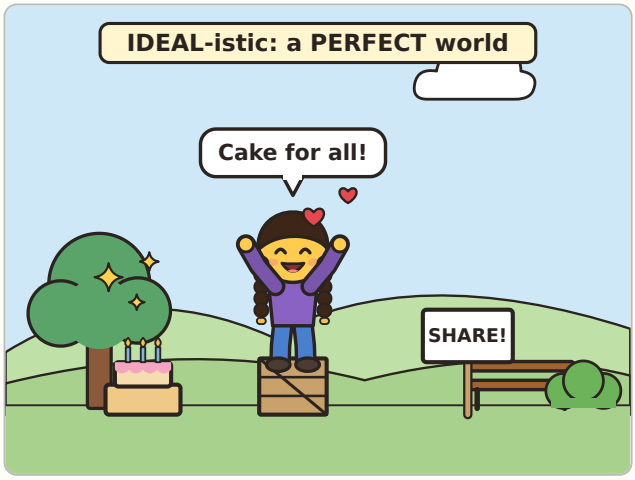
MEANING a person or thing that is mysterious and hard to understand

MEMORY HOOK **a masked MYSTERY: who is it?.** Every evening a stranger in a mask leaves a single flower on the park bench and slips away. No one knows who it is: the stranger is an **enigma**.

The new neighbor was an **enigma***: no one ever saw him come or go, yet his garden was always perfect.*

SIMILAR mystery, puzzle, riddle, conundrum

idealistic eye-dee-uh-**LIS**-tik *adjective*



MEANING guided by ideals of how things should be, rather than by what is practical

MEMORY HOOK **IDEAL-istic: aiming for the IDEAL world.** Lila wants a world where everyone shares, no one is ever lonely and every day has cake. She is **idealistic**.

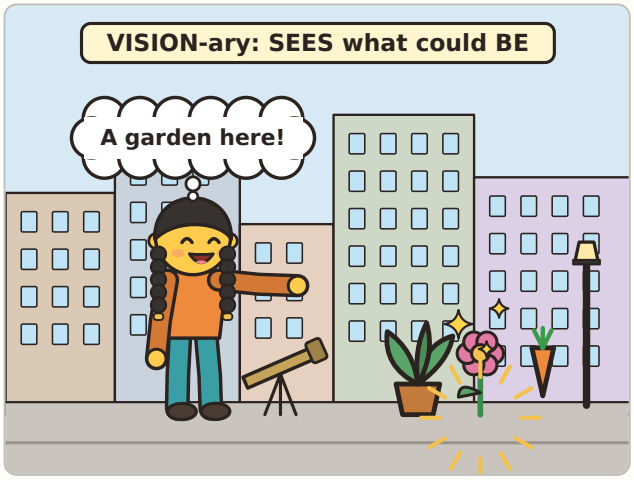
The **idealistic** *young teacher believed that every student could learn to love poetry.*

PARTS **ideal** a perfect model + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR high-minded, romantic, principled

OPPOSITE pragmatic, realistic, cynical

visionary **VIZH**-uh-nair-ee *adjective*



MEANING thinking about the future with imagination and wisdom

MEMORY HOOK **VISION-ary: SEES the future.** Tia looks at the weedy empty lot and sees what could be: rows of tomatoes and kids picking beans. She is **visionary**.

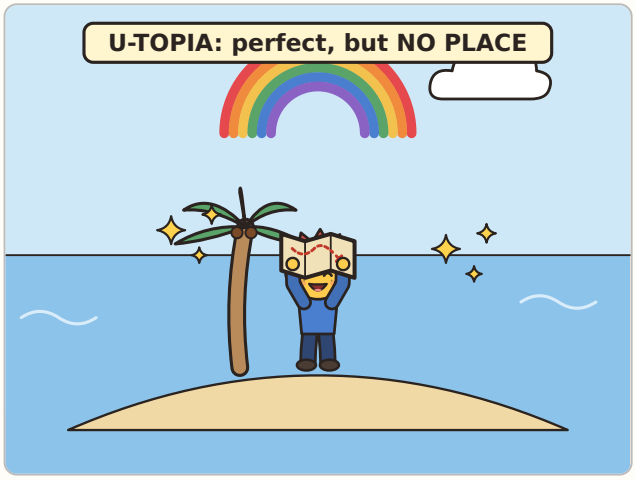
The **visionary** *inventor sketched flying machines long before anyone could build one.*

PARTS **vis** see

SIMILAR imaginative, farsighted, idealistic, inspired

OPPOSITE shortsighted, unimaginative

utopian yoo-**TOH**-pee-un *adjective*



MEANING aiming for a perfect society; too ideal to be realistic

MEMORY HOOK **YOU-TOPIA: a perfect place that is NO place.** On Pip's map of the perfect island, the rivers are lemonade and nobody ever argues. Lovely, but it's no real place: a **utopian** dream.

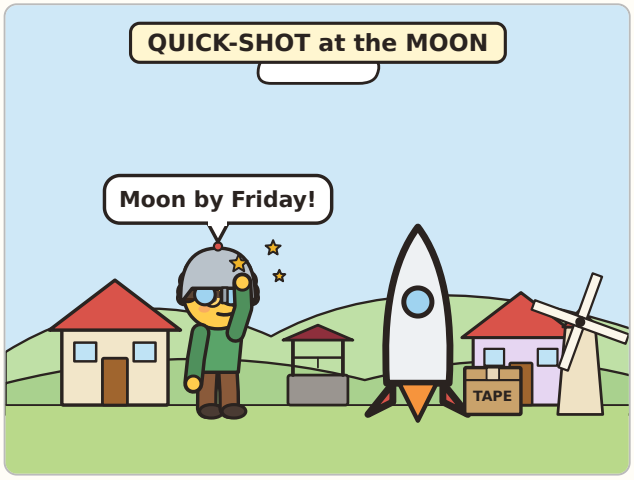
In their **utopian** *town, no door had a lock and no neighbor ever argued.*

PARTS **u-** not (from Greek ou) + **top** place

SIMILAR idealistic, visionary, perfect, unrealistic

OPPOSITE dystopian, realistic, practical

quixotic kwik-**SOT**-ik *adjective*



MEANING hopelessly idealistic and impractical, in a noble or romantic way

MEMORY HOOK **QUICK-SHOT: a brave shot at the impossible.** Sami builds a cardboard rocket to fly to the moon by Friday. It's a brave, noble shot at the impossible: his plan is **quixotic**.

His **quixotic** *plan was to clean every beach in the state by himself.*

PARTS **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR idealistic, impractical, romantic, unrealistic

OPPOSITE practical, pragmatic, realistic

whimsical **WIM**-zih-kul *adjective*



MEANING playfully odd or fanciful; following sudden fancies

MEMORY HOOK **WHIM-sical: follows every playful WHIM.** On a whim, Nell plants daisies in an old boot, hangs teacups in a tree and gives her cat a party hat. Her garden is **whimsical**.

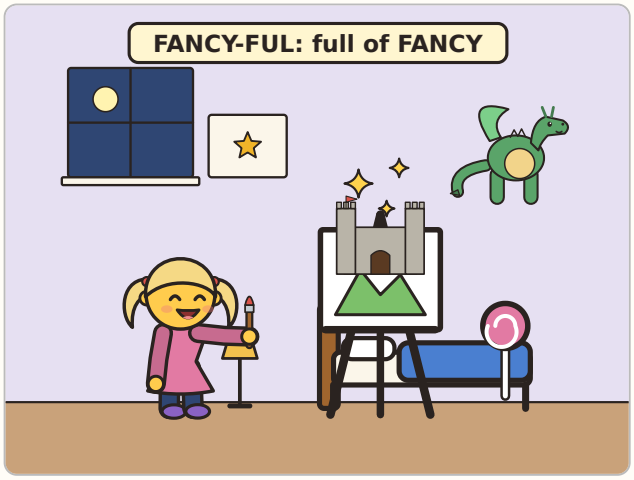
The café's **whimsical** *chairs were shaped like giant teacups.*

PARTS **-ical** having to do with, like

SIMILAR playful, quirky, fanciful, fantastical

OPPOSITE serious, sober, conventional

fanciful **FAN**-sih-ful *adjective*



MEANING imaginative but not realistic; existing only in the imagination

MEMORY HOOK **FANCY-FUL: FULL of FANCY.** Ivy paints a castle with candy towers, a lollipop bridge and a dragon who serves tea. Her picture is **fanciful**.

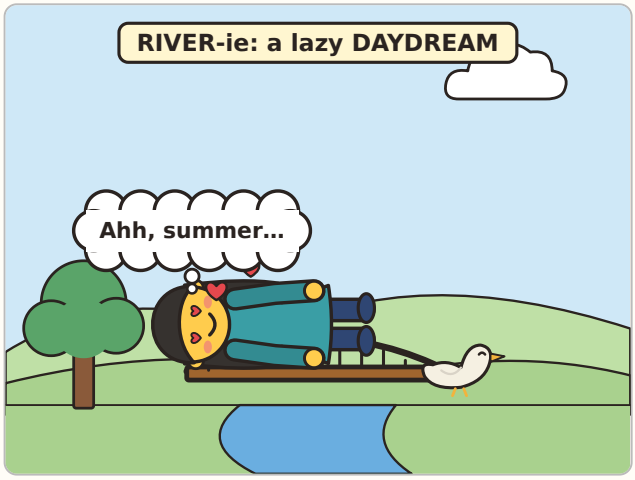
Ivy drew a **fanciful** *castle with candy towers and a moat of chocolate milk.*

PARTS **-ful** full of

SIMILAR imaginative, far-fetched, whimsical, unrealistic

OPPOSITE realistic, factual, practical

reverie **REV**-uh-ree *noun*



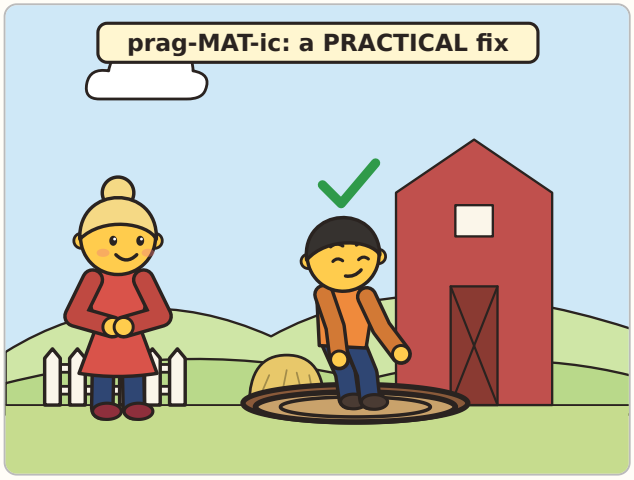
MEANING a pleasant daydream; being lost in happy thoughts

MEMORY HOOK **RIVER-ie: drifting off by the RIVER.** Lying by the lazy river, Lin watches the clouds float by and drifts into happy thoughts of summer. She is lost in a **reverie**.

The ringing phone snapped Grandpa out of his **reverie**.

SIMILAR daydream, trance, musing, dream
OPPOSITE alertness, attention

pragmatic prag-**MAT**-ik *adjective*



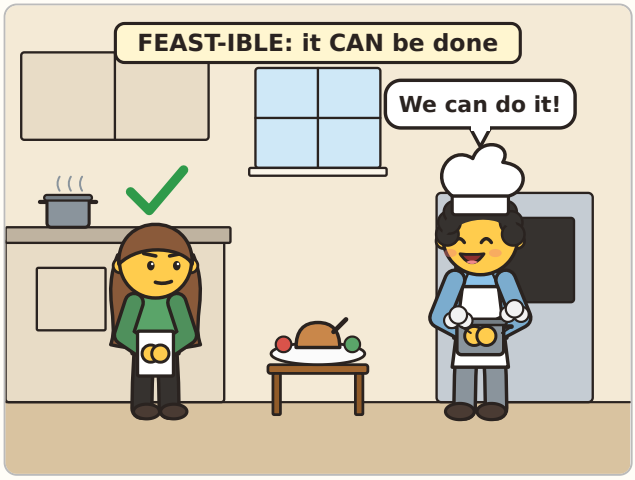
MEANING dealing with things sensibly and practically

MEMORY HOOK **prag-MAT-ic: put down a MAT and get across.** The path to the barn is all mud, so Dev doesn't wish it away; he lays down an old mat and walks right over. He is **pragmatic**.

Rather than wait years for a new bridge, the **pragmatic** *villagers built a ferry.*

PARTS **pragmat** deed, business + **-ic** having to do with
SIMILAR practical, sensible, realistic, down-to-earth
OPPOSITE idealistic, impractical, quixotic

feasible **FEE**-zuh-bul *adjective*



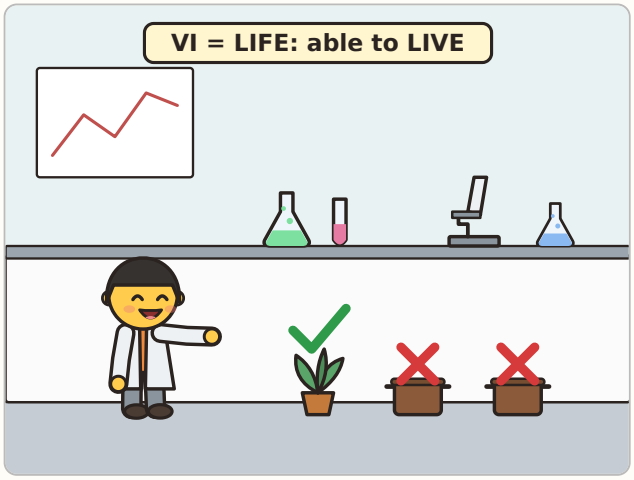
MEANING possible to do; workable

MEMORY HOOK **FEAST-ible: yes, we CAN make the feast.** Can two friends cook a feast for fifty? With three ovens, a list and a plan, yes: the feast is **feasible**.

With three more helpers, finishing the mural by Friday became **feasible**.

PARTS **feas** do, make + **-ible** able to be
SIMILAR doable, possible, workable, achievable
OPPOSITE impossible, impractical, unworkable

viable **VYE**-uh-bul *adjective*



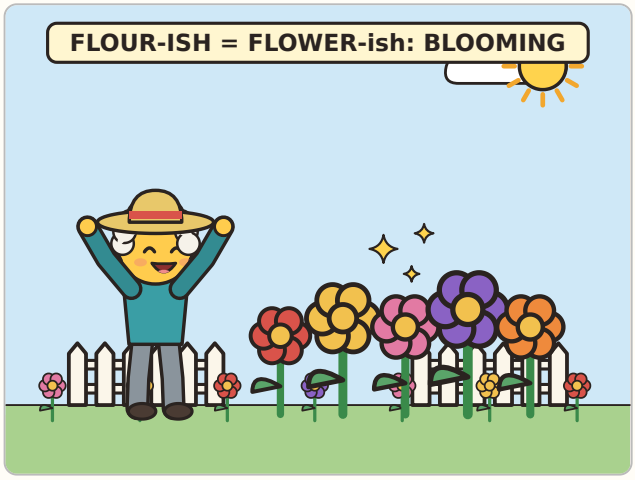
MEANING able to work, live or succeed

MEMORY HOOK **VI = LIFE: able to LIVE and grow.** Kai plants three seeds in three pots. Two stay bare, but one sprouts and keeps growing: that seed was **viable**.

Only one of the three seeds was **viable**, *and it sprouted within a week.*

PARTS **vi** life + **-able** able to
SIMILAR workable, practicable, feasible, sustainable
OPPOSITE unworkable, doomed, impractical

flourish **FLUR**-ish *verb*



MEANING to grow well and healthily; to do very well

MEMORY HOOK **FLOUR-ish = FLOWER-ish: blooming all over.** Nana Lou's garden bursts with flowers of every color, taller and brighter every week. It **flourishes**.

Tomatoes **flourish** *in Nana Lou's sunny backyard.*

PARTS **flour** flower (from Latin flos)

SIMILAR thrive, prosper, bloom, boom
OPPOSITE wither, decline, languish

thrive **THRIVE** *verb*



MEANING to grow strong and healthy; to do well

MEMORY HOOK **THRIVE rhymes with HIVE: a busy, growing HIVE.** Every week there are more bees and more honey; the busy hive grows and grows. It **thrives**!

The rescued puppy **thrived** *on long walks and lots of attention.*

SIMILAR flourish, prosper, grow, boom
OPPOSITE wither, fail, decline

burgeon **BUR**-jun *verb*



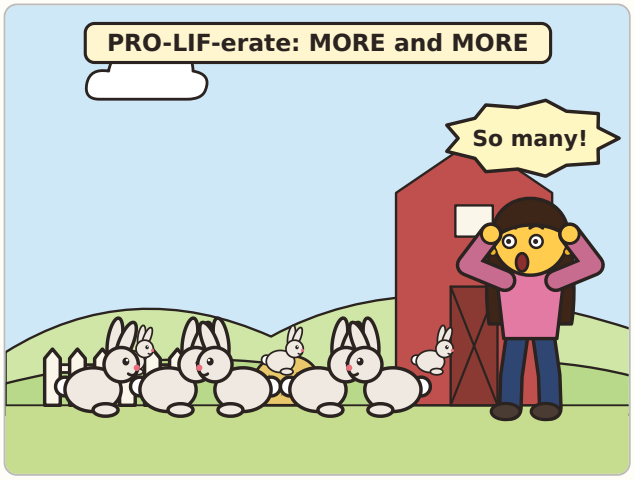
MEANING to grow or expand quickly

MEMORY HOOK **BURGER-on: the BURGER stack grows FAST.** At the cookout, Sven's stack of burgers grows fast: one, then three, then six, taller than his nose! The stack **burgeons**.

Weeds **burgeoned** *in the empty lot after a week of rain.*

SIMILAR grow rapidly, boom, mushroom, expand
OPPOSITE shrink, dwindle, decline

proliferate pruh-**LIF**-uh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to increase quickly in number; to multiply

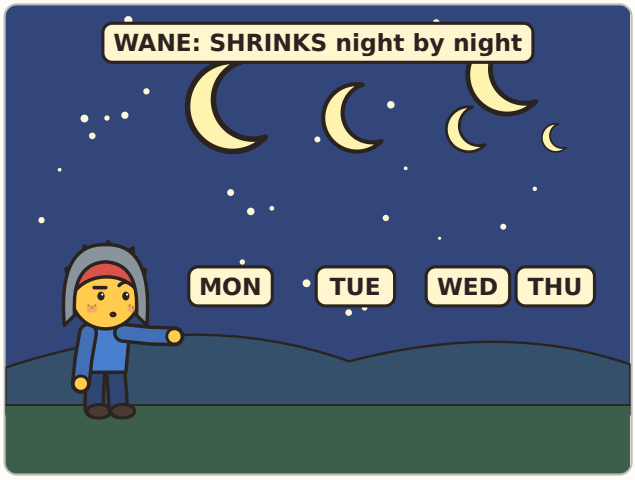
MEMORY HOOK **PROLIFIC bunnies: LIFE makes more LIFE.** Two rabbits in spring, twenty by summer, two hundred by fall! The rabbits **proliferate**.

Rabbits **proliferated** *in the meadow until there were hundreds.*

PARTS **proli** offspring + **fer** bear, carry + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR multiply, spread, mushroom, increase
OPPOSITE decrease, dwindle, diminish

wane WAYN *verb*



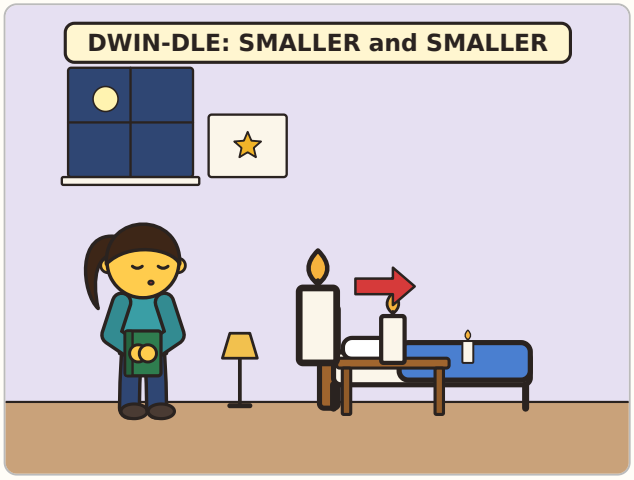
MEANING to grow smaller or weaker little by little

MEMORY HOOK **WANE: a little LESS each night.** Each night Pip looks out his window, and each night the moon is a little thinner. The moon **wanes**.

Interest in the new game **waned** *after a few weeks.*

SIMILAR decrease, fade, lessen, weaken
OPPOSITE wax, grow, increase

dwindle DWIN-dul *verb*



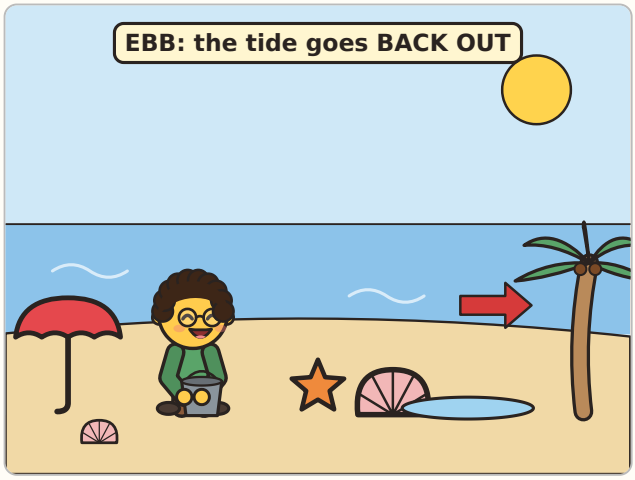
MEANING to grow smaller little by little until little is left

MEMORY HOOK **DWIN-DLE like a CAN-DLE: it shrinks down.** Maya reads late into the night, and her candle shrinks from tall to short to a tiny stub. It **dwindles**.

Our supply of marshmallows **dwindled** *as the campfire night went on.*

SIMILAR shrink, decrease, diminish, lessen
OPPOSITE grow, increase, swell

ebb EB *verb*



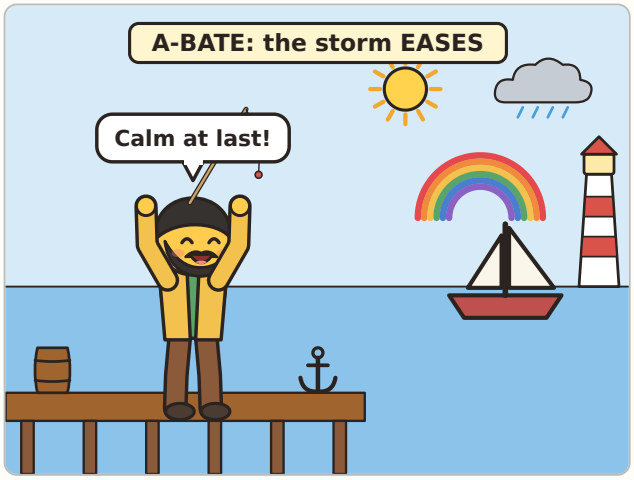
MEANING to flow back out, like the tide; to fade away

MEMORY HOOK **EBB: the sea slides BACK, back, back.** The water slides back out to sea, and Sami finds starfish and shells left behind on the wet sand. The tide **ebbs**.

As the tide **ebbed**, *the children hunted for crabs in the pools left behind.*

SIMILAR recede, flow back, fade, lessen
OPPOSITE flow, rise, surge

abate uh-BAYT *verb*



MEANING to become less strong or intense

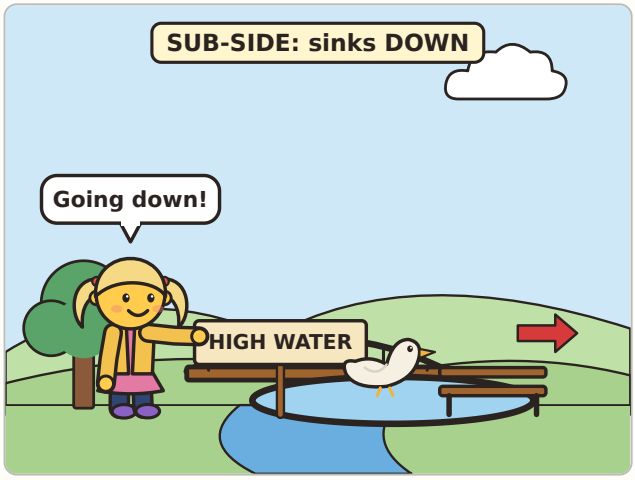
MEMORY HOOK **A-BAIT: the storm calms, so out comes the BAIT.** The wind drops, the rain slows, and the sun peeks out. The storm **abates**, so Omar grabs his bait and heads back to fishing.

We waited inside the barn until the storm **abated**.

PARTS **bat** beat

SIMILAR subside, lessen, ease, die down
OPPOSITE intensify, increase, worsen

subside sub-**SIDE** *verb*



MEANING to die down; also, to sink to a lower level

MEMORY HOOK **SUB-SIDE: the water sinks DOWN.** After the flood, the water in the park sinks down, lower and lower, until the bench appears again. The flood **subsides**.

After the river flooded, it took a week for the water to **subside**.

PARTS **sub-** down, under + **sid** settle, sit

SIMILAR abate, die down, ease, lessen
OPPOSITE rise, increase, intensify

atrophy **AT**-ruh-fee *verb*



MEANING to waste away or weaken from lack of use

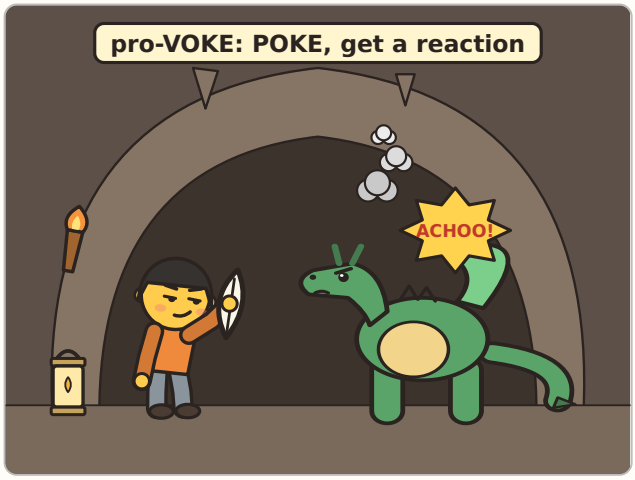
MEMORY HOOK **A TROPHY gathering dust.** Grandpa Gus won a tennis trophy long ago, but he hasn't touched a racket since. The trophy gathers dust, and his tennis skills **atrophy**.

After six weeks in a cast, the muscles in Dev's arm had begun to **atrophy**.

PARTS **a-** without + **troph** nourishment

SIMILAR waste away, wither, weaken, shrink
OPPOSITE strengthen, grow, develop

provoke pruh-**VOHK** *verb*



MEANING to stir up a reaction, especially anger

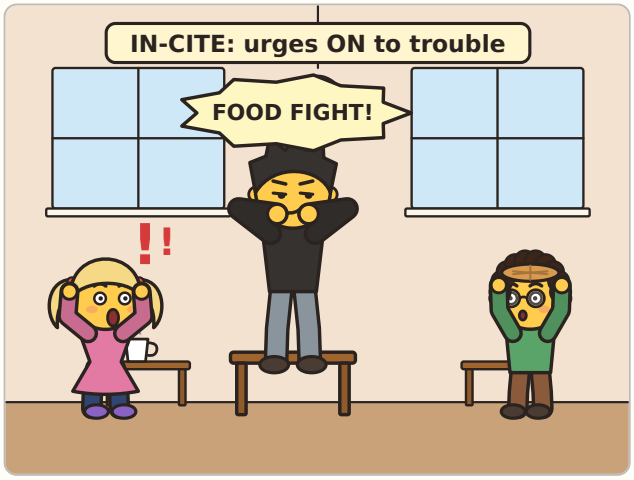
MEMORY HOOK **pro-VOKE: POKE it and get a reaction.** Kai tickles the sleeping dragon's nose with a feather, poke, poke, and he **provokes** a giant, smoky sneeze!

Poking a sleeping cat is a sure way to **provoke** *a hiss.*

PARTS **pro-** forth + **voc** call

SIMILAR prompt, spark, trigger, anger
OPPOSITE calm, soothe, appease

incite in-**SITE** *verb*



MEANING to urge people on, especially to trouble or violence

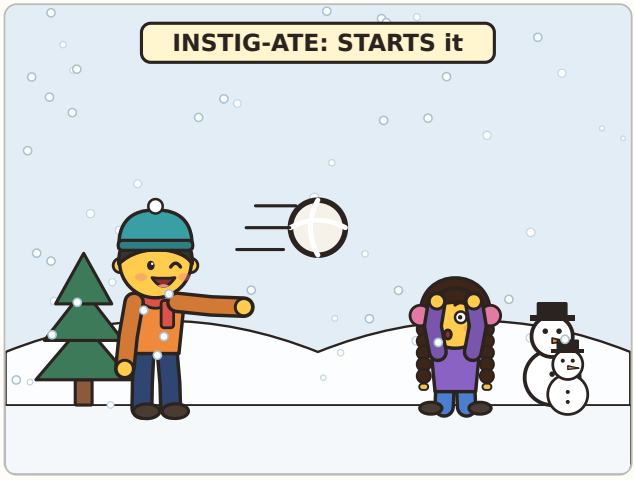
MEMORY HOOK **IN-CITE: urges everyone IN SIGHT on.** Rex jumps onto a lunch table and yells "Food fight!", urging everyone in sight to start throwing. He **incites** trouble.

The prankster tried to **incite** *a food fight in the cafeteria.*

PARTS **in-** on + **cite** set in motion

SIMILAR urge on, stir up, provoke, whip up
OPPOSITE calm, discourage, deter

instigate IN-stih-gayt *verb*



MEANING to start something, especially trouble; to bring it about

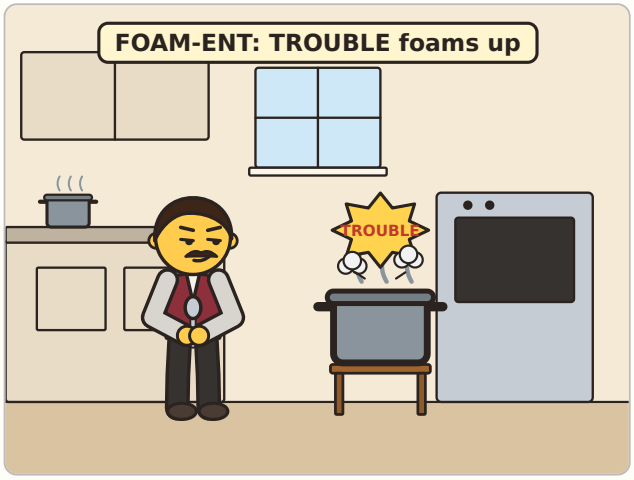
MEMORY HOOK **IN-STIG-ATE: in an INSTANT, it STARTS.** Dev throws the very first snowball, and in an instant everyone is throwing. He **instigates** the snowball fight.

*Dev **instigated** the snowball fight by tossing the first one at his sister.*

PARTS **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR start, initiate, begin, set off
OPPOSITE stop, end, halt

foment foh-MENT *verb*



MEANING to stir up trouble or unrest

MEMORY HOOK **FOAM-ENT: stir till trouble FOAMS over.** Victor stirs his pot of gossip faster and faster, adding a pinch of rumor here and a dash of grumbling there, until it foams over. He **foments** trouble.

*Rumors on the school bus **fomented** a feud between the two grades.*

SIMILAR stir up, whip up, incite, provoke
OPPOSITE quell, calm, suppress

goad GOHD *verb*



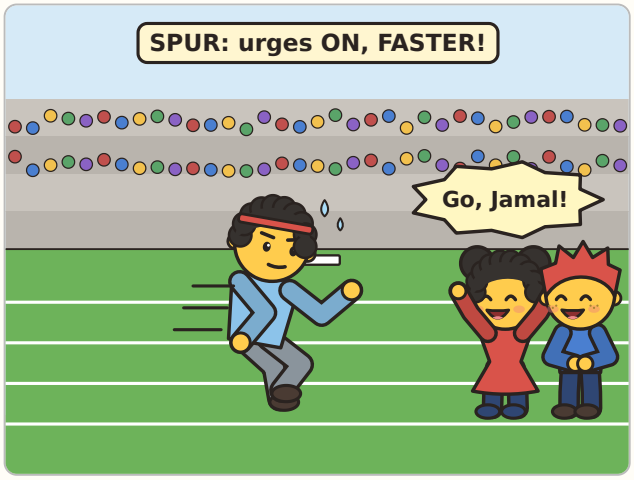
MEANING to push or provoke someone into doing something

MEMORY HOOK **GOAD: "GO! GO! GO!" until you do it.** Rosa's friends chant "Go! Go! Go!" until she finally steps up to the microphone to sing. They **goad** her into it.

*His teammates **goaded** Kai into singing at the talent show.*

SIMILAR prod, spur, push, needle
OPPOSITE discourage, deter, dissuade

spur SPUR *verb*



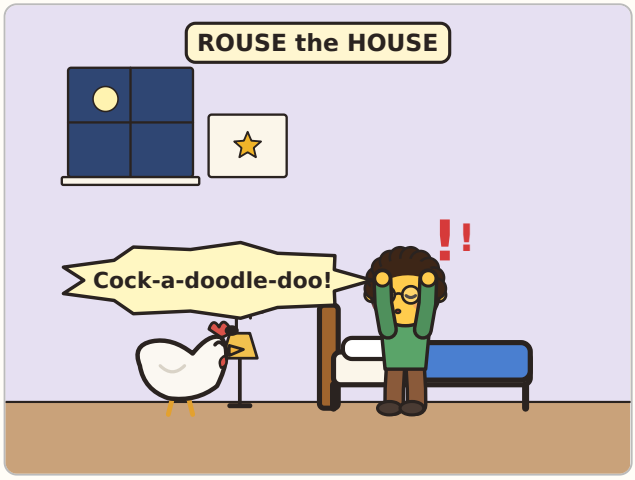
MEANING to urge on; to push someone to act faster or harder

MEMORY HOOK **SPUR: cheers that PUSH you FASTER.** Jamal is tired in the last lap, but the crowd's cheers push him to run faster and faster. The cheers **spur** him on.

*The cheering crowd **spurred** the tired runners toward the finish line.*

SIMILAR urge, encourage, motivate, prompt
OPPOSITE discourage, hinder, deter

rouse ROWZ *verb*



MEANING to wake someone up; to stir up feelings or action

MEMORY HOOK **ROUSE the HOUSE: the rooster wakes everyone.** Cock-a-doodle-doo! The rooster crows right outside the window, and the whole house wakes up. He **rouses** everyone.

The smell of pancakes **roused** *Sami from a deep sleep.*

SIMILAR wake, awaken, stir, spur
OPPOSITE lull, calm, pacify

stoke STOHK *verb*



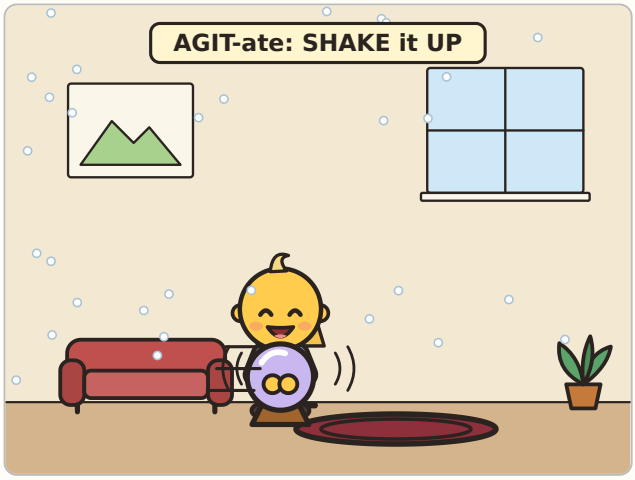
MEANING to add fuel to a fire; to stir up strong feelings

MEMORY HOOK **STOKE it and the flames SOAR.** Marcus adds another log to the campfire, and the flames leap high. He **stokes** the fire.

Grandpa **stoked** *the campfire until the flames leaped high.*

SIMILAR fuel, feed, fan, stir up
OPPOSITE dampen, smother, calm

agitate AJ-ih-tayt *verb*



MEANING to stir up or shake; to make someone anxious or upset

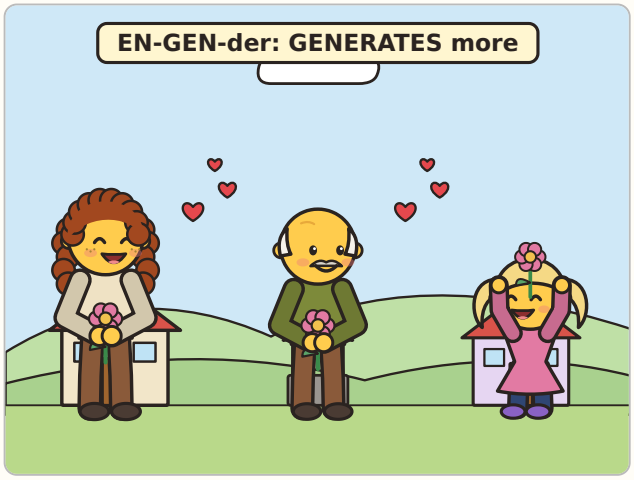
MEMORY HOOK **AGIT-ATE: SHAKE it all UP.** Theo shakes the snow globe hard, and the snow swirls wildly inside. He **agitates** it.

The washing machine **agitates** *the clothes to shake the dirt loose.*

PARTS **ag** drive, do + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR stir, shake, upset, disturb
OPPOSITE calm, soothe, settle

engender en-JEN-der *verb*



MEANING to cause something to exist; to give rise to

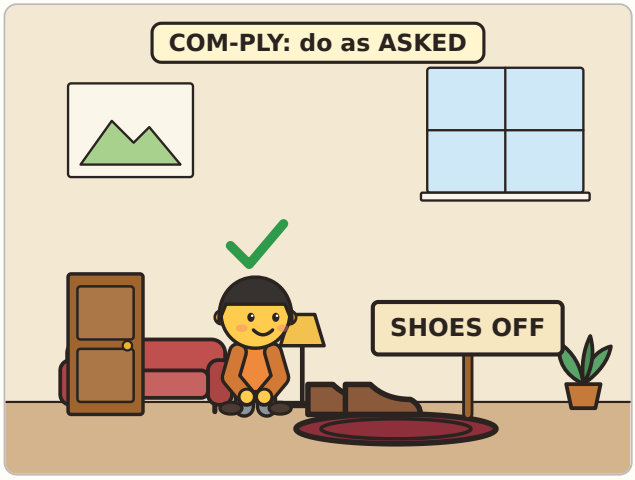
MEMORY HOOK **EN-GEN-der: GENerates more.** Nell hands a neighbor a flower; he passes one to Ivy; she passes one to her grandpa. One kind act **engenders** many more.

Her fair rules **engendered** *trust among the players.*

PARTS **en-** in + **gen** birth, produce

SIMILAR cause, produce, create, generate
OPPOSITE prevent, stifle

comply kum-**PLY** *verb*



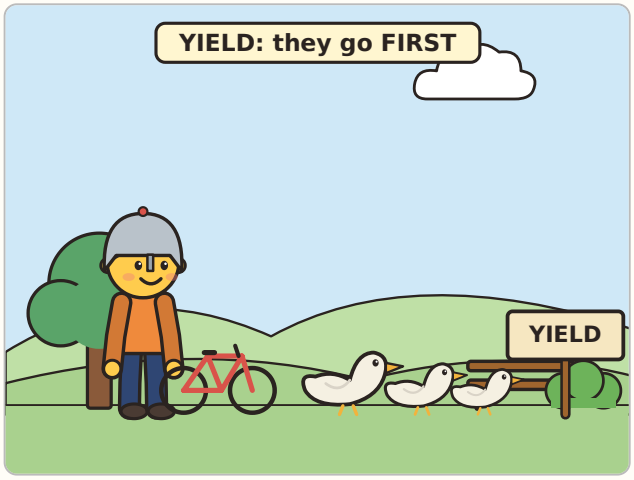
MEANING to do what is asked, ordered or required

MEMORY HOOK **COM-PLY: COME and PLAY by the rules.** The sign on the door says SHOES OFF, so Kai sits down and takes off his sneakers before he comes in to play. He **complies**.

All visitors must **comply** *with the museum's no-flash rule.*

SIMILAR obey, follow, conform, go along
OPPOSITE defy, disobey, resist

yield **YEELD** *verb*



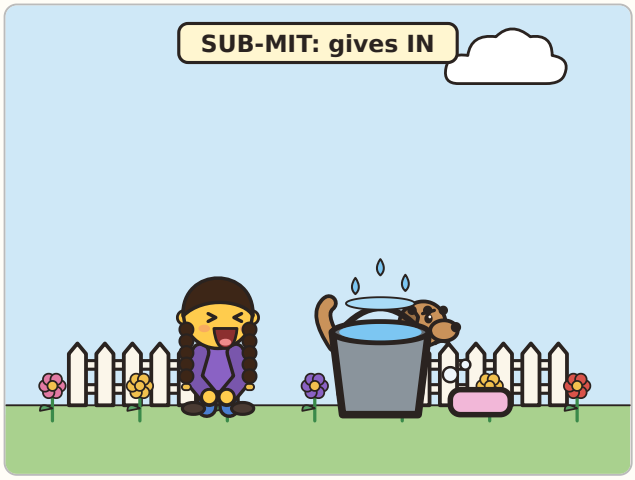
MEANING to give way to pressure, to another person or to traffic

MEMORY HOOK **YIELD: let them go FIRST.** Dev stops his bike and waits while a line of ducks waddles across the path. He **yields** to the ducks.

Drivers must **yield** *to people in the crosswalk.*

SIMILAR give way, give in, surrender, submit
OPPOSITE resist, withstand, hold out

submit sub-**MIT** *verb*



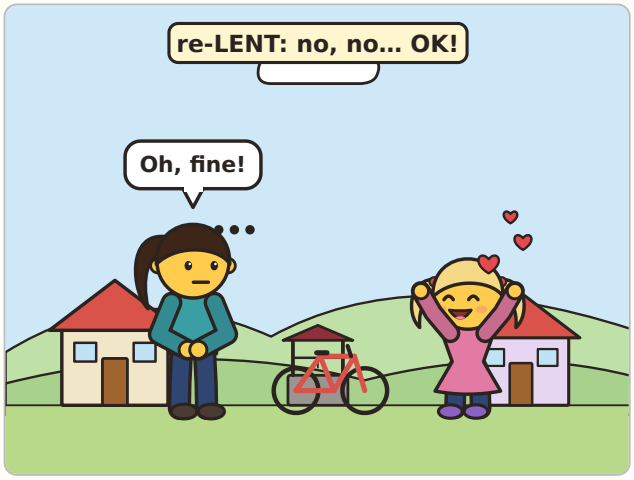
MEANING to give in to someone's authority or control

MEMORY HOOK **SUB-MIT: gives in and goes UNDER the suds.** After a long struggle, the muddy puppy gives up and sits still in the tub of suds. He **submits** to his bath.

The players **submitted** *to the referee's decision without another word.*

PARTS **sub-** under + **mit** send, let go
SIMILAR yield, give in, surrender, comply
OPPOSITE resist, defy, fight

relent rih-**LENT** *verb*



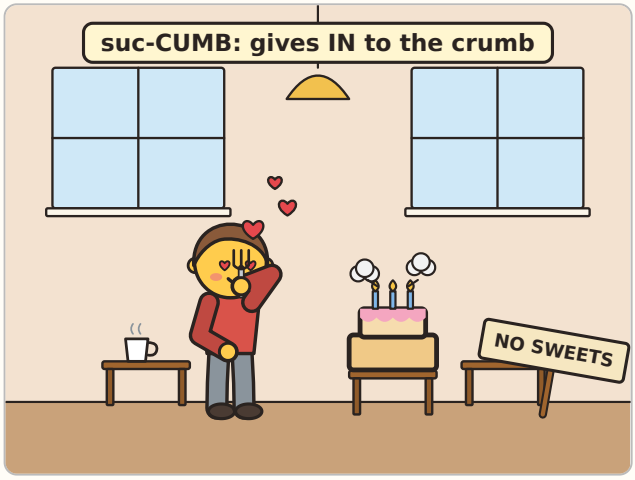
MEANING to become less strict or severe; to give in after refusing

MEMORY HOOK **re-LENT: she finally LENT it.** Ivy begs to borrow her big sister's bike. Maya says no, no and no again, then sighs and lends it after all. Maya **relents**.

Mom finally **relented** *and let us stay up to watch the meteor shower.*

PARTS **re-** back + **lent** soft, bending
SIMILAR give in, soften, yield, back down
OPPOSITE persist, harden, stand firm

succumb suh-**KUM** *verb*



MEANING to give in to pressure, temptation or force

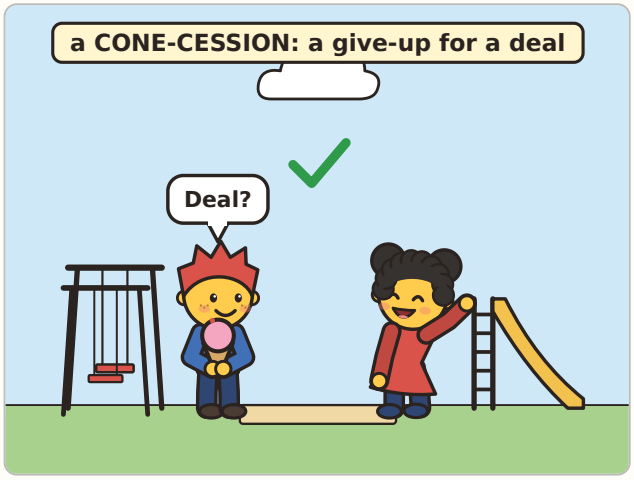
MEMORY HOOK **suc-CRUMB: gives in to the CRUMB.** Jonah promised himself no sweets, but the chocolate cake smells so good. He **succumbs** and takes a big bite.

After an hour of staring at the cake, Jonah **succumbed** *and ate a slice.*

PARTS **suc-** under (a form of sub-) + **cumb** lie down

SIMILAR give in, yield, surrender, submit
OPPOSITE resist, withstand, overcome

concession kun-**SESH**-un *noun*



MEANING something given up or allowed in order to reach an agreement

MEMORY HOOK **a CONE-cession: give a CONE to make a deal.** Pip and Zoe both want the swing. Pip hands Zoe his ice cream cone, and she lets him swing first. The cone is his **concession**.

As a **concession**, *the coach let the team choose the music for practice.*

PARTS **con-** thoroughly + **cess** yield, go + **-ion** the act of

SIMILAR compromise, allowance, accommodation, grant
OPPOSITE demand

acquiesce ak-wee-**ES** *verb*



MEANING to accept or agree quietly, without protest, often unwillingly

MEMORY HOOK **ac-QUIET-esce: goes along QUIETLY.** The family votes for soup instead of pizza. Rosa sighs, says nothing and quietly sets out the bowls: she **acquiesces**.

Too tired to argue, Grandpa **acquiesced** *to watching the cartoon movie one more time.*

PARTS **ac-** to (a form of ad-) + **quies** rest, be quiet

SIMILAR accept, consent, go along, give in
OPPOSITE resist, protest, object

capitulate kuh-**PICH**-uh-layt *verb*



MEANING to surrender or give in completely

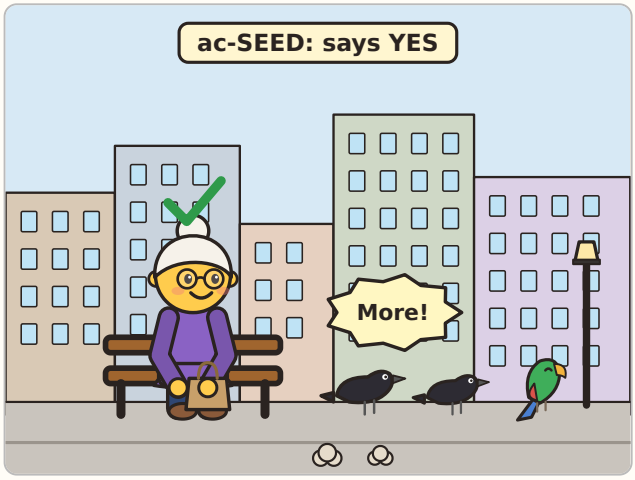
MEMORY HOOK **CAP-itulate: off comes the CAP, up goes the white flag.** King Gus takes off his crown, raises both hands and waves a white flag from the castle: “We give up!” He **capitulates**.

After a long siege, the castle finally **capitulated**.

PARTS **capit** head, heading + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR surrender, give up, yield, give in
OPPOSITE resist, fight on, hold out

accede ak-**SEED** *verb*



MEANING to agree to a request or demand

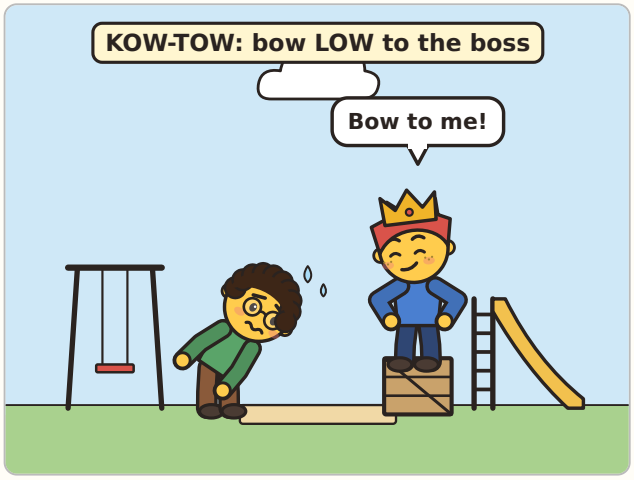
MEMORY HOOK **ac-SEED: says YES to more SEEDS.** The birds line up and squawk for more seeds, and Granny Mae says yes, tossing out another handful. She **accedes** to their demand.

The principal **acceded** *to the students' request for a longer lunch.*

PARTS **ac-** to (a form of ad-) + **cede** go, yield

SIMILAR agree, consent, go along, give in
OPPOSITE refuse, reject, deny

kowtow **KOW**-tow *verb*



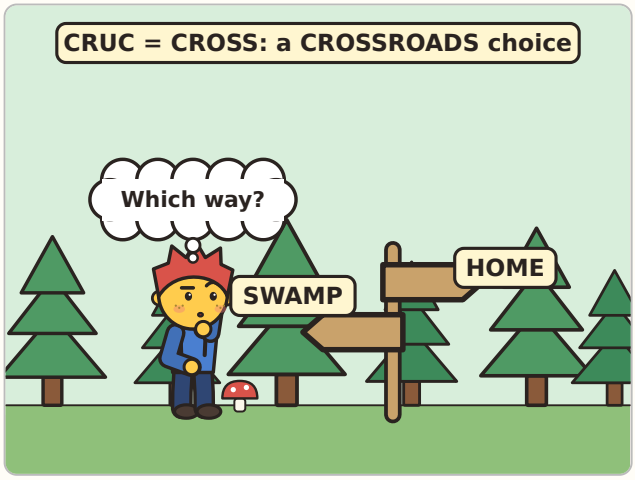
MEANING to act too humbly and obediently in order to please someone powerful

MEMORY HOOK **KOW-TOW: bow down to your TOES.** Whatever bossy Pip in the paper crown says, Sami bows down to his toes: "Yes, boss! Anything, boss!" Sami **kowtows**.

The new player refused to **kowtow** *to the bossy team captain.*

SIMILAR grovel, bow and scrape, fawn, toady
OPPOSITE defy, stand up to, resist

crucial **KROO**-shul *adjective*



MEANING extremely important; deciding how things turn out

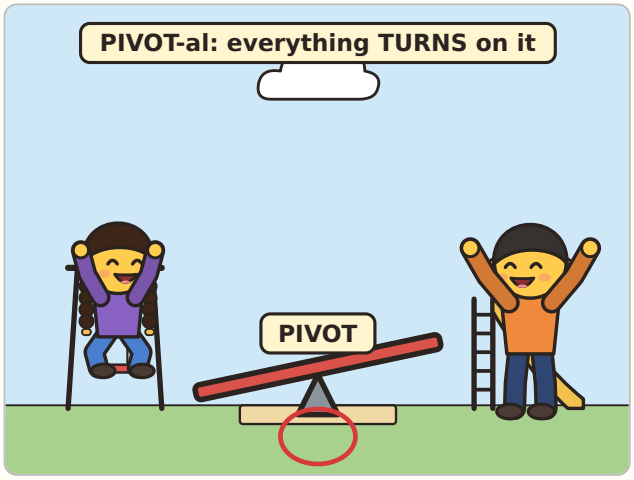
MEMORY HOOK **CRUC = CROSS: the CROSSROADS choice.** At the crossroads, one sign points home and the other points to the swamp. Choosing the right road is **crucial**!

Getting enough sleep is **crucial** *the night before a big test.*

PARTS **cruc** cross

SIMILAR vital, critical, essential, key
OPPOSITE unimportant, trivial, minor

pivotal **PIV**-uh-tul *adjective*



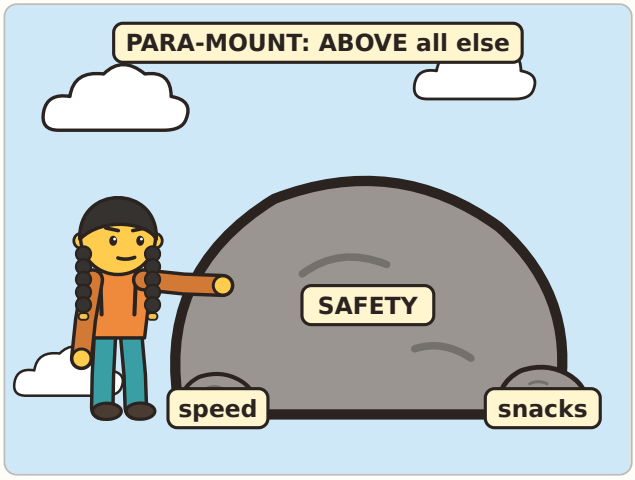
MEANING of central importance; the point on which everything turns

MEMORY HOOK **PIVOT-al: everything TURNS on it.** The whole seesaw tips up and down on one little pin in the middle. Without it, nothing moves: the pin is **pivotal**.

Winning the coin toss turned out to be **pivotal** *in the close game.*

SIMILAR central, key, critical, crucial
OPPOSITE minor, peripheral, unimportant

paramount **PAIR**-uh-mount *adjective*



MEANING more important than anything else

MEMORY HOOK **PARA-MOUNT: high above the rest, like a MOUNTain.** On Tia's hiking list, "Stay safe" towers above everything else, like a mountain over little hills. Safety is **paramount**.

On the field trip, safety was **paramount**.

SIMILAR supreme, foremost, chief, key
OPPOSITE minor, secondary, lesser

preeminent pree-**EM**-ih-nunt *adjective*



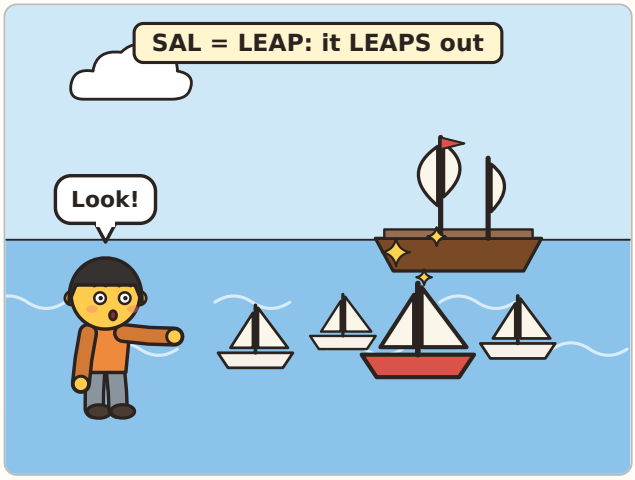
MEANING better or more famous than all others in a field

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-EMINENT: stands out above even the famous.** There are many famous bakers in town, but Nell stands out above them all; her line stretches around the block. She is **preeminent**.

She is the **preeminent** *expert on spiders in the whole country.*

PARTS **pre-** before, above + **e-** out + **min** jut, stand out
SIMILAR leading, foremost, top, outstanding
OPPOSITE minor, obscure, inferior

salient **SAY**-lee-unt *adjective*



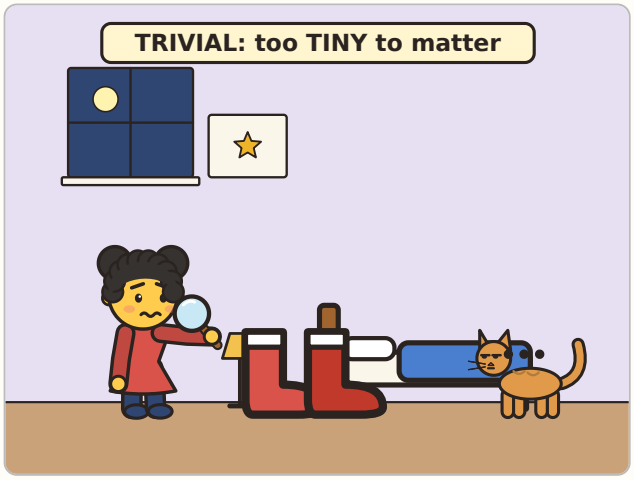
MEANING most noticeable or important; standing out

MEMORY HOOK **SAIL-ient: the one red SAILboat that LEAPS out.** Among all the white sailboats on the bay, one is bright red. It leaps out at you: the red boat is the **salient** sight.

The **salient** *feature of the old house was its bright red door.*

PARTS **sal** leap
SIMILAR noticeable, prominent, striking, key
OPPOSITE minor, inconspicuous, unimportant

trivial **TRIV**-ee-ul *adjective*



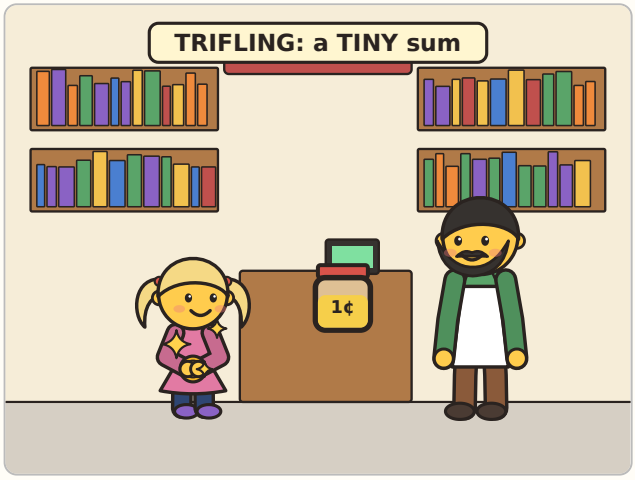
MEANING of little importance or value

MEMORY HOOK **TRIVIA-l: a tiny fact that hardly matters.** Zoe frets that her left sock is one shade darker than her right. It's a **trivial** difference; no one will ever notice.

Don't worry about such a **trivial** *mistake; it was only one comma.*

PARTS **tri-** three + **via** road
SIMILAR unimportant, minor, petty, insignificant
OPPOSITE important, significant, crucial

trifling TRY-fling *adjective*



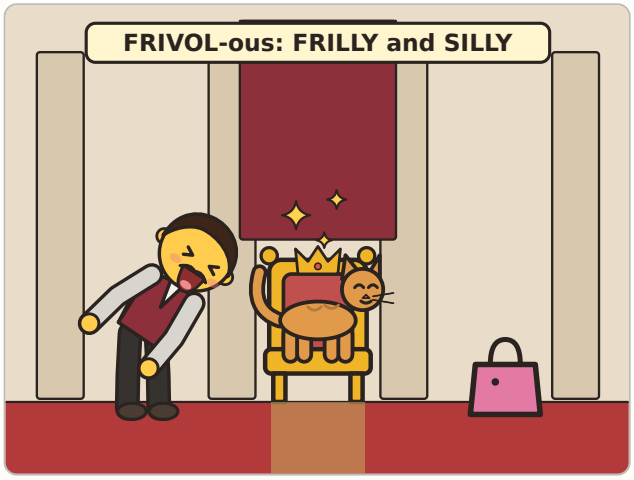
MEANING small and unimportant

MEMORY HOOK **TRIFLE: a TINY little thing.** The ring toss costs one penny, and Ivy flips it into the jar without a second thought: a **trifling** sum.

The repair cost a **trifling** *sum: just two dollars for a new screw.*

SIMILAR trivial, minor, petty, negligible
OPPOSITE important, serious, significant

frivolous FRIV-uh-lus *adjective*



MEANING not serious; silly or not worth taking seriously

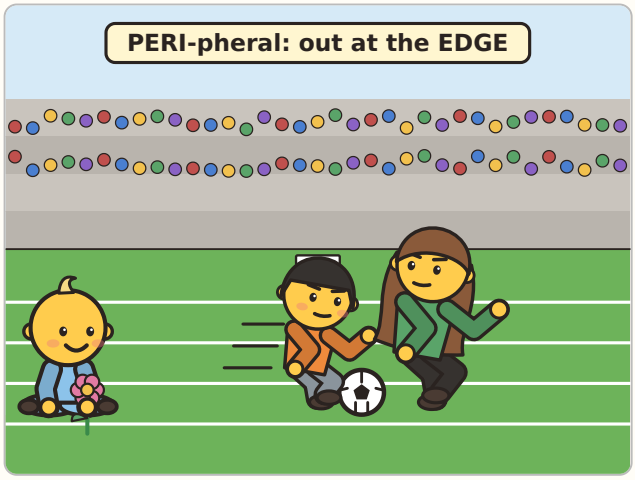
MEMORY HOOK **FRIVOL-ous: FRILLY and SILLY.** Victor buys his cat a tiny jeweled crown and a velvet throne. Frilly, silly and not needed at all: the purchases are **frivolous**.

Grandpa thought buying a hat for the dog was **frivolous**, *but the dog loved it.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR silly, trivial, foolish, flippant
OPPOSITE serious, important, sensible

peripheral puh-RIF-er-ul *adjective*



MEANING at the edge; of minor importance

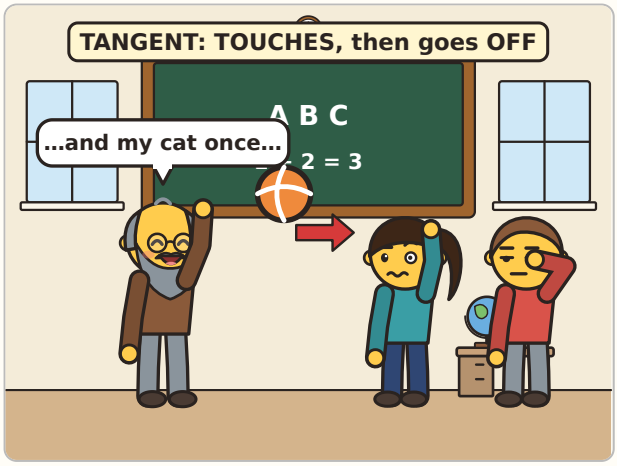
MEMORY HOOK **PERI-pheral: out AROUND the edge.** The soccer game rages in the middle of the field, but little Theo is out at the edge picking daisies. His part in the game is **peripheral**.

The new bus line will reach even the **peripheral** *neighborhoods at the edge of town.*

PARTS **peri-** around + **pher** carry

SIMILAR outer, minor, secondary, marginal
OPPOSITE central, main, core

tangential tan-JEN-shul *adjective*



MEANING only slightly connected to the main point; going off the topic

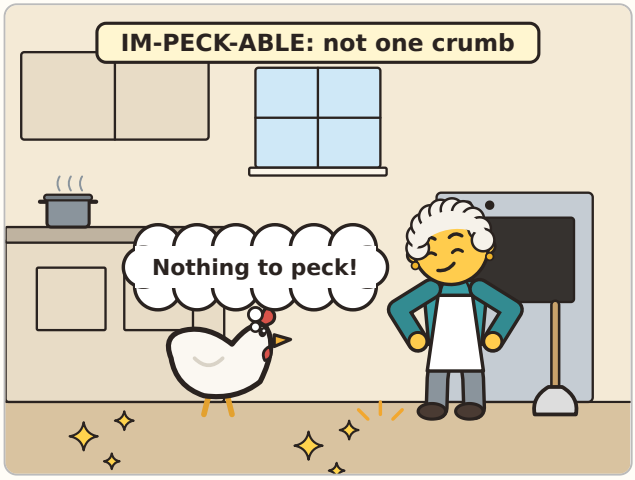
MEMORY HOOK **TANGENT: touches the topic, then shoots OFF.** Professor Edwin starts the history lesson, then shoots off: "…which reminds me of my cat, who once…" His story is **tangential**.

The speaker's **tangential** *story about his cat had nothing to do with the budget.*

PARTS **tang** touch

SIMILAR digressive, off-topic, irrelevant, peripheral
OPPOSITE relevant, central, pertinent

impeccable im-**PEK**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING perfect; without a single flaw or fault

MEMORY HOOK **not a crumb to PECK: im-PECK-able.** The hen hunts all over Nana Lou's kitchen floor and finds not one crumb to peck: the floor is **impeccable**.

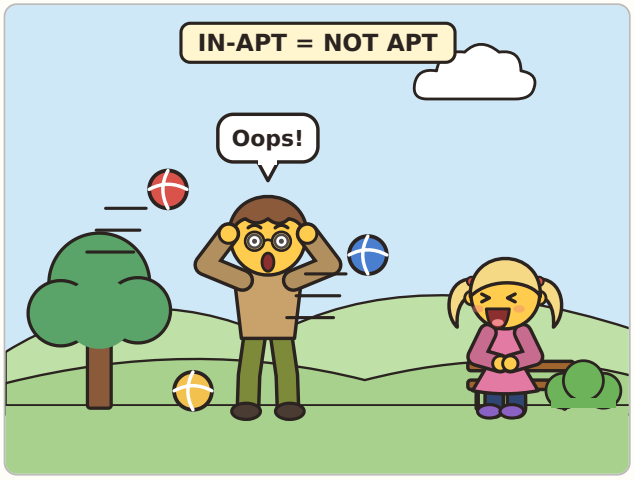
Her **impeccable** *handwriting made the party invitations look printed.*

PARTS **im-** not + **pecc** sin, do wrong + **-able** able to

SIMILAR flawless, perfect, faultless, spotless

OPPOSITE flawed, faulty, sloppy

inept ih-**NEPT** *adjective*



MEANING clumsy; lacking the skill to do something well

MEMORY HOOK **IN-APT: NOT APT at all.** Felix is not apt at juggling: every ball he tosses ends up on the grass. He is **inept**.

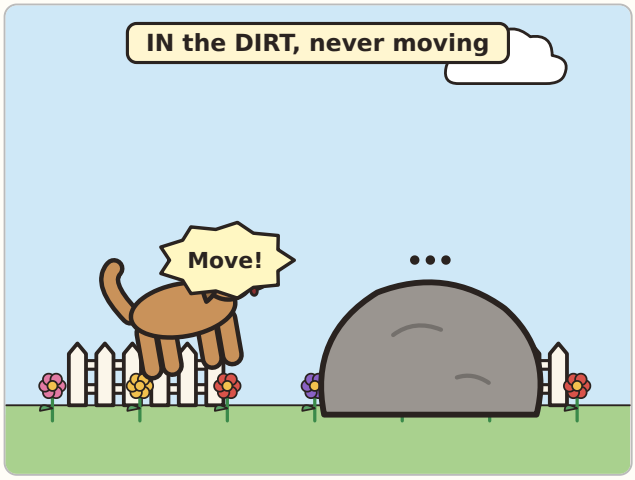
The **inept** *referee kept losing track of the score.*

PARTS **in-** not + **ept (apt)** fit, suited

SIMILAR clumsy, unskilled, incompetent, bungling

OPPOSITE skillful, adept, competent

inert ih-**NURT** *adjective*



MEANING not moving or acting; without energy or force

MEMORY HOOK **IN the DIRT: in-ERT.** The puppy barks and barks at the big rock lying in the dirt, but the rock never moves: it is **inert**.

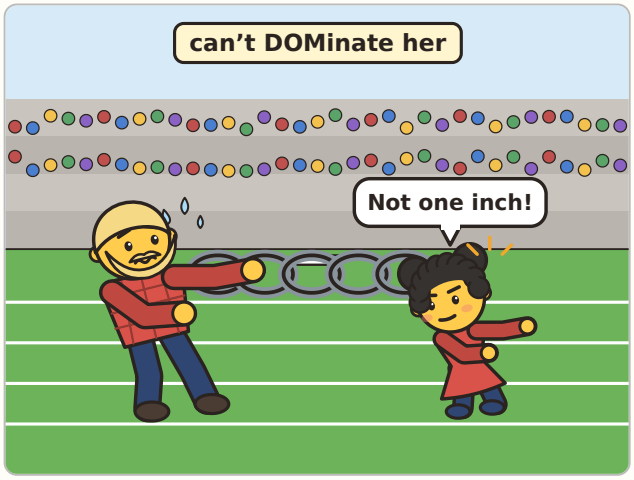
The cat lay **inert** *on the warm windowsill all afternoon.*

PARTS **in-** not, without + **ert (art)** skill

SIMILAR motionless, still, inactive, lifeless

OPPOSITE active, lively, moving

indomitable in-**DOM**-ih-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to defeat, tame or discourage

MEMORY HOOK **you can't DOMinate her: in-DOM-itable.** Big Sven pulls with all his might, but he can't dominate little Zoe in tug-of-war; she won't budge an inch. She is **indomitable**.

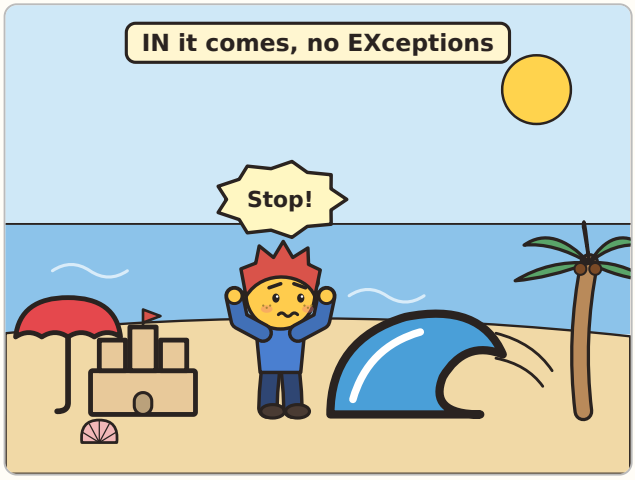
The **indomitable** *little team kept playing hard even when it was losing by twenty points.*

PARTS **in-** not + **domit** tame + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR unconquerable, unbeatable, invincible, unyielding

OPPOSITE weak, feeble, submissive

inexorable in-**EK**-ser-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to stop or change; not moved by pleading

MEMORY HOOK **IN it comes, no EXceptions.** Pip shouts "Stop!" at the sea, but the tide keeps coming in, no exceptions: it is **inexorable**.

The **inexorable** *tide crept up the beach and swallowed our sandcastle.*

PARTS **in-** not + **exor** win over by pleading + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR relentless, unstoppable, unyielding, inevitable
OPPOSITE stoppable, yielding

61. Not: in-, im- and ir-

insatiable in-**SAY**-shuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to satisfy; always wanting more

MEMORY HOOK **never SATIsfied: in-SATI-able.** Ivy has eaten a whole stack of pancakes and still is not satisfied: "More!" Her appetite is **insatiable**.

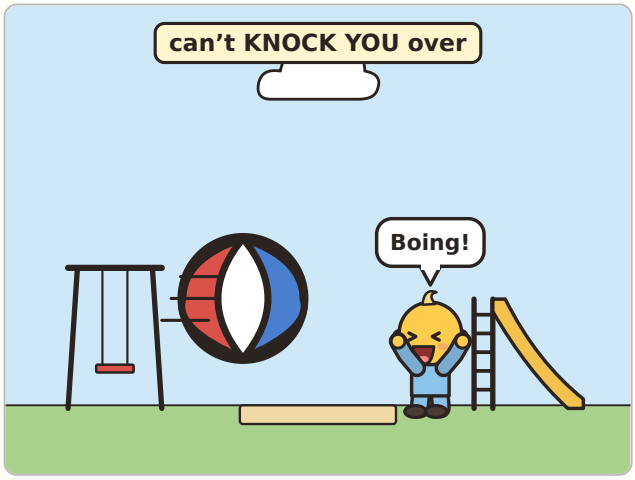
The puppy had an **insatiable** *appetite for tennis balls.*

PARTS **in-** not + **sati** enough, full + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR unquenchable, voracious, unappeasable
OPPOSITE satisfied, content

61. Not: in-, im- and ir-

innocuous ih-**NOK**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING harmless; not likely to hurt or upset anyone

MEMORY HOOK **in-KNOCK-YOU-ous: it can't KNOCK YOU over.** The huge beach ball bounces right into Theo, but it is so soft it can't knock you over; it is **innocuous**.

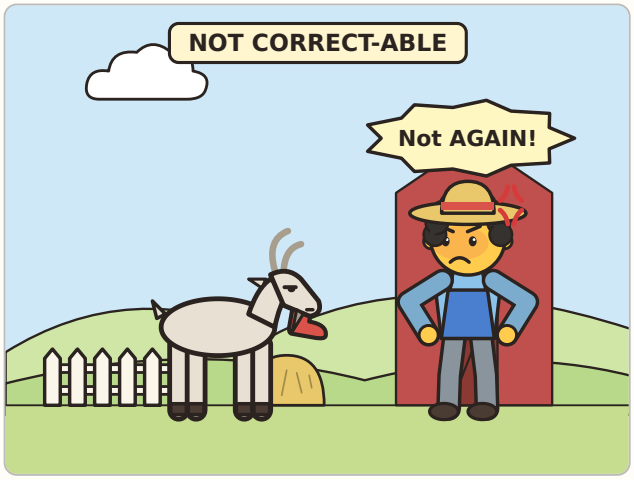
Her **innocuous** *question about the weather somehow started a long argument.*

PARTS **in-** not + **noc** harm + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR harmless, inoffensive, mild, safe
OPPOSITE harmful, offensive, dangerous

61. Not: in-, im- and ir-

incorrigible in-**KOR**-ih-juh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to correct or reform; always misbehaving

MEMORY HOOK **NOT CORRECT-able.** Farmer Jamal has told the goat "No!" a hundred times, but it still eats the socks off his line; it cannot be corrected. The goat is **incorrigible**.

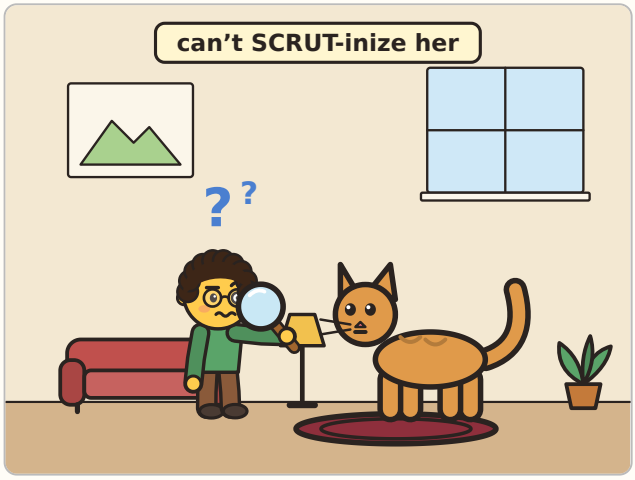
Our **incorrigible** *parrot still squawks at the mail carrier every single morning.*

PARTS **in-** not + **corrig** correct, set right + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR unruly, hopeless, unreformable, incurable
OPPOSITE obedient, manageable, reformable

61. Not: in-, im- and ir-

inscrutable in-**SKROO**-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to understand or read; mysterious

MEMORY HOOK **can't SCRUTinize it: in-SCRUT-able.** Sami scrutinizes the cat's face with a magnifying glass, but he still can't tell what she is thinking: her face is **inscrutable**.

The cat stared at me with an **inscrutable** *look, and I had no idea what it wanted.*

PARTS **in-** not + **scrut** search, examine + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR mysterious, unreadable, puzzling, enigmatic

OPPOSITE readable, obvious, transparent

irrevocable ih-**REV**-uh-kuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to undo or take back

MEMORY HOOK **can't call it back: ir-RE-VOC-able.** Once Kai drops the letter into the mailbox, he can't call it back, however loudly he shouts: mailing it was **irrevocable**.

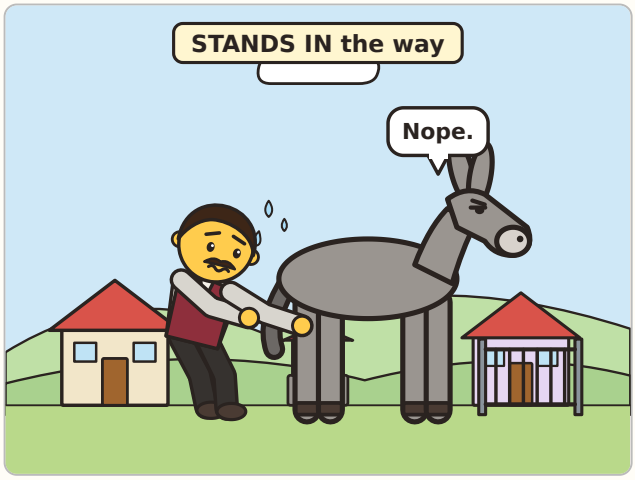
Pressing "send" felt **irrevocable**; *the message was already on its way.*

PARTS **ir-** not + **re-** back + **voc** call + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR irreversible, unalterable, final, permanent

OPPOSITE reversible, changeable, revocable

obstinate **OB**-stuh-nit *adjective*



MEANING stubbornly refusing to change one's mind or plan

MEMORY HOOK **STANDS IN the way: ob-STIN-ate.** The donkey stands in the middle of the gate, and no amount of pushing will move it: it is **obstinate**.

The **obstinate** *toddler refused to wear anything but her rain boots, even on a sunny day.*

PARTS **ob-** in the way + **stin** stand (akin to Latin stare) + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR stubborn, headstrong, pigheaded, inflexible

OPPOSITE flexible, agreeable, compliant

tenacious tuh-**NAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING holding on firmly; refusing to give up

MEMORY HOOK **holds on with all TEN fingers.** The wind howls around the cliff, but Maya holds on with all ten fingers and keeps climbing: she is **tenacious**.

The **tenacious** *terrier would not let go of the rope toy.*

PARTS **ten** hold + **-acious** inclined to, full of

SIMILAR persistent, determined, dogged, unrelenting

OPPOSITE irresolute, wavering, weak

steadfast **STED**-fast *adjective*



MEANING firm and loyal; not changing or giving way

MEMORY HOOK **STEADY, held FAST in its place.** Every stormy night, keeper Tia stays at her post and keeps the lighthouse lamp burning for the boats: she is **steadfast**.

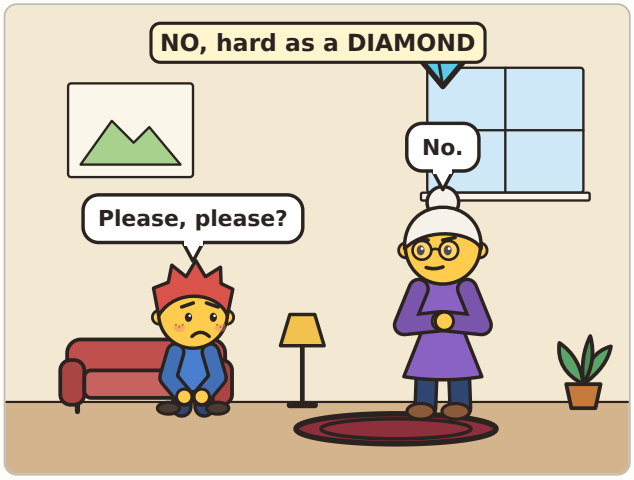
Through every losing season, the team's **steadfast** *fans filled the bleachers.*

PARTS **stead** place + **fast** fixed, firm

SIMILAR loyal, faithful, firm, unwavering

OPPOSITE fickle, disloyal, wavering

adamant **AD**-uh-munt *adjective*



MEANING firmly insisting; refusing to be talked out of something

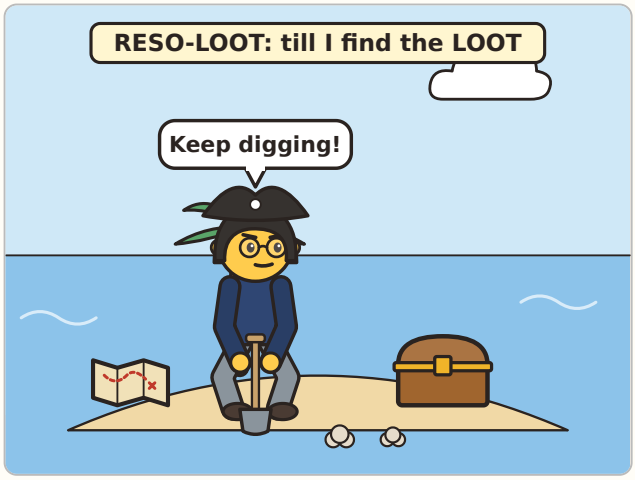
MEMORY HOOK **a NO as hard as a DIAMOND.** Pip begs to have cake for breakfast, but Granny Mae's "no" is as hard as a diamond: she is **adamant**. (Diamond and adamant come from the same Greek word, adamas.)

Grandpa was **adamant** *that we wear our seat belts, even for a one-block drive.*

SIMILAR insistent, unyielding, firm, unshakable

OPPOSITE flexible, yielding, wavering

resolute **REZ**-uh-loot *adjective*



MEANING firmly determined; set on a purpose

MEMORY HOOK **REZ-uh-LOOT: won't quit till the LOOT.** Captain Ada has dug for three days, and she won't stop until she finds the loot: she is **resolute**.

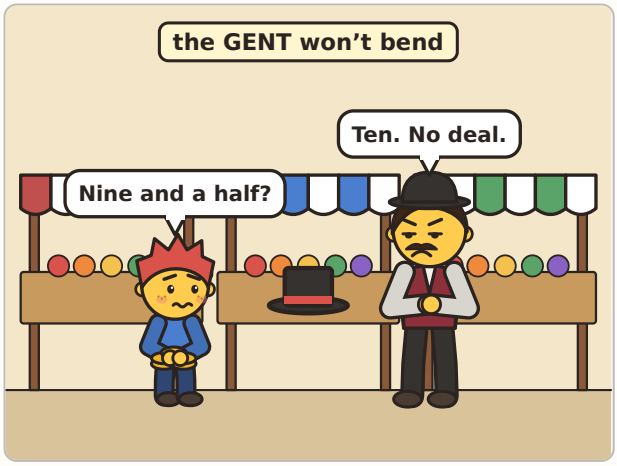
With a **resolute** *face, Dev stepped up to take the last penalty kick.*

PARTS **re-** back, again + **solu** loosen, free

SIMILAR determined, purposeful, unwavering, steadfast

OPPOSITE irresolute, hesitant, wavering

intransigent in-**TRAN**-sih-junt *adjective*



MEANING refusing to compromise or give way at all

MEMORY HOOK **the GENT who won't make a deal: in-TRANS-i-GENT.** Pip offers nine coins for the hat, then nine and a half, but the seller is a gent who will not bend an inch: "Ten, or no deal." He is **intransigent**.

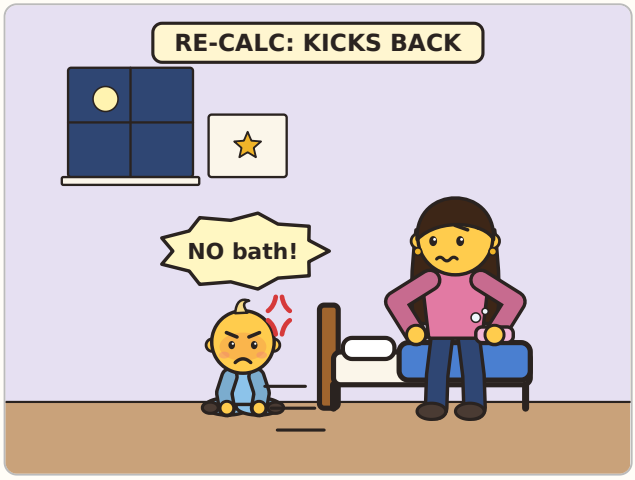
The two **intransigent** *cats each refused to give up the sunny spot on the porch.*

PARTS **in-** not + **transig** come to terms, compromise + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR uncompromising, unbending, inflexible, unyielding

OPPOSITE flexible, accommodating, compromising

recalcitrant rih-**KAL**-sih-trunt *adjective*



MEANING stubbornly refusing to obey or cooperate

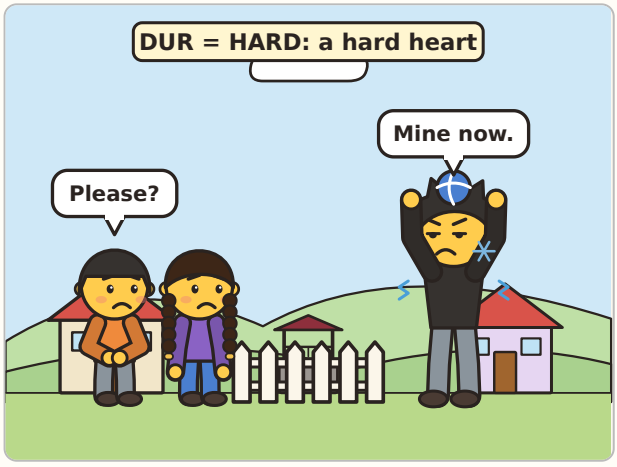
MEMORY HOOK **KICKS BACK with his heels: re-CALC-itrant.** At bath time, Theo kicks his heels and shouts “No!” He fights every rule: he is **recalcitrant**.

The **recalcitrant** *printer jammed every time we tried to print the poster.*

PARTS **re-** back + **calc** heel (Latin calx) + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR defiant, uncooperative, disobedient, stubborn
OPPOSITE obedient, cooperative, docile

obdurate **OB**-duh-rit *adjective*



MEANING hard-hearted and stubborn, especially when one should give way

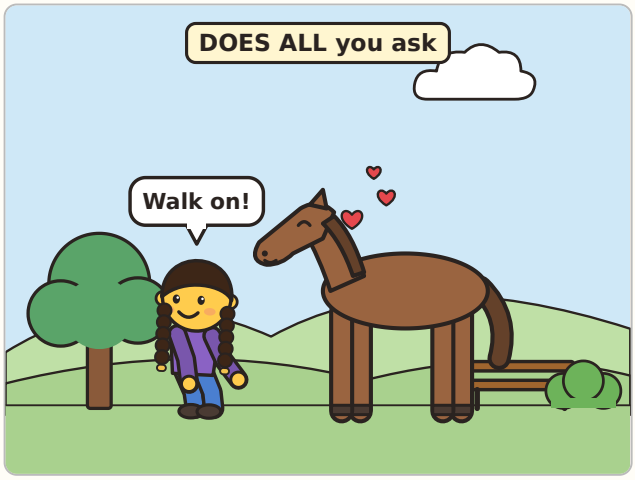
MEMORY HOOK **ob-DUR-ate: hard as DURable stone.** However nicely the children ask, Rex won’t give back the ball that flew over his fence; his heart is as hard as durable stone. He is **obdurate**.

Even the puppy’s sad eyes could not soften the **obdurate** *landlord.*

PARTS **ob-** thoroughly + **dur** hard, lasting + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR hard-hearted, unmoved, unyielding, stubborn
OPPOSITE softhearted, yielding, compassionate

docile **DOS**-ul *adjective*



MEANING calm and easy to teach, lead or control

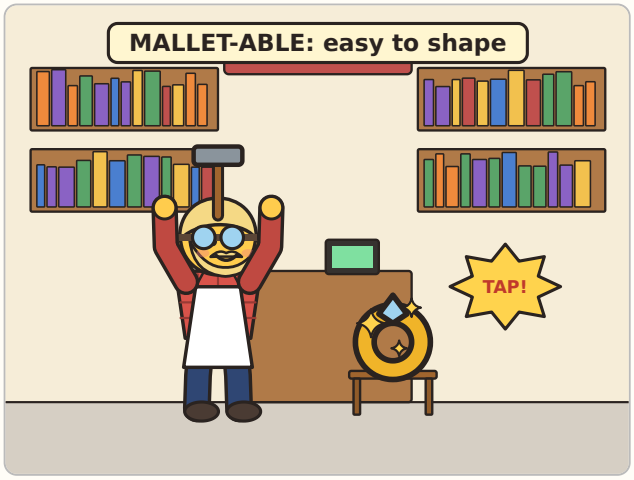
MEMORY HOOK **DOS-ul: it DOES ALL you ask.** Ask the pony to walk, stop or turn, and it does all you ask: it is **docile**.

The **docile** *old horse let every child at the fair take a turn on its back.*

PARTS **doc** teach + **-ile** able to be

SIMILAR obedient, gentle, tame, manageable
OPPOSITE unruly, willful, recalcitrant

malleable **MAL**-ee-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING easily shaped or bent; also, easily influenced

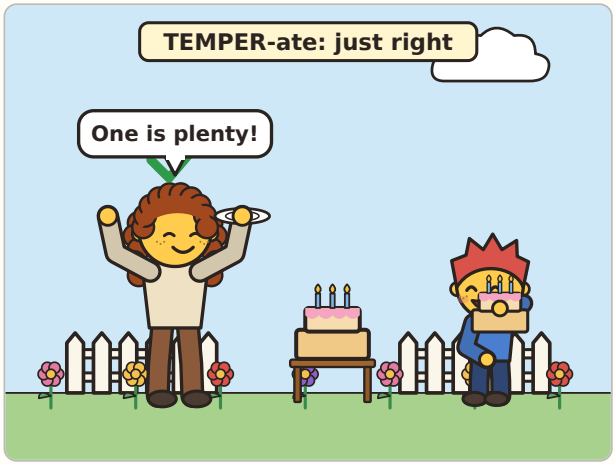
MEMORY HOOK **MALLET-able: shaped with a MALLET.** A few taps of the smith’s mallet and the soft gold bends into a ring: gold is **malleable**.

Warm wax is **malleable**, *so the children pressed it into star shapes.*

PARTS **malle** hammer + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR pliable, flexible, moldable, adaptable
OPPOSITE rigid, inflexible, brittle

temperate TEM-per-it *adjective*



MEANING moderate; showing self-control and avoiding extremes

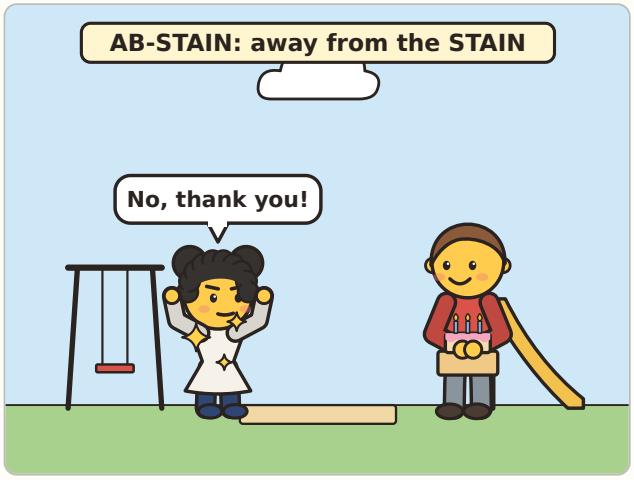
MEMORY HOOK **a TEMPERATURE that's just right.** Nell's habits are like a mild spring day, never too hot or too cold: one slice of cake, then "No more, thanks." She is **temperate**.

Even when the team lost, Coach Ada gave a **temperate** *answer instead of an angry one.*

PARTS **temper** mix in the right measure, moderate + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR moderate, restrained, self-controlled, mild
OPPOSITE excessive, extreme, immoderate

abstain ub-STAYN *verb*



MEANING to choose not to do or have something

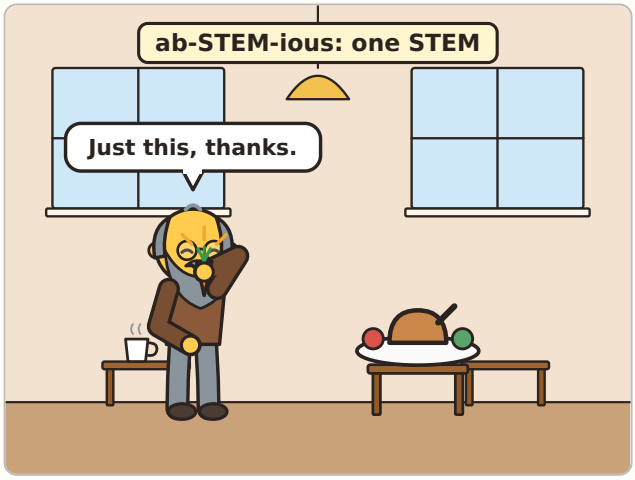
MEMORY HOOK **AB + STAIN: stay away from the STAIN.** At the party, Zoe keeps away from the chocolate fountain so nothing will stain her white dress: she **abstains**.

Grandpa **abstains** *from coffee after lunch so he can sleep at night.*

PARTS **abs-** away + **tain (ten)** hold

SIMILAR refrain, hold back, avoid, forgo
OPPOSITE indulge, partake

abstemious ab-STEE-mee-us *adjective*



MEANING eating and drinking only a little; sparing

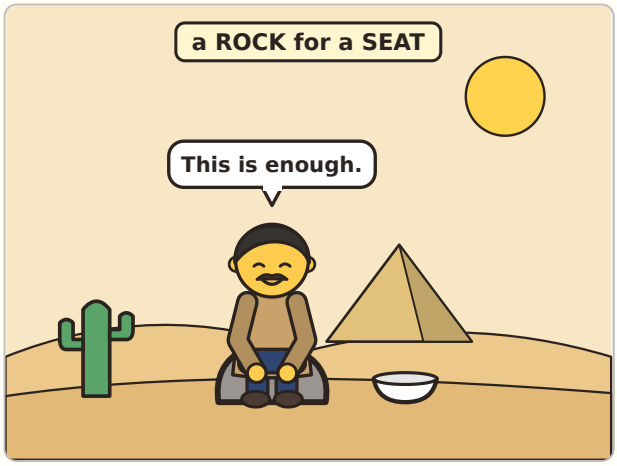
MEMORY HOOK **ab-STEM-ious: just one STEM.** At a table piled with food, Professor Edwin eats one stem of celery and calls it lunch: he is **abstemious**.

The **abstemious** *hiker carried only a pear and a bottle of water for the whole day.*

PARTS **abs-** away from + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR sparing, moderate, temperate, self-denying
OPPOSITE gluttonous, greedy, indulgent

ascetic uh-SET-ik *adjective*



MEANING giving up comforts and pleasures on purpose; very strict with oneself

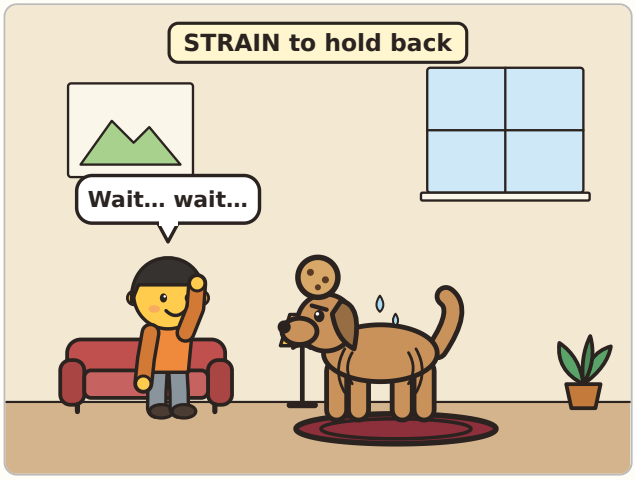
MEMORY HOOK **a ROCK for a SEAT: uh-SEAT-ic.** The hermit on the mountain gave up his soft chair and uses a rock for a seat; he gives up every comfort on purpose. He lives an **ascetic** life.

The runner kept an **ascetic** *schedule: early bed, plain food and no days off.*

PARTS **asket** exercise, train (Greek) + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR austere, self-denying, spartan, strict
OPPOSITE self-indulgent, luxurious, sybaritic

restraint rih-**STRAYNT** *noun*



MEANING control over one's own actions or feelings; holding back

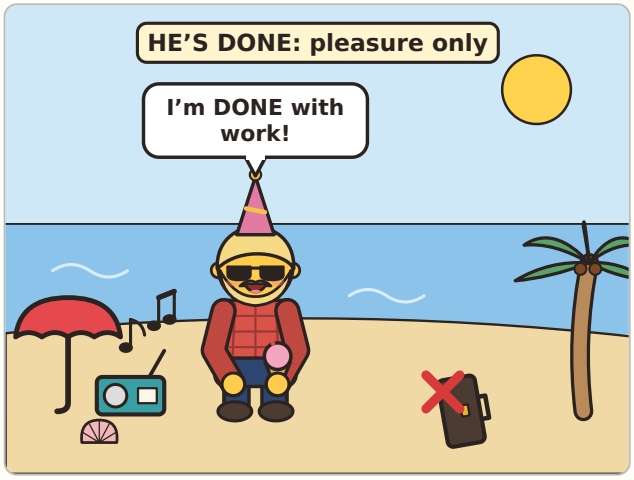
MEMORY HOOK **re-STRAIN-t: STRAIN to hold back.** The puppy strains and quivers, but it keeps the cookie balanced on its nose until Kai says "OK!" That is **restraint**.

It took real **restraint** *not to open the presents before Grandma arrived.*

PARTS **re-** back + **strain** draw tight

SIMILAR self-control, self-discipline, moderation, composure
OPPOSITE indulgence, excess, recklessness

hedonist **HEE**-duh-nist *noun*



MEANING a person who lives mainly for pleasure

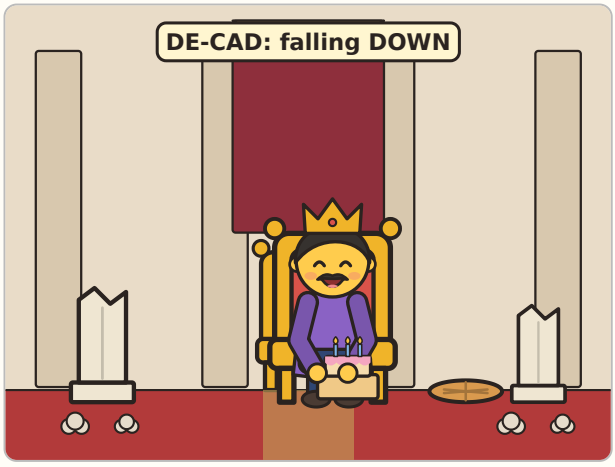
MEMORY HOOK **HE'S DONE with work: HE-DONE-ist.** Sven says he is done with chores forever; from now on it is ice cream, music and naps in the sun. He is a **hedonist**.

On vacation, even sensible Aunt Lin turned into a **hedonist**, *napping in the sun and ordering dessert first.*

PARTS **hedon** pleasure (Greek) + **-ist** a person who

SIMILAR pleasure-seeker, sybarite, sensualist, bon vivant
OPPOSITE ascetic, puritan

decadent **DEK**-uh-dunt *adjective*



MEANING spoiled by too much luxury and pleasure, and slipping downhill

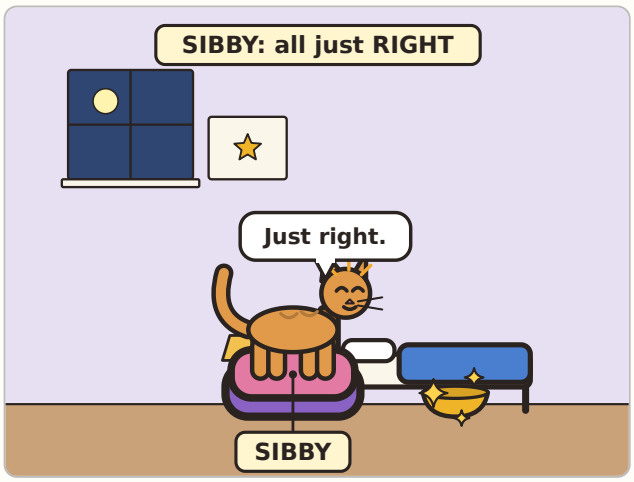
MEMORY HOOK **DE-CAD: falling DOWN from luxury.** The king lounges on his throne eating cake all day while the castle crumbles around him: his court has grown **decadent**.

The cake was so **decadent** *that it had three kinds of chocolate and a layer of fudge.*

PARTS **de-** down + **cad** fall + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR self-indulgent, overindulgent, corrupt, degenerate
OPPOSITE disciplined, austere, virtuous

sybarite **SIB**-uh-rite *noun*



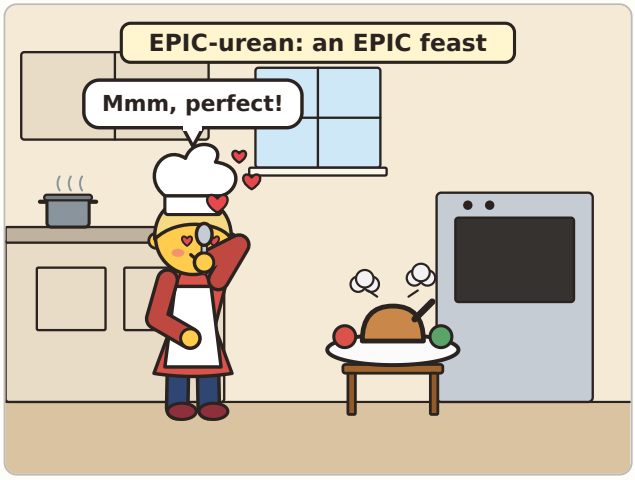
MEANING a person devoted to luxury and comfort

MEMORY HOOK **SIBBY wants it all just RIGHT.** Sibby the cat sleeps only on silk pillows and sips cream from a golden bowl; everything must be just right for this little **sybarite**.

A true **sybarite**, *Victor would not sit on any chair without a velvet cushion.*

SIMILAR hedonist, pleasure-seeker, voluptuary
OPPOSITE ascetic

epicurean ep-ih-kyoo-**REE**-un *adjective*



MEANING devoted to fine food and the pleasures of eating

MEMORY HOOK **EPIC-urean: an EPIC feast.** Chef Greta cooks an epic seven-course dinner and savors every bite: her tastes are **epicurean**.

Dad planned an **epicurean** *birthday dinner with seven small courses.*

SIMILAR gourmet, discriminating, pleasure-loving, refined
OPPOSITE ascetic, abstemious

voracious vuh-**RAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING wanting huge amounts of food, or of some activity

MEMORY HOOK **VOR = eat: de-VOUR-s every book.** Sami devours a book, then another, then another, and still wants more: he is a **voracious** reader.

After swimming all morning, the **voracious** *campers ate every pancake in sight.*

PARTS **vor** eat, devour + **-acious** full of, inclined to
SIMILAR ravenous, insatiable, greedy, avid
OPPOSITE full, satisfied, indifferent

witty **WIT**-ee *adjective*



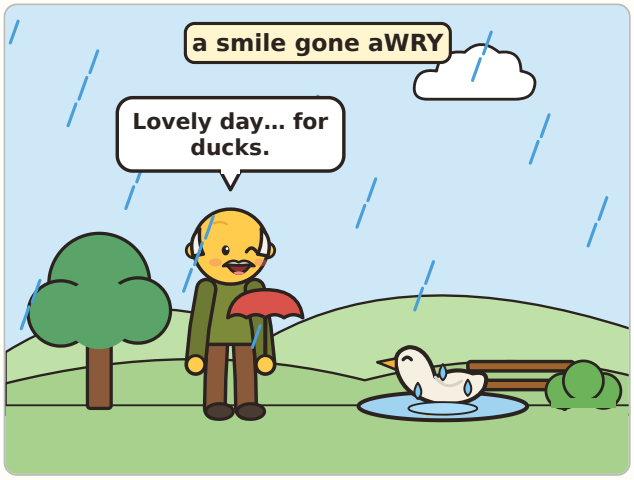
MEANING cleverly funny, especially with quick remarks

MEMORY HOOK **full of quick WIT: WIT-ty.** Rosa always has a quick, clever line ready, and her friends can't stop laughing: she is **witty**.

Her **witty** *reply made even the grumpy bus driver laugh.*

SIMILAR clever, humorous, quick-witted, amusing
OPPOSITE dull, humorless

wry **RYE** *adjective*



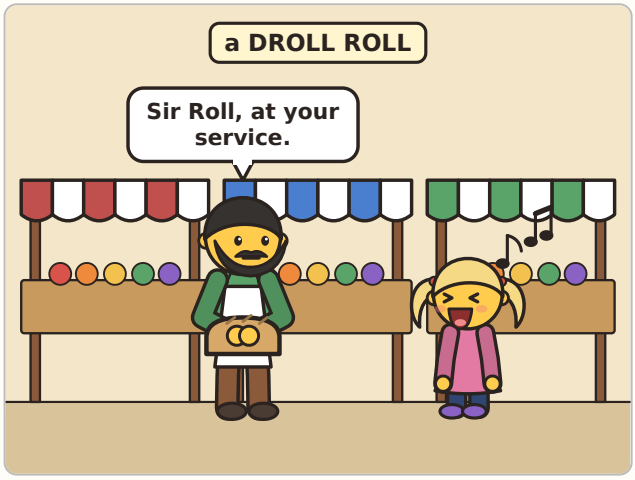
MEANING dryly funny, often with a touch of irony

MEMORY HOOK **a smile gone aWRY.** Rain pours on the picnic, and Grandpa Gus gives a crooked half smile: "Lovely day… for ducks." His humor is **wry**.

Dad gave a **wry** *smile when our "waterproof" tent leaked on the first night.*

SIMILAR dry, ironic, droll, mocking
OPPOSITE earnest, solemn

droll DROHL *adjective*



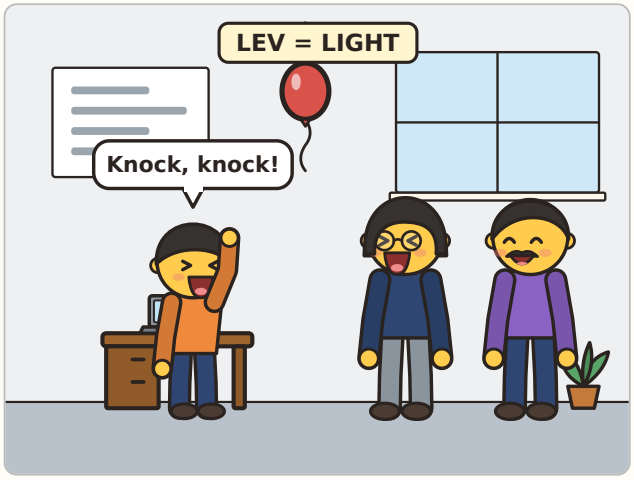
MEANING funny in an odd, quiet or dry way

MEMORY HOOK **a DROLL ROLL.** Baker Omar gives a bread roll a mustache and, with a perfectly straight face, bows: “Sir Roll, at your service.” His joke is **droll**.

The old fisherman had a **droll** *way of telling stories, never smiling while everyone else laughed.*

SIMILAR amusing, whimsical, dry, comical
OPPOSITE serious, dull

levity LEV-ih-tee *noun*



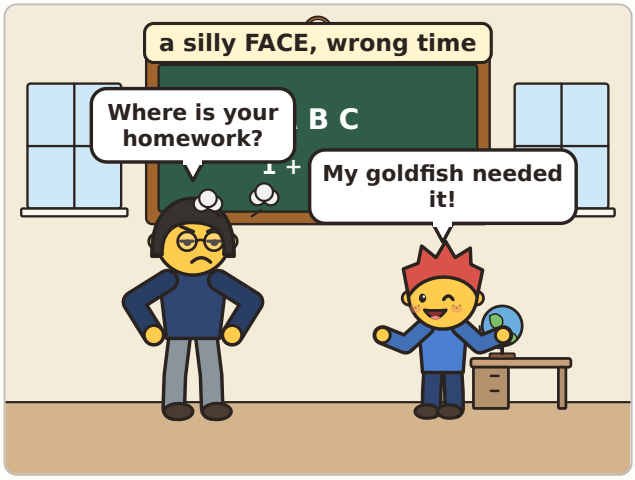
MEANING lightness of mood or humor, especially at a serious time

MEMORY HOOK **LEV = LIGHT: a joke that LEVitates.** The long meeting feels heavy until Dev’s joke floats up like a balloon and lifts everyone’s mood: a moment of **levity**.

A little **levity** *helped the nervous players relax before the final game.*

PARTS **lev** light (not heavy) + **-ity** the state or quality of being
SIMILAR lightheartedness, frivolity, humor, playfulness
OPPOSITE gravity, seriousness, solemnity

facetious fuh-**SEE**-shus *adjective*



MEANING joking at a time that calls for being serious

MEMORY HOOK **FACE-tious: a silly FACE at the wrong time.** When the teacher asks why his homework is late, Pip pulls a silly face and says, “My goldfish needed it.” He is being **facetious**.

“Maybe we should all move to the moon,” Kai said, but he was only being **facetious**.

PARTS **facet** witty, joking (Latin facetus) + **-ious** full of, having
SIMILAR flippant, joking, tongue-in-cheek
OPPOSITE serious, earnest, sincere

sarcastic sar-**KAS**-tik *adjective*



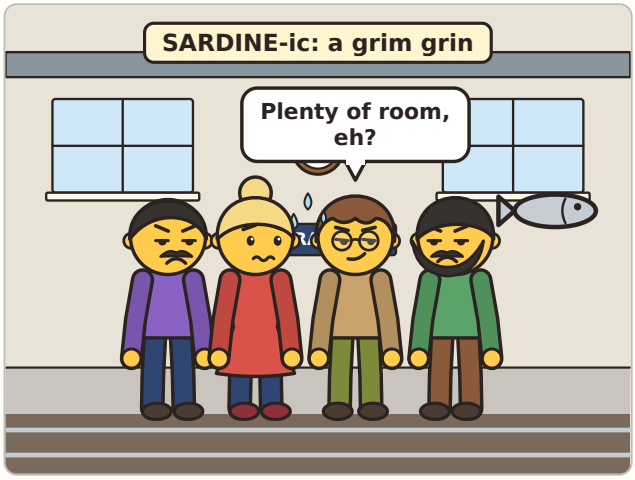
MEANING saying the opposite of what one means, to mock or show annoyance

MEMORY HOOK **“Oh, GREAT”: says the OPPOSITE.** The bus splashes Kai with mud, and he says, “Oh, wonderful. Just what I wanted.” He means the opposite: he is being **sarcastic**.

“Oh, great, more homework,” Lila said in a **sarcastic** *voice.*

PARTS **sarc** flesh (Greek sarx) + **-ic** having to do with, like
SIMILAR mocking, snide, sardonic, cutting
OPPOSITE sincere, earnest

sardonic sar-**DON**-ik *adjective*



MEANING grimly mocking; scornfully amused

MEMORY HOOK **SARDINE-ic: a grim grin, packed like SARDINES.** Squashed into the train like a sardine in a can, Felix gives a grim grin: “Plenty of room, eh?” His humor is **sardonic**.

The tired reporter gave a **sardonic** *laugh when the “quick” meeting entered its third hour.*

PARTS **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR mocking, scornful, cynical, sarcastic

OPPOSITE sincere, warm, earnest

satire **SAT**-eye-er *noun*



MEANING humor that exposes foolishness or wrongdoing, often by exaggerating it

MEMORY HOOK **SAT + IRE: anger turned into laughs.** Tired of silly rules, the students put their ire into a play about a king who bans frowning; the whole school laughs and gets the point. The play is a **satire**.

The comic strip is a gentle **satire** *of office life, full of pointless meetings.*

SIMILAR send-up, ridicule, mockery, spoof

OPPOSITE tribute, praise

parody **PAIR**-uh-dee *noun*



MEANING a funny imitation that exaggerates the original

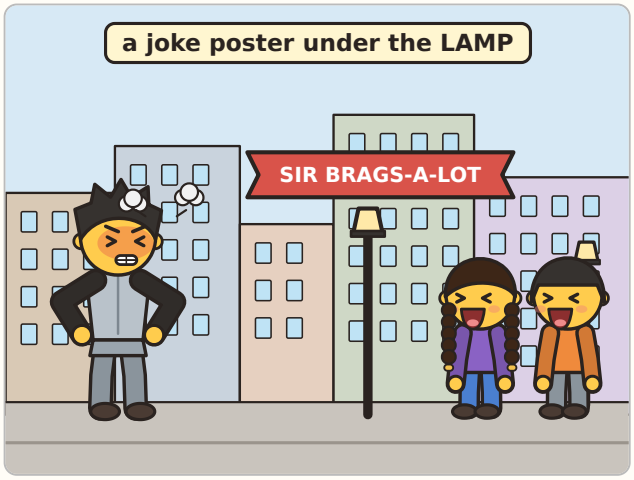
MEMORY HOOK **PARROT-dy: a PARROT’s funny copy.** The parrot copies Grandpa’s sneeze, only louder and sillier: “AH-AH-AH-CHOOOO!” It is a **parody** of his sneeze.

The class wrote a **parody** *of a weather report, forecasting a ninety percent chance of homework.*

PARTS **para-** beside (Greek) + **ody (ode)** song

SIMILAR spoof, send-up, imitation, caricature

lampoon lam-**POON** *verb*



MEANING to mock in public, often in writing or pictures

MEMORY HOOK **a joke poster under the LAMP.** The town is tired of Sir Rex’s bragging, so someone hangs a funny poster under the street lamp: “SIR BRAGS-A-LOT.” It **lampoons** him for all to see.

The comedy show **lampooned** *the strangest fashion trends of the year.*

SIMILAR mock, ridicule, satirize, spoof

OPPOSITE praise, flatter

tedious TEE-dee-us *adjective*



MEANING long, slow and tiresome

MEMORY HOOK **TEDDY-ous: so many TEDDIES.** Sorting a hundred teddy bears by size takes hours and hours: the job is **tedious**.

Sorting a thousand buttons by color was a **tedious** *job.*

PARTS **tedi** weariness (Latin taedium) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR boring, tiresome, monotonous, dreary
OPPOSITE exciting, interesting, engaging

monotonous muh-NOT-uh-nus *adjective*



MEANING dull because it never changes; always the same

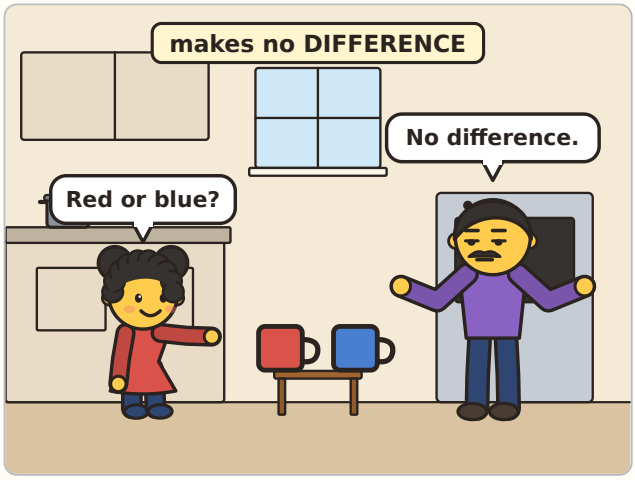
MEMORY HOOK **MONO-TONE: one note, again and again.** Felix plays the same single piano key for an hour: "Plink… plink… plink…" The sound is **monotonous**.

The **monotonous** *hum of the fan put the baby to sleep.*

PARTS **mono-** one + **ton** tone, sound + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR repetitive, unvarying, humdrum, dull
OPPOSITE varied, lively, interesting

indifferent in-DIF-er-unt *adjective*



MEANING not caring or interested either way

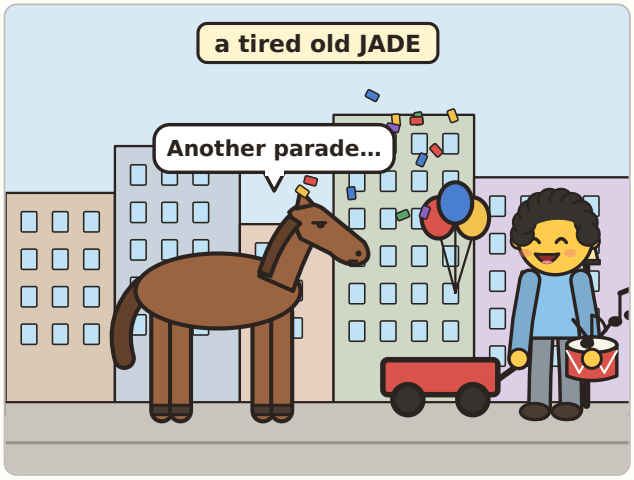
MEMORY HOOK **it makes no DIFFERENCE to me.** Ask Uncle Marcus if he wants the red cup or the blue one, and he shrugs: it makes no difference to him. He is **indifferent**.

The cat seemed completely **indifferent** *to its expensive new toy.*

PARTS **in-** not + **differ** be different + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR uninterested, unconcerned, apathetic, detached
OPPOSITE interested, concerned, eager

jaded JAY-did *adjective*



MEANING tired and bored from having too much of something

MEMORY HOOK **a tired old JADE (a worn-out horse).** An old word for a worn-out horse is a jade. Dusty has pulled the parade wagon a thousand times, and not even the brass band excites him now: he is **jaded**.

After ten summers at the same beach, the **jaded** *teenagers barely looked at the waves.*

SIMILAR weary, world-weary, blasé, sated
OPPOSITE eager, enthusiastic, fresh

blasé blah-**ZAY** *adjective*



MEANING unimpressed, as if one has seen it all before

MEMORY HOOK **"BLAH," she SAYS: blah-ZAY.** The fireworks burst in every color, and little Ivy squeals, but her big sister just says, "Blah." Rosa is **blasé**.

*Kai acted **blasé** about meeting the star pitcher, but his hands were shaking.*

SIMILAR unimpressed, nonchalant, indifferent, offhand
OPPOSITE impressed, excited, enthusiastic

ennui on-**WEE** *noun*



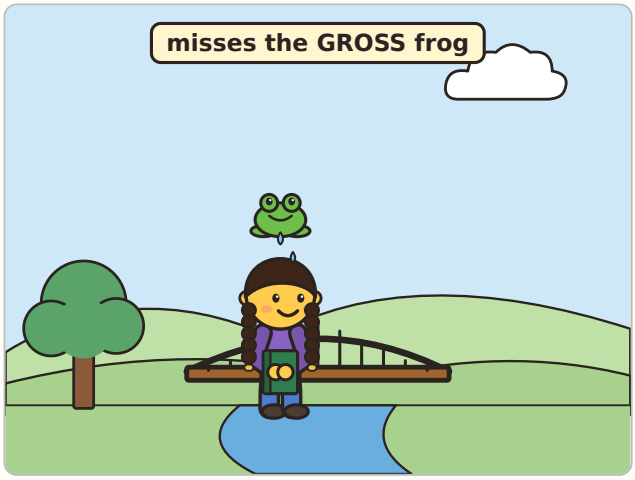
MEANING a weary, restless feeling of boredom

MEMORY HOOK **on-WEE: "What do WE do now?".** On the tenth rainy day of summer, the cousins sigh on the sofa: "What do WE do now?" They are full of **ennui**.

*By the fourth rainy afternoon, a heavy **ennui** had settled over the cabin.*

SIMILAR boredom, listlessness, weariness, tedium
OPPOSITE excitement, enthusiasm, interest

engrossed en-**GROHST** *adjective*



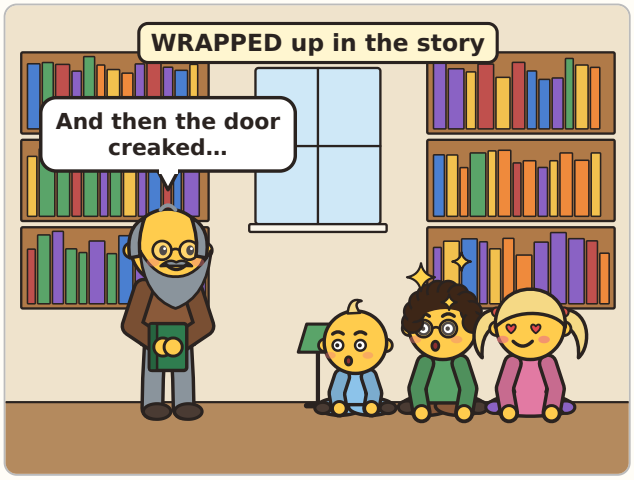
MEANING so interested that one notices nothing else

MEMORY HOOK **so lost in it, she misses the GROSS frog.** Lila is so deep in her book that she never notices the gross, slimy frog sitting on her head: she is **engrossed**.

*Maya was so **engrossed** in her puzzle that she forgot to eat lunch.*

SIMILAR absorbed, immersed, captivated
OPPOSITE distracted, bored, inattentive

rapt **RAPT** *adjective*



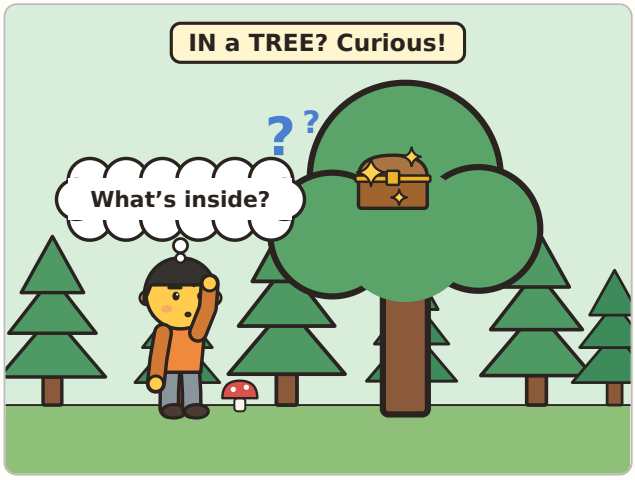
MEANING completely fascinated; giving full attention

MEMORY HOOK **WRAPPED up in the story.** The children sit wrapped up in Professor Edwin's tale, mouths open, not moving a muscle: they are **rapt**.

*The children listened in **rapt** silence as Grandpa told the story of the winter the river froze solid.*

SIMILAR spellbound, enthralled, absorbed, fascinated
OPPOSITE distracted, bored, inattentive

intrigued in-**TREEGD** *adjective*



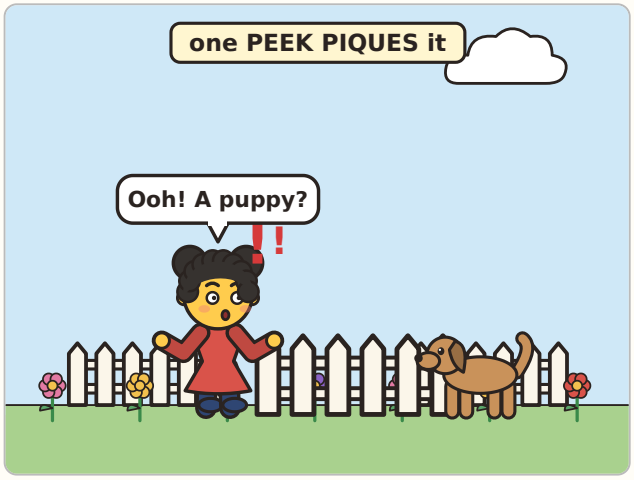
MEANING very curious and eager to know more

MEMORY HOOK **IN a TREE? Curious!.** A locked box sits high in the old oak tree. Who put it there, and what is inside? Kai can't stop wondering: he is **intrigued**.

Lila was **intrigued** *by the old map she found in the attic.*

SIMILAR curious, fascinated, interested, captivated
OPPOSITE bored, uninterested, indifferent

pique **PEEK** *verb*



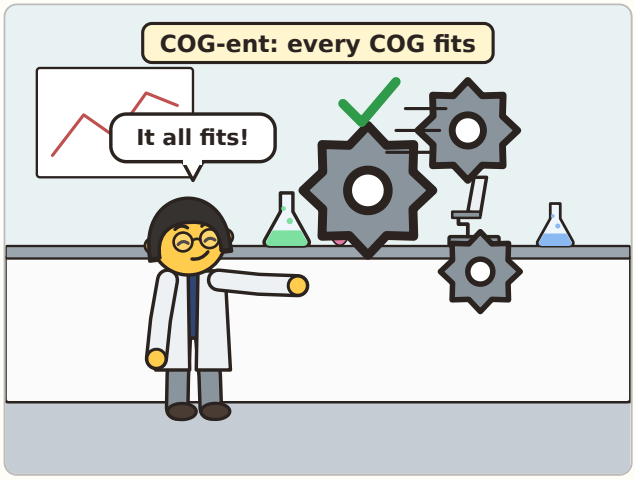
MEANING to stir up interest or curiosity

MEMORY HOOK **one PEEK PIQUES your interest.** Through a knothole in the fence, Zoe takes one peek at the new neighbor's puppy, and that peek **piques** her curiosity.

The movie trailer was made to **pique** *your curiosity without giving away the ending.*

SIMILAR arouse, stir, spark, kindle
OPPOSITE dull, deaden

cogent **KOH**-junt *adjective*



MEANING clear, logical and convincing

MEMORY HOOK **COG-ent: every COG fits.** In Ada's argument every point fits the next like the cogs of a clock, so the whole thing turns smoothly: it is **cogent**.

Rosa made a **cogent** *case for a longer lunch break, complete with charts.*

SIMILAR convincing, compelling, persuasive, sound
OPPOSITE unconvincing, weak, muddled

trenchant **TREN**-chunt *adjective*



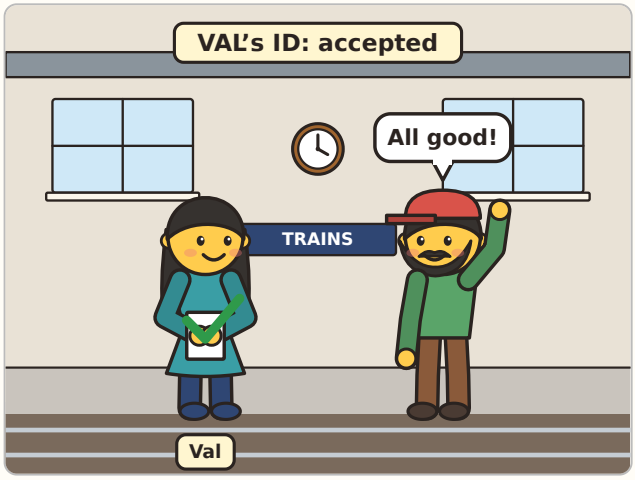
MEANING sharp, clear and forceful, cutting straight to the point

MEMORY HOOK **the TRENCH COAT detective: sharp and clear.** The detective in the trench coat sums up the case in one sharp, clear line: "The cake thief has frosting on his sleeve." Her remark is **trenchant**.

The coach's **trenchant** *comments at halftime showed the team exactly what was going wrong.*

SIMILAR incisive, sharp, keen, pointed
OPPOSITE vague, mild, woolly

valid VAL-id *adjective*



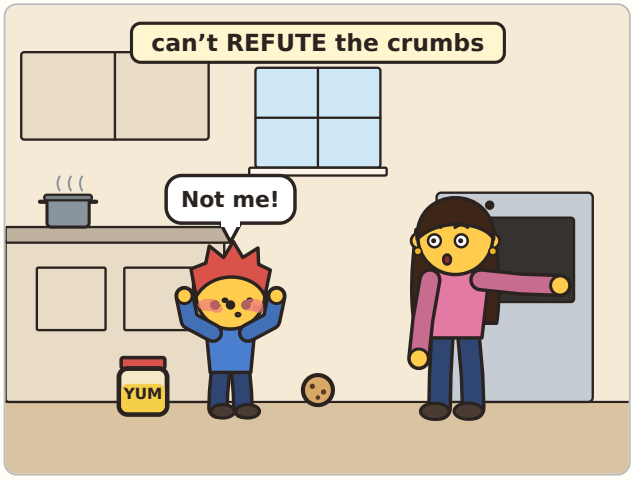
MEANING logically correct or well grounded; also, officially accepted

MEMORY HOOK **VAL + ID: Val's ID is accepted.** At the gate, Val shows her ID; it is real and up to date, so the guard waves her through. Her ID is **valid**.

Your library card is **valid** *for one more year.*

SIMILAR logical, well-founded, legitimate, reasonable
OPPOSITE invalid, unsound, void

irrefutable ir-ih-FYOO-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to prove wrong

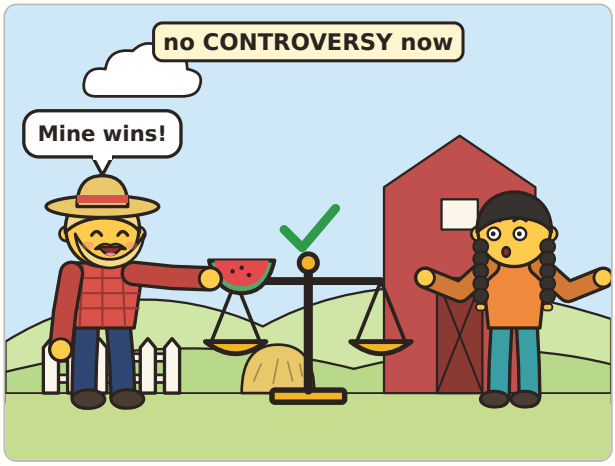
MEMORY HOOK **can't REFUTE the crumbs.** Pip says he didn't eat the cookies, but crumbs cover his face and his hand is still in the jar: the proof is **irrefutable**.

The video replay was **irrefutable** *proof that the ball crossed the line.*

PARTS **ir-** not + **refut** prove wrong + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR undeniable, indisputable, incontrovertible, conclusive
OPPOSITE questionable, doubtful, debatable

incontrovertible in-kon-truh-VUR-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING so certain that no one can dispute it

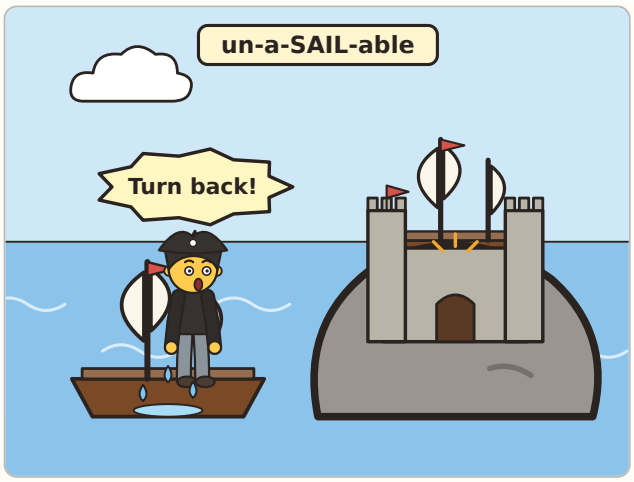
MEMORY HOOK **no CONTROVERSY: in-CONTROVERT-ible.** Sven and Tia argue over whose watermelon is heavier until the scale settles it: no controversy now. The answer is **incontrovertible**.

The photo finish was **incontrovertible***: the blue runner won by an inch.*

PARTS **in-** not + **contro (contra)** against + **vert** turn + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR indisputable, undeniable, irrefutable, certain
OPPOSITE debatable, uncertain, questionable

unassailable un-uh-SAY-luh-bul *adjective*



MEANING too strong to be attacked or questioned

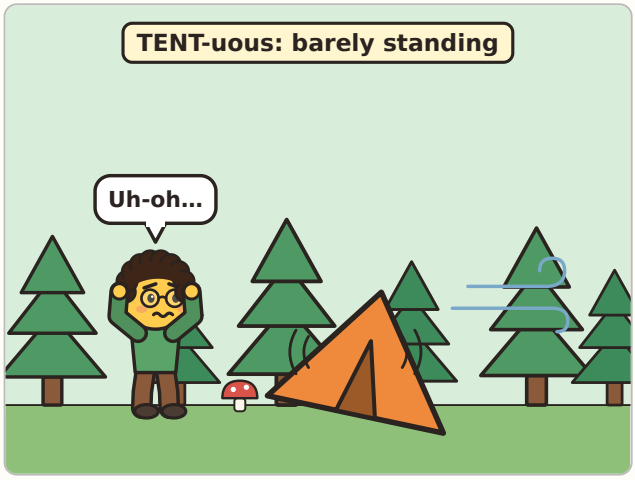
MEMORY HOOK **un-a-SAIL-able: no ship can SAIL in.** The pirates sail at the island fort again and again, but its walls never give way: the fort is **unassailable**.

With a twenty-point lead and two minutes left, the team's position looked **unassailable**.

PARTS **un-** not + **assail** attack + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR impregnable, invulnerable, irrefutable, secure
OPPOSITE vulnerable, weak, questionable

tenuous **TEN**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING very weak, thin or slight

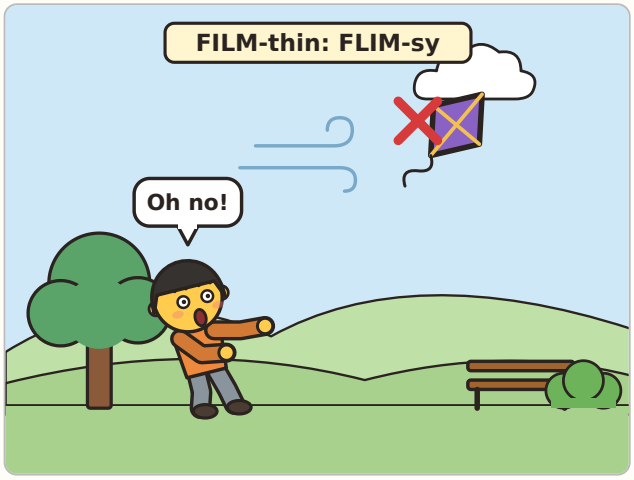
MEMORY HOOK **TENT-uous: a TENT barely standing.** The tent is held up by one thin, wobbly pole, and the next breeze could knock it down: its hold is **tenuous**.

The kitten kept a **tenuous** *grip on the top of the curtain.*

PARTS **tenu** thin (Latin tenuis) + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR flimsy, weak, slight, thin
OPPOSITE strong, solid, substantial

flimsy **FLIM**-zee *adjective*



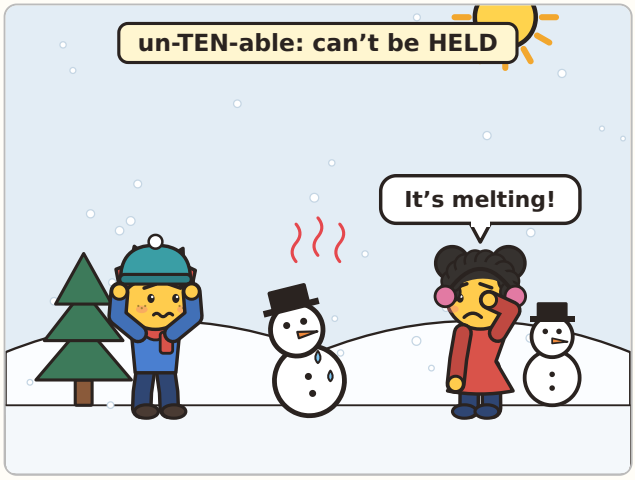
MEANING weak and easily broken; also, hard to believe

MEMORY HOOK **FILM-thin: FLIM-sy.** Kai's kite is made of film-thin paper and two twigs, and the first gust rips it in half: it is **flimsy**.

The **flimsy** *umbrella turned inside out at the first gust of wind.*

SIMILAR weak, fragile, tenuous, feeble
OPPOSITE sturdy, strong, convincing

untenable un-**TEN**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to defend, keep or hold on to

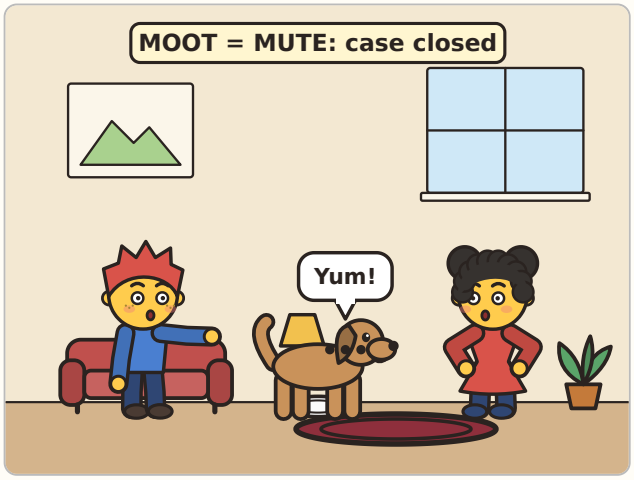
MEMORY HOOK **un-TEN-able: TEN = hold, so it can't be HELD.** The sun is melting the snow fort, and Pip and Zoe can't hold it much longer: their position is **untenable**.

With the river rising around the campsite, staying another night was **untenable**.

PARTS **un-** not + **ten** hold + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR indefensible, unsound, unsupportable, insupportable
OPPOSITE defensible, sound, tenable

moot **MOOT** *adjective*



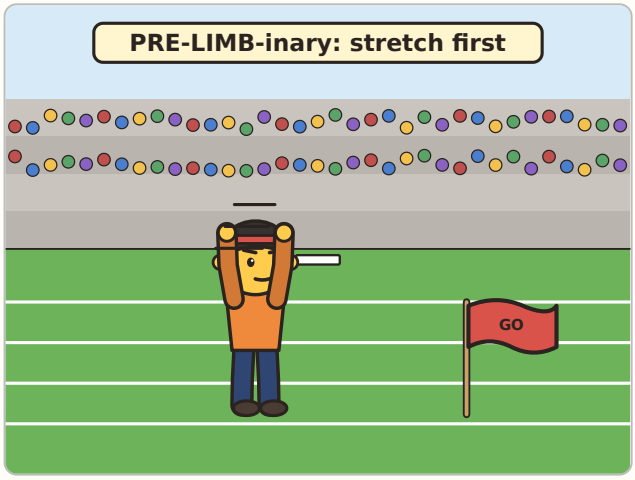
MEANING open to debate; also, no longer worth arguing about

MEMORY HOOK **MOOT = MUTE: nothing left to argue.** Pip and Zoe argue over who gets the last cookie, until they see the dog already ate it. The argument goes mute: the question is **moot**.

Whether to hold the picnic indoors became **moot** *when the rain stopped.*

SIMILAR debatable, arguable, academic, irrelevant
OPPOSITE settled, relevant

preliminary prih-**LIM**-uh-nair-ee *adjective*



MEANING coming before the main part, to prepare for it

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-LIMB: stretch your LIMBS before.** Before the big race, Dev stretches every limb, one by one: these are his **preliminary** exercises.

The **preliminary** *round of the spelling bee weeded out half the contestants.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **limin** threshold, doorway + **-ary** having to do with

SIMILAR introductory, preparatory, initial, opening
OPPOSITE final, concluding, main

subsequent **SUB**-sih-kwunt *adjective*



MEANING coming after; following

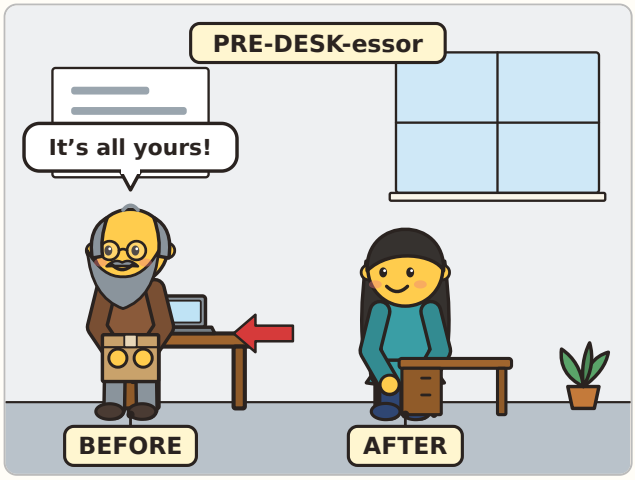
MEMORY HOOK **SUB-SEQUEL: the SEQUEL comes after.** A sequel is the story that comes after the first one. Pip and Lila can't wait for Part 2, due out the **subsequent** summer.

The first storm knocked down a tree, and **subsequent** *storms finished off the fence.*

PARTS **sub-** close to, after + **sequ** follow + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR following, later, succeeding, ensuing
OPPOSITE previous, prior, preceding

predecessor **PRED**-uh-ses-er *noun*



MEANING a person who held a job or role before someone else

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-DESK-essor: at the DESK before you.** Edwin carries his box out the door, and Lin sits down at his old desk; the one who had the desk before her is her **predecessor**.

The new coach kept many of the drills from her **predecessor**.

PARTS **pre-** before + **de-** away + **cess** go + **-or** one who

SIMILAR forerunner, previous holder, precursor
OPPOSITE successor

successor suk-**SES**-er *noun*



MEANING a person or thing that follows another in a role or place

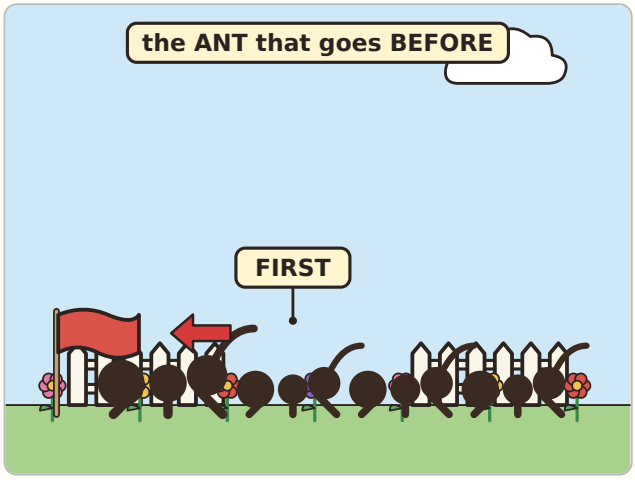
MEMORY HOOK **takes the torch NEXT: SUCCESS-or.** In the relay, Dev hands the torch to Maya, who runs the next stretch: Maya is his **successor**.

The old queen named her niece as her **successor**.

PARTS **suc- (sub-)** close after + **cess** go + **-or** one who

SIMILAR heir, replacement, follower
OPPOSITE predecessor, forerunner

antecedent an-tuh-**SEE**-dunt *noun*



MEANING something that comes before and leads to something else

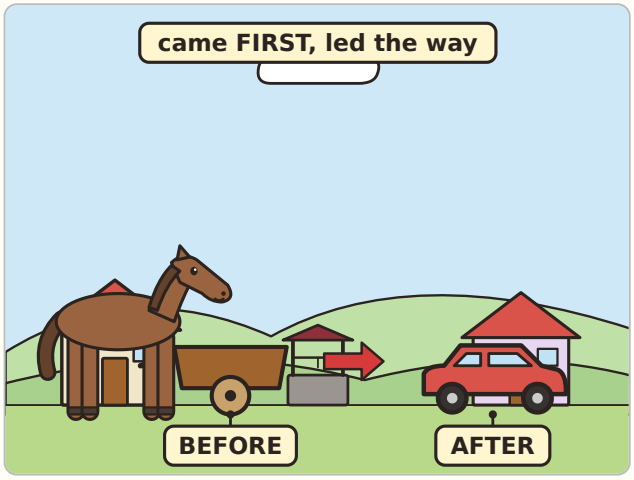
MEMORY HOOK **the ANT-ecedent: the ANT that goes BEFORE.** The first ant marches ahead, and all the others follow behind it; the one that goes before is the **antecedent**.

The old telegraph was an **antecedent** *of today's text message.*

PARTS **ante-** before + **ced** go + **-ent** being or doing (a noun or adjective ending)

SIMILAR forerunner, precursor, predecessor
OPPOSITE consequence, result

precursor prih-**KUR**-ser *noun*



MEANING something that came earlier and led the way to a later thing

MEMORY HOOK **PRE + CURSOR (runner): the FORERUNNER.** Long before cars, horse-drawn carts rumbled down the roads; the cart ran ahead of the car in history. It was a **precursor**.

The abacus was a **precursor** *of the calculator.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **curs** run + **-or** one who, a thing that

SIMILAR forerunner, predecessor, antecedent, harbinger
OPPOSITE successor, descendant

harbinger **HAR**-bin-jer *noun*



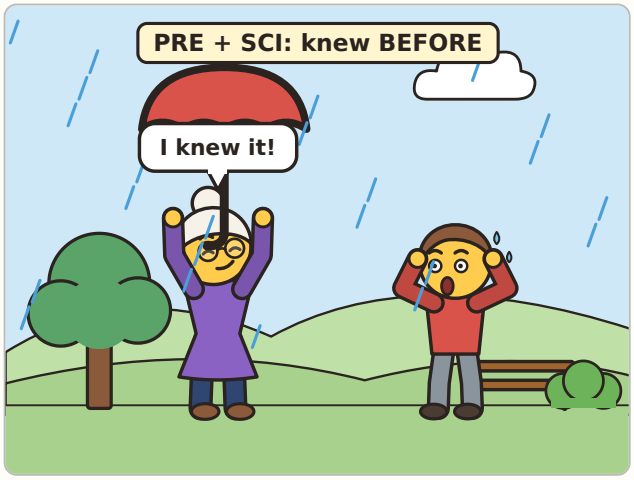
MEANING a sign or messenger of what is coming

MEMORY HOOK **HARK! A sign of what's coming.** "Hark! Spring is on its way!" says the first butterfly over the melting snow; it is a **harbinger** of spring.

The first crocus poking through the snow is a **harbinger** *of spring.*

SIMILAR herald, sign, omen, forerunner

prescient **PRESH**-ee-unt *adjective*



MEANING knowing or sensing what will happen before it does

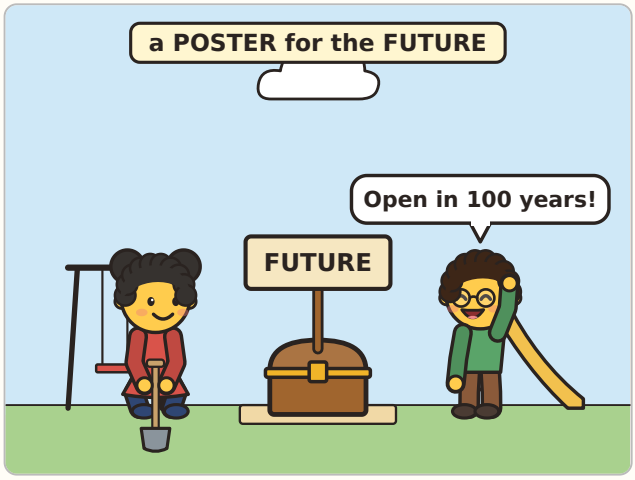
MEMORY HOOK **PRE + SCI: knows BEFORE.** On a cloudless morning, Granny Mae packs an umbrella; by noon it pours, and she is the only one dry. She was **prescient**.

Her **prescient** *warning about the leaky roof saved our books from the rain.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **sci** know + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR farsighted, foresighted, prophetic, visionary
OPPOSITE shortsighted, unaware

posterity pos-**TER**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING all the people of the future; later generations

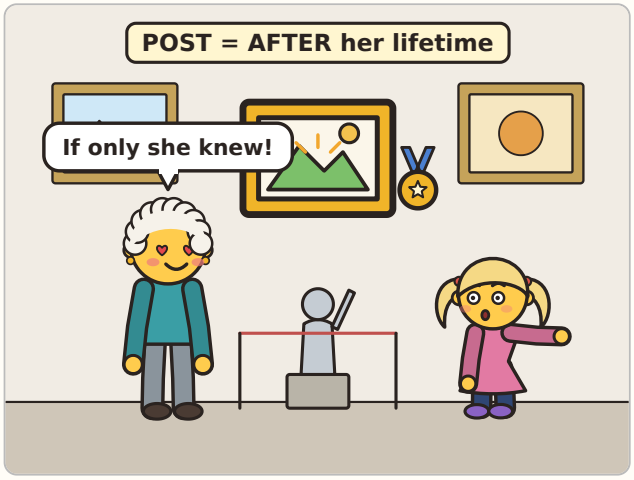
MEMORY HOOK **a POSTER for the FUTURE: POSTER-ity.** The class seals a poster in a time capsule for the children of a hundred years from now: they are saving it for **posterity**.

Mom recorded Grandpa's stories for **posterity**.

PARTS **post** after + **-ity** the state or quality of being

SIMILAR future generations, descendants, heirs
OPPOSITE ancestors, forebears

posthumous **POS**-chuh-mus *adjective*



MEANING happening or given after a person's death

MEMORY HOOK **POST = after: praise that comes AFTER a life.** Great-Grandma Rose painted all her life, but her pictures won prizes only after she had passed away: her fame was **posthumous**.

The poet's best-known book was a **posthumous** *collection, printed after she died.*

PARTS **post** after + **-ous** having to do with

SIMILAR after-death, postmortem
OPPOSITE lifetime

deter dih-**TUR** *verb*



MEANING to discourage someone from acting, often through fear of what might happen

MEMORY HOOK **DE-TERR: TERRIFY them away.** Felix dresses up as a scarecrow, and the crows flap off in terror; the scary sight **deters** them from the corn.

The barking dog **deters** *anyone from climbing over the fence.*

PARTS **de-** away + **ter** frighten (as in terror)

SIMILAR discourage, dissuade, scare off, prevent
OPPOSITE encourage, motivate, invite

dissuade dih-**SWAYD** *verb*



MEANING to talk someone out of doing something

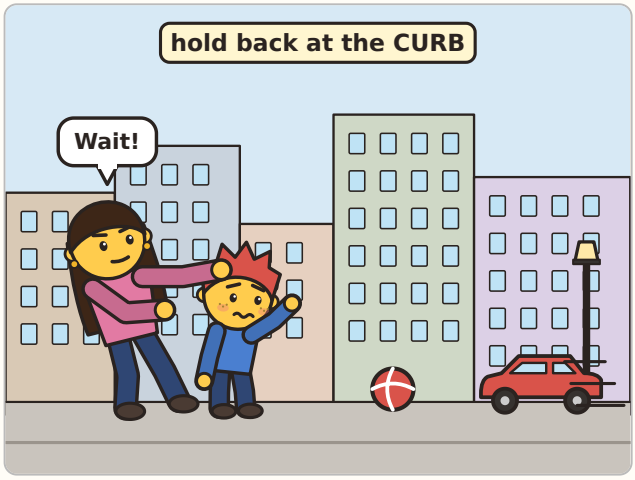
MEMORY HOOK **DIS-SUADE: the opposite of perSUADE.** Dev wants to paint his room neon orange, but Dad talks him out of it: Dad **dissuades** him.

Nothing could **dissuade** *Maya from trying out for the team.*

PARTS **dis-** apart, away + **suade** urge

SIMILAR discourage, deter, talk out of
OPPOSITE persuade, convince, encourage

curb KURB *verb*



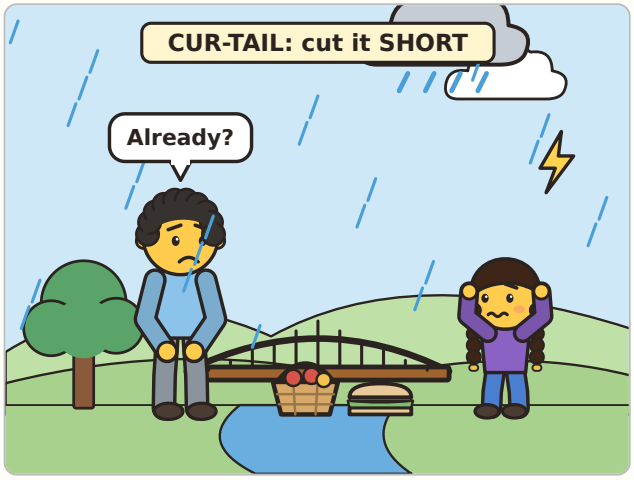
MEANING to hold back or keep under control

MEMORY HOOK **hold back at the CURB.** Pip wants to dash after his ball, but Mom holds him back at the curb until the cars pass: she **curbs** his rush.

The library posted a new rule to **curb** *noise after six o'clock.*

SIMILAR restrain, check, limit, control
OPPOSITE unleash, encourage

curtail ker-TAYL *verb*



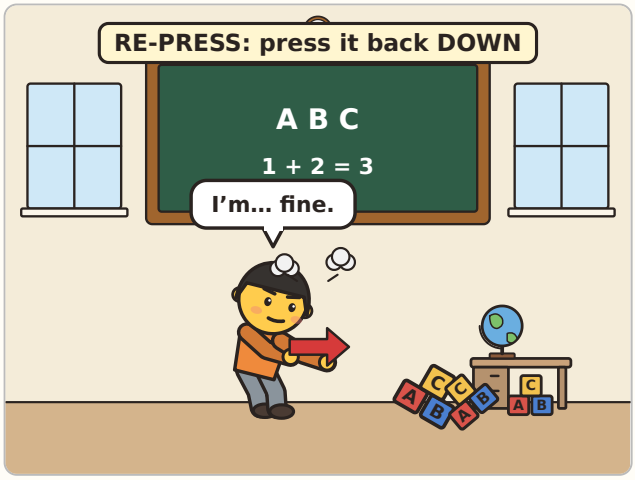
MEANING to cut short or cut back

MEMORY HOOK **CUR-TAIL: snip the TAIL off.** Ten minutes into the picnic, a storm rolls in and snips the afternoon short like a tail: the rain **curtails** the picnic.

Rain **curtailed** *the game after only three innings.*

SIMILAR shorten, cut short, cut back, limit
OPPOSITE extend, lengthen, prolong

repress rih-PRES *verb*



MEANING to hold back or keep down, especially a feeling

MEMORY HOOK **RE-PRESS: press it back DOWN.** Kai's block tower crashes, and he feels the anger rising, but he presses it back down and takes a slow breath: he **represses** it.

Dev had to **repress** *a laugh when the principal's microphone squeaked.*

PARTS **re-** back + **press** press

SIMILAR hold back, restrain, suppress, stifle
OPPOSITE express, release, vent

suppress suh-PRES *verb*



MEANING to put down by force; to keep from being seen or known

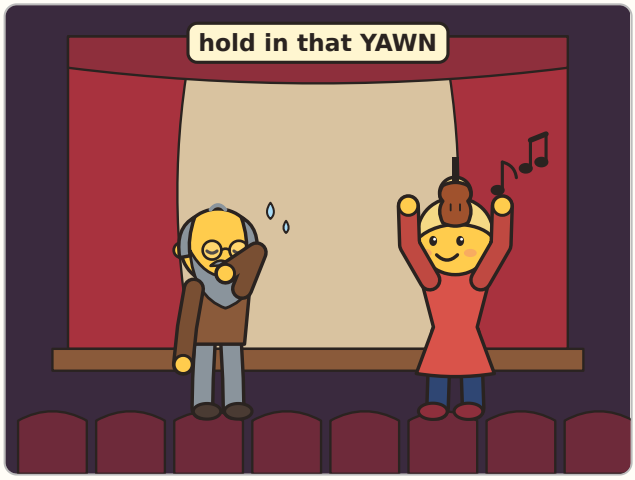
MEMORY HOOK **SUP-PRESS: press it DOWN UNDER.** Omar pours bucket after bucket until the campfire is pressed down to nothing: he **suppresses** the flames.

The firefighters worked all night to **suppress** *the brush fire.*

PARTS **sup- (sub-)** under + **press** press

SIMILAR put down, quell, crush, repress
OPPOSITE encourage, reveal, release

stifle STY-ful *verb*



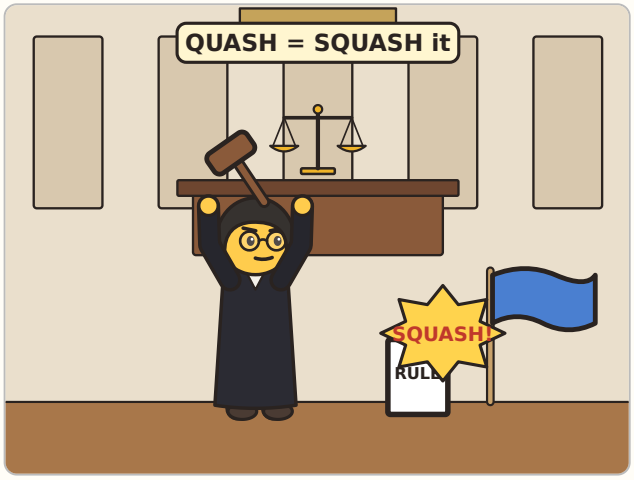
MEANING to hold back, as a yawn or a laugh; also, to smother

MEMORY HOOK **a STIFF hand: STIF-le the yawn.** In the middle of the long concert, Professor Edwin clamps a stiff hand over his mouth to hold in a giant yawn: he **stifles** it.

Grandpa **stifled** *a yawn during the long speech.*

SIMILAR smother, muffle, hold back, repress
OPPOSITE release, express, encourage

quash KWOSH *verb*



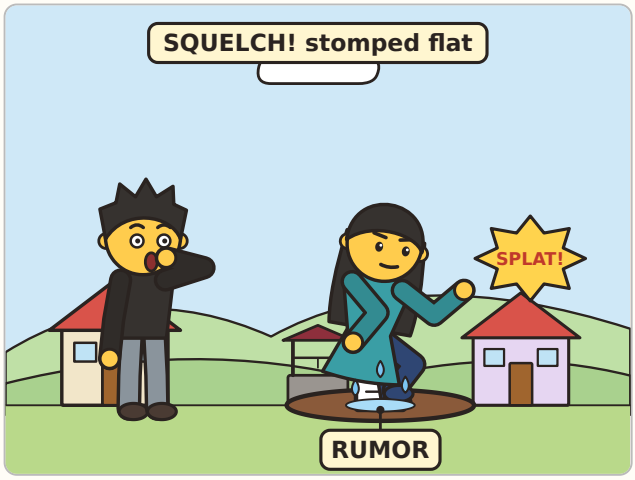
MEANING to put a complete stop to; to cancel officially

MEMORY HOOK **QUASH = SQUASH it flat.** The judge brings her gavel down on the unfair rule and squashes it flat: she **quashes** it.

The coach **quashed** *the rumor that the team was moving to another city.*

SIMILAR squash, put down, cancel, overturn
OPPOSITE uphold, approve

squelch SKWELCH *verb*



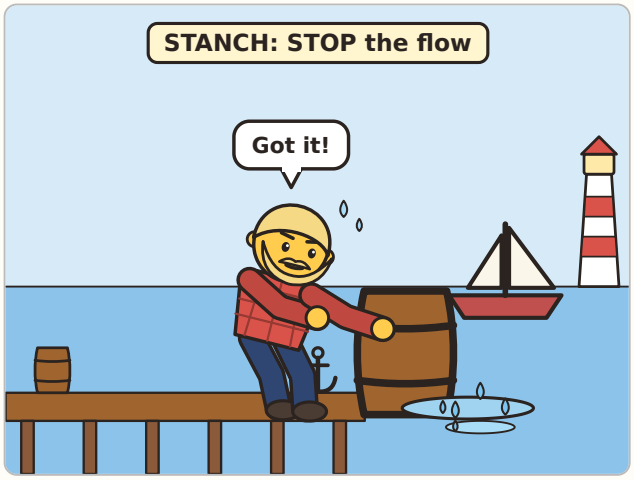
MEANING to crush or silence completely

MEMORY HOOK **SQUELCH! like a boot in the mud.** Rex starts a silly rumor, and Lin stomps on it at once, squelch, like a boot in deep mud: she **squelches** it.

Mom **squelched** *our plan to build a ramp off the garage roof.*

SIMILAR squash, silence, crush, quash
OPPOSITE encourage, foster

stanch STAWNCH *verb*



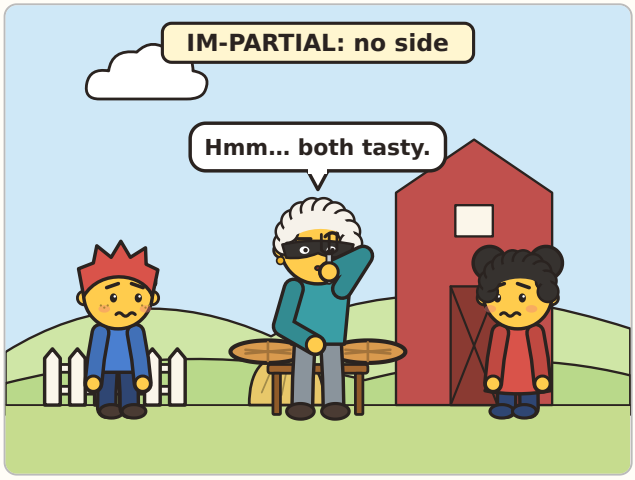
MEANING to stop the flow of a liquid

MEMORY HOOK **STANCH: STOP the gush.** Water gushes from a hole in the rain barrel, and Sven slaps his hand over it to stop the flow: he **stanches** the leak.

The plumber hurried to **stanch** *the flood from the broken pipe.*

SIMILAR stop, stem, check, halt
OPPOSITE release

impartial im-**PAR**-shul *adjective*



MEANING treating all sides equally; not taking sides

MEMORY HOOK **IM-PARTIAL: not PARTIAL to either side.** Nana Lou judges the pie contest wearing a blindfold, so she can't favor her own grandson's pie: she is **impartial**.

A good referee stays **impartial**, *even when her hometown team is playing.*

PARTS **im-** not + **part** part, side + **-ial** having to do with

SIMILAR fair, unbiased, neutral, evenhanded

OPPOSITE biased, partial, one-sided

disinterested dis-**IN**-truh-stid *adjective*



MEANING having nothing to gain or lose, and so able to judge fairly

MEMORY HOOK **no INTEREST (no stake) in who wins.** Professor Edwin judges the pet show because he owns no pets: he gains nothing whoever wins. He is **disinterested**.

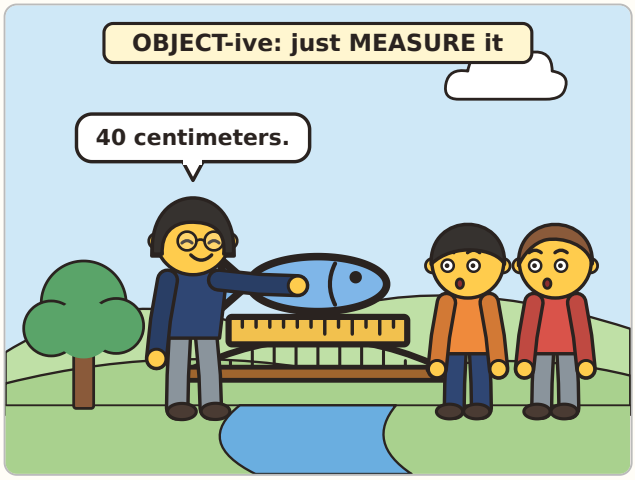
We asked a **disinterested** *neighbor to settle the argument, since she had no stake in it.*

PARTS **dis-** not + **interest** a stake, a share + **-ed** having

SIMILAR impartial, neutral, unbiased

OPPOSITE biased, partial, involved

objective ub-**JEK**-tiv *adjective*



MEANING based on facts rather than personal feelings

MEMORY HOOK **OBJECT-ive: just measure the OBJECT.** Dev and Jonah argue about whose fish is bigger, so Ada simply measures each one with a ruler: the answer is **objective**.

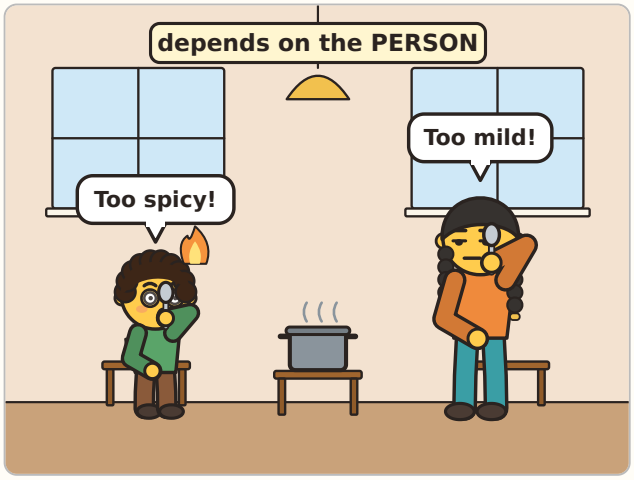
A thermometer gives an **objective** *reading of the temperature.*

PARTS **ob-** toward, before + **ject** throw + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR factual, unbiased, impartial, neutral

OPPOSITE subjective, biased, personal

subjective sub-**JEK**-tiv *adjective*



MEANING based on personal feelings, tastes or opinions

MEMORY HOOK **depends on the SUBJECT: the person.** Sami tastes the soup and gasps "Too spicy!"; Tia tastes the same soup and says "Not spicy enough!" Spiciness here is **subjective**.

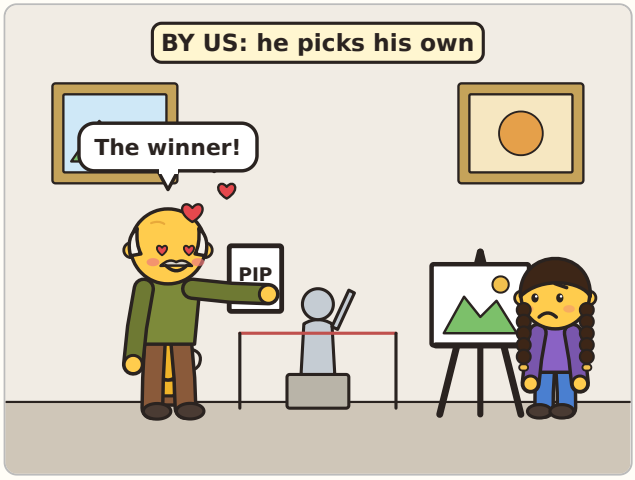
Whether a song is beautiful is partly a **subjective** *question.*

PARTS **sub-** under + **ject** throw + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR personal, individual, emotional

OPPOSITE objective, factual, impartial

bias **BY**-us *noun*



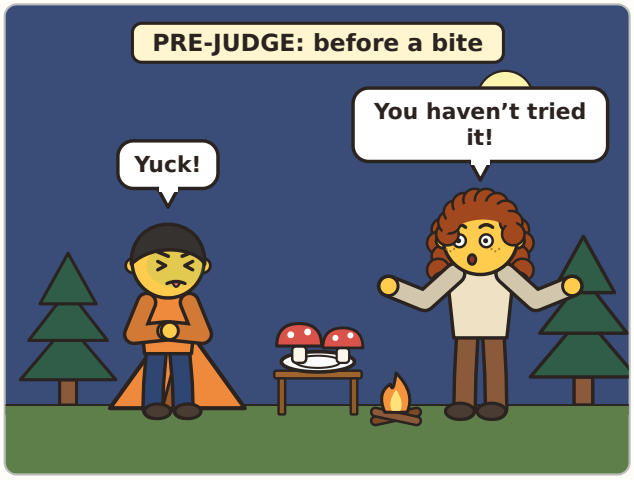
MEANING a leaning for or against someone that gets in the way of fair judgment

MEMORY HOOK **BY US: he always picks ours.** In the art contest, Grandpa always picks the drawings made by us, his grandkids, whatever they look like: that is **bias**.

The coach admitted a **bias** *toward players who showed up early.*

SIMILAR partiality, favoritism, prejudice, leaning
OPPOSITE fairness, impartiality, neutrality

prejudice **PREJ**-uh-dis *noun*



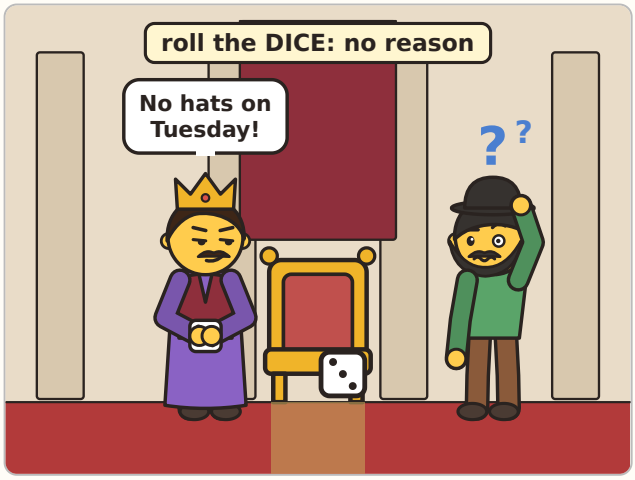
MEANING an opinion formed before knowing the facts, usually an unfair one

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-JUDGE: before a single bite.** Dev decides he hates mushrooms before he has tasted a single bite: "Yuck!" He is judging ahead of time, out of **prejudice**.

Lila tried to read the new book without **prejudice**, *even though she had disliked the author's first one.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **judic** judgment
SIMILAR preconception, bias, prejudgment, intolerance
OPPOSITE open-mindedness, fairness

arbitrary **AR**-bih-trair-ee *adjective*



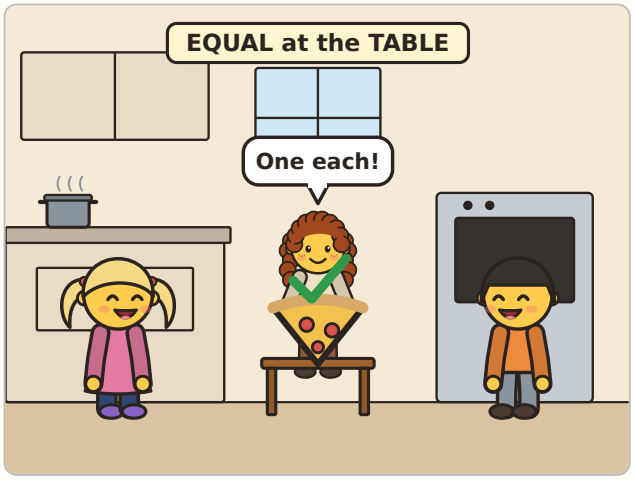
MEANING based on whim or chance rather than on reason

MEMORY HOOK **the king rolls the dice: no reason at all.** King Victor rolls dice to decide each new rule: "Tuesday: no hats!" His rules are **arbitrary**.

The order of the names on the list was **arbitrary**; *it meant nothing at all.*

SIMILAR random, capricious, whimsical, unreasoned
OPPOSITE reasoned, logical, rational

equitable **EK**-wih-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING fair and just to everyone involved

MEMORY HOOK **EQUI-TABLE: EQUAL shares at the TABLE.** Nell cuts the pizza into equal slices so everyone at the table gets the same: her way of sharing is **equitable**.

The sisters worked out an **equitable** *plan for sharing the bike.*

PARTS **equ** equal, fair + **-able** having the quality of
SIMILAR fair, just, evenhanded, impartial
OPPOSITE unfair, unjust, biased

dispassionate dis-**PASH**-uh-nit *adjective*



MEANING calm and fair; not swayed by strong feelings

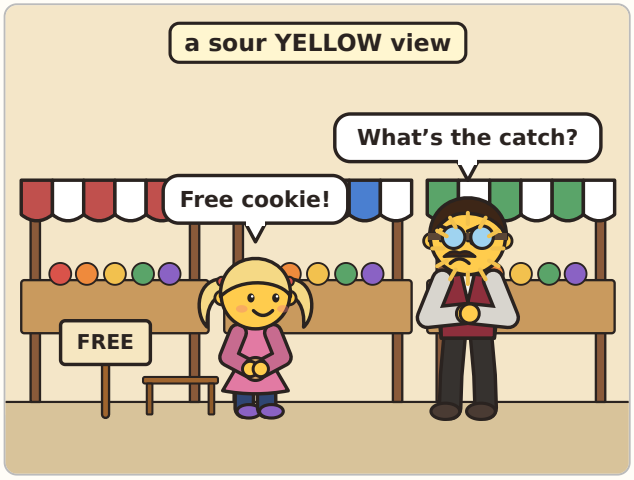
MEMORY HOOK **DIS-PASSION: no PASSION, just a calm call.** The fans shout and stamp, but the referee calmly checks the line and makes her call: she is **dispassionate**.

The scientist gave a **dispassionate** *report of the results, neither cheering nor complaining.*

PARTS **dis-** without + **passion** strong feeling + **-ate** having the quality of

SIMILAR calm, detached, impartial, cool
OPPOSITE emotional, passionate, heated

jaundiced JAWN-dist *adjective*



MEANING soured by bitterness, envy or distrust

MEMORY HOOK **seeing through sour YELLOW glasses.** Ivy offers Uncle Victor a free cookie, but he squints through his old yellow glasses: "What's the catch?" His view of everything is **jaundiced**.

After losing money once, Uncle Victor took a **jaundiced** *view of every bargain.*

SIMILAR bitter, cynical, distrustful, resentful
OPPOSITE trusting, optimistic

arduous AR-joo-us *adjective*



MEANING needing great effort; hard and tiring

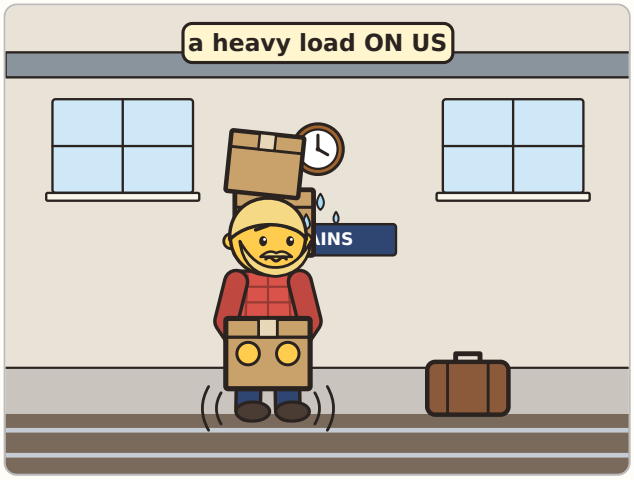
MEMORY HOOK **HARD-uous: a steep, HARD climb.** The trail rises like a wall, and Tia and Marcus puff up it one step at a time: the climb is **arduous**.

The **arduous** *climb took six hours, almost all of it uphill.*

PARTS **ardu** steep, high (Latin arduus) + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR strenuous, demanding, grueling, laborious
OPPOSITE easy, effortless, light

onerous ON-er-us *adjective*



MEANING heavy and troublesome, like a burden

MEMORY HOOK **a heavy load ON US.** Every box in the move lands on us: Sven staggers along under a tower of them. The job is **onerous**.

Caring for twelve goats turned out to be an **onerous** *chore.*

PARTS **oner (onus)** load, burden + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR burdensome, heavy, taxing, oppressive
OPPOSITE light, easy

laborious luh-**BOR**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING needing a lot of slow, careful work

MEMORY HOOK **LABOR-ious: so much LABOR.** Felix copies the whole thick book by hand with a feather pen, one slow letter at a time: the work is **laborious**.

Copying the old recipe book by hand was a **laborious** *job.*

PARTS **labor** work + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR painstaking, toilsome, arduous, tedious
OPPOSITE easy, effortless, quick

grueling **GROO**-uh-ling *adjective*



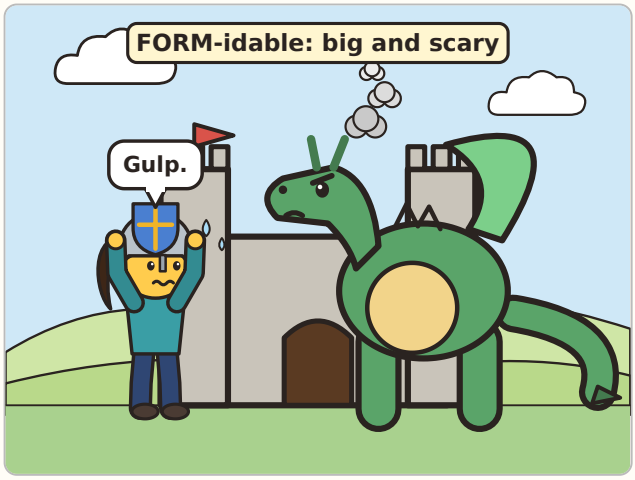
MEANING extremely tiring and demanding

MEMORY HOOK **too tired for anything but GRUEL.** After hiking up and down three mountains, Jonah is too tired to eat anything but a bowl of mush, called gruel: the hike was **grueling**.

After a **grueling** *practice in the heat, the team flopped onto the grass.*

SIMILAR exhausting, punishing, arduous, strenuous
OPPOSITE easy, relaxing

formidable **FOR**-mih-duh-bul *adjective*



MEANING inspiring fear or respect through size, strength or difficulty

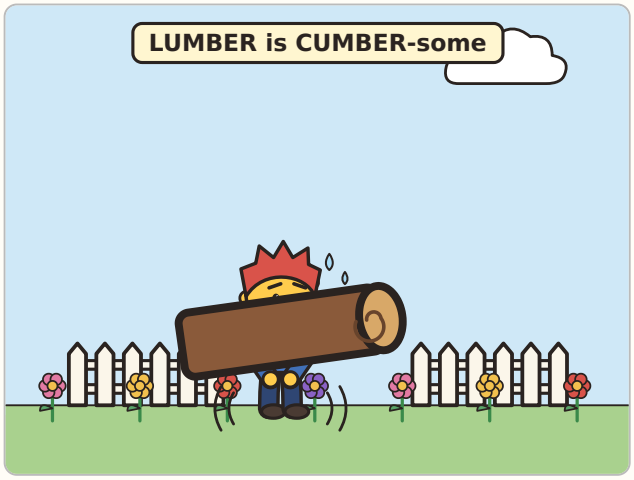
MEMORY HOOK **FORM-idable: a FORM so big you fear it.** The dragon guarding the gate is huge, fast and clever, and even brave Maya takes a deep breath: it is a **formidable** foe.

The chess champion was a **formidable** *opponent.*

PARTS **formid** fear (Latin formido) + **-able** able to be, worth being

SIMILAR daunting, intimidating, imposing, powerful
OPPOSITE weak, feeble, unimpressive

cumbersome **KUM**-ber-sum *adjective*



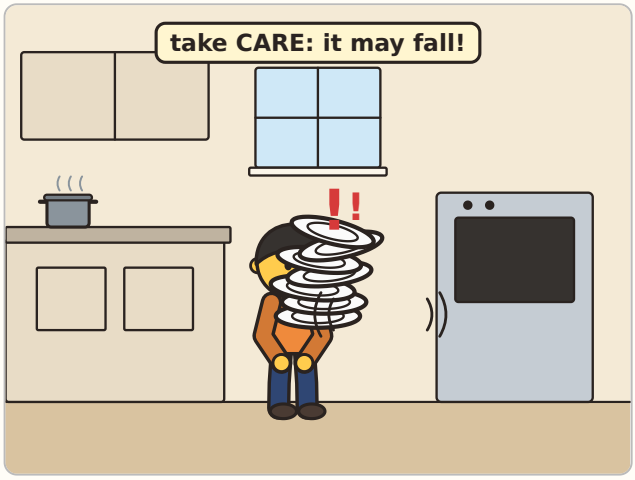
MEANING large and awkward to carry or use; also, slow and complicated

MEMORY HOOK **LUMBER is CUMBER-some.** Pip tries to carry a huge piece of lumber home by himself, but it is so long and heavy that he can barely shuffle: it is **cumbersome**.

The **cumbersome** *old suitcase had no wheels and kept banging into my knees.*

SIMILAR awkward, unwieldy, bulky, clumsy
OPPOSITE handy, convenient, compact

precarious prih-**KAIR**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING unsteady and likely to fall or fail

MEMORY HOOK **take CARE! pre-CARE-ious.** Dev carries a wobbling tower of twelve plates across the kitchen. Take care! It could crash at any moment: the stack is **precarious**.

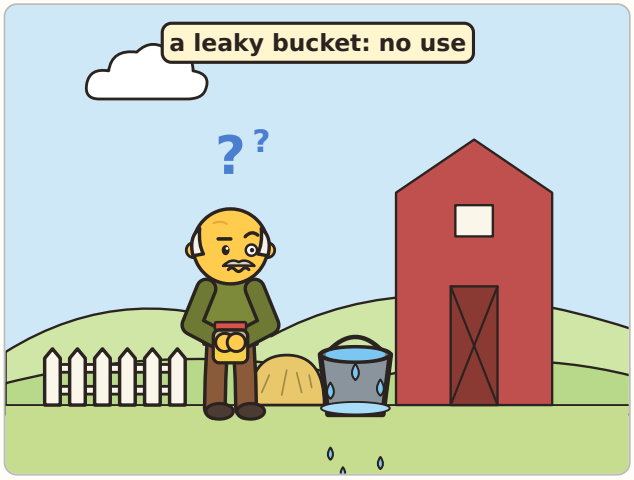
The cat sat in a **precarious** *spot on the very edge of the shelf.*

PARTS **prec** pray, beg + **-arious** having to do with

SIMILAR unstable, shaky, risky, perilous

OPPOSITE stable, secure, safe

futile **FYOO**-tul *adjective*



MEANING useless; having no chance of success

MEMORY HOOK **FUTILE = leaky: filling a bucket full of holes.** Grandpa Gus keeps pouring water into a bucket full of holes, and it runs out as fast as it goes in: his effort is **futile**.

Trying to stay dry in that storm was **futile**.

SIMILAR useless, pointless, vain, hopeless

OPPOSITE useful, effective, fruitful

facile **FAS**-ul *adjective*



MEANING too simple to be useful; shallow and easy

MEMORY HOOK **FAS-ul: a FAST, too-easy fix.** Asked how to save the old theater, Rex says, “Just tell people to come!”, as if it were that simple. His answer is **facile**.

The essay offered a **facile** *answer to a hard question.*

PARTS **fac** do, make + **-ile** able to be

SIMILAR superficial, simplistic, glib, shallow

OPPOSITE profound, thoughtful, careful

effortless **EF**-ert-lis *adjective*



MEANING needing, or seeming to need, no effort at all

MEMORY HOOK **EFFORT-LESS: no sweat.** Pip puffs halfway up the ladder, but the cat springs straight onto the top shelf in one smooth leap: for her it is **effortless**.

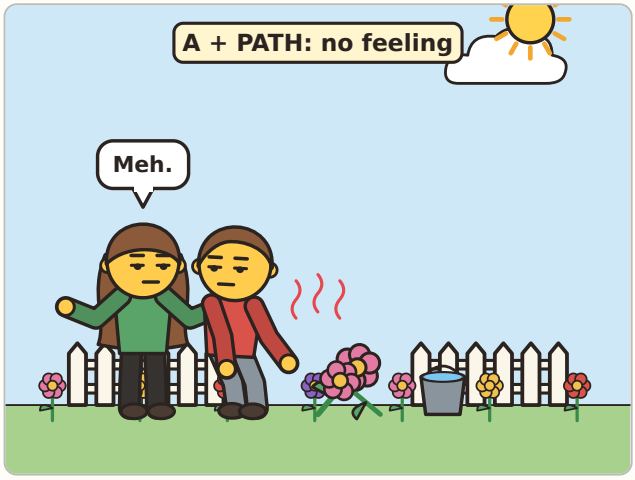
The dancer made the high leap look **effortless**.

PARTS **effort** hard work + **-less** without

SIMILAR easy, smooth, graceful, painless

OPPOSITE arduous, laborious, difficult

apathy **AP**-uh-thee *noun*



MEANING lack of interest, feeling or concern

MEMORY HOOK **A + PATH: WITHOUT feeling.** The class garden is wilting in the sun, but everyone just shrugs and walks past: nobody cares. That is **apathy**.

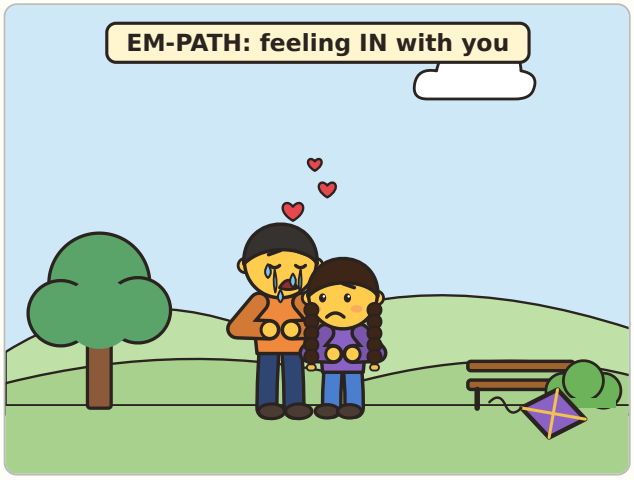
The team's **apathy** *was plain: no one even came to the last practice.*

PARTS **a-** without + **path** feeling + **-y** state or quality

SIMILAR indifference, unconcern, listlessness, detachment

OPPOSITE concern, enthusiasm, interest

empathy **EM**-puh-thee *noun*



MEANING the ability to understand and share another person's feelings

MEMORY HOOK **EM-PATH: feeling IN their shoes.** When Dev's kite breaks, Lila feels his sadness as if it were her own and gives him a hug: she has **empathy**.

Thanks to his **empathy**, *Sami always knew when a friend needed cheering up.*

PARTS **em-** in + **path** feeling + **-y** state or quality

SIMILAR understanding, compassion, fellow feeling

OPPOSITE indifference, callousness

antipathy an-**TIP**-uh-thee *noun*



MEANING a strong, settled dislike

MEMORY HOOK **ANTI-PATH: a feeling AGAINST.** From the day they met, Whiskers the cat and Rufus the dog have glared and growled at each other: they share a deep **antipathy**.

Grandpa's **antipathy** *toward loud music was no secret.*

PARTS **anti-** against + **path** feeling + **-y** state or quality

SIMILAR dislike, hostility, aversion, animosity

OPPOSITE liking, affection, sympathy

pathos **PAY**-thos *noun*



MEANING a quality in a story, speech or scene that stirs pity or sadness

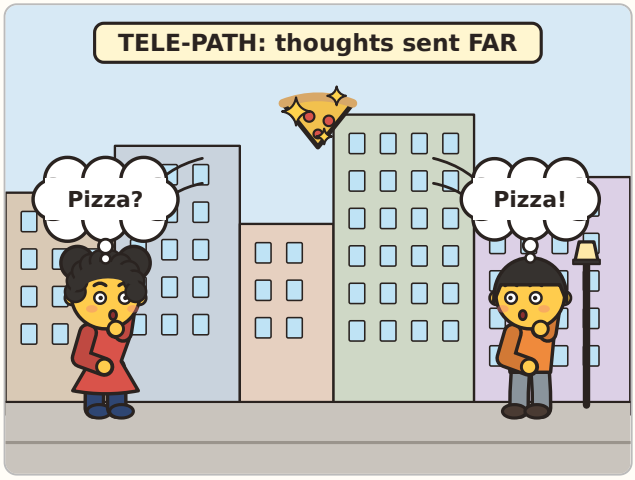
MEMORY HOOK **PATH-os: the sad PATH home.** In the school play, the lost puppy walks its lonely path home through the rain, and the audience reaches for tissues: the scene is full of **pathos**.

The movie's last scene, with the old dog waiting by the door, is full of **pathos**.

PARTS **path** feeling, suffering

SIMILAR poignancy, pity, sadness, emotion

telepathy tuh-**LEP**-uh-thee *noun*



MEANING the supposed sending of thoughts from one mind to another without words

MEMORY HOOK **TELE-PATH: feelings sent FAR.** Zoe is at one end of the town and Kai at the other, yet both suddenly think "Pizza!" at the same moment: they joke that it is **telepathy**.

The twins joked that they had **telepathy** *because they always ordered the same sandwich.*

PARTS **tele-** far + **path** feeling + **-y** state or quality

SIMILAR mind reading, thought transfer

philanthropist fih-**LAN**-thruh-pist *noun*



MEANING a person who gives money or time to help others

MEMORY HOOK **PHIL loves ANTHROPOS: Phil loves people.** Phil loves people so much that he pays for a brand-new park where everyone in town can play: Phil is a **philanthropist**.

A local **philanthropist** *paid for new books in every classroom.*

PARTS **phil** love + **anthrop** human being + **-ist** a person who

SIMILAR benefactor, donor, patron, humanitarian

OPPOSITE miser, misanthrope

bibliophile **BIB**-lee-uh-file *noun*



MEANING a person who loves books

MEMORY HOOK **BIBLIO = book, PHILE = lover.** Granny Mae hugs her newest book like an old friend, surrounded by towers of the ones she already loves: she is a **bibliophile**.

The **bibliophile** *had books stacked on every chair in his house.*

PARTS **biblio** book + **phile** lover of

SIMILAR book lover, bookworm

misanthrope **MIS**-un-throhp *noun*



MEANING a person who dislikes people in general

MEMORY HOOK **MIS + ANTHROP: dislikes PEOPLE.** Rex lives alone at the top of the hill behind a sign that says GO AWAY, and he grumbles at every friendly visitor: he is a **misanthrope**.

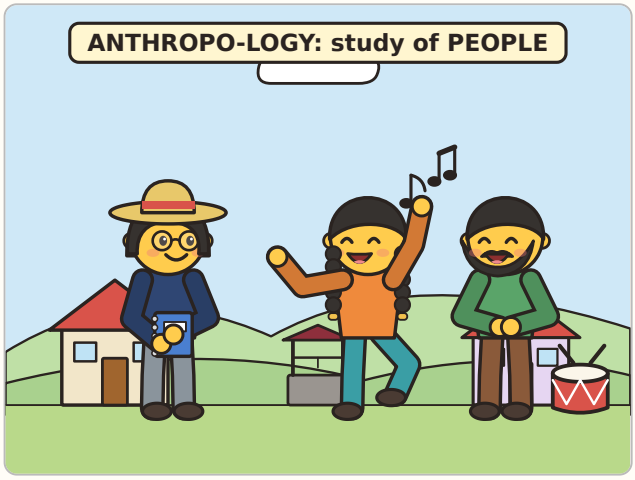
The grumpy **misanthrope** *in the story lives alone on a cliff and turns away every visitor.*

PARTS **mis (miso)** hate + **anthrop** human being

SIMILAR people hater, cynic, grouch

OPPOSITE philanthropist, humanitarian

anthropology an-thruh-**POL**-uh-jee *noun*



MEANING the study of human beings and their ways of life

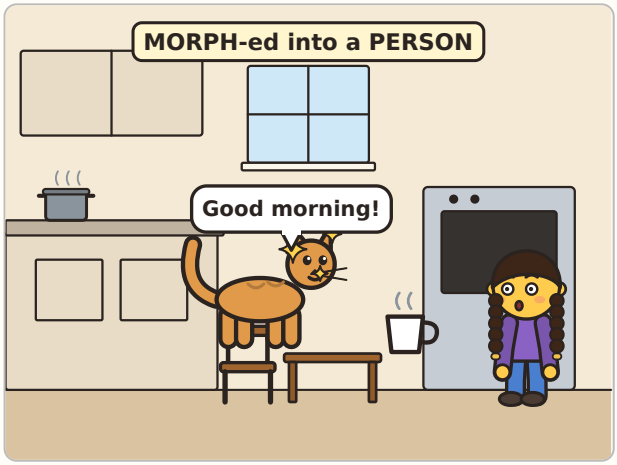
MEMORY HOOK **ANTHROPO + LOGY: the study of PEOPLE.** Ada spends a year in a mountain village, writing down how people cook, dance, farm and tell stories: she works in **anthropology**.

Maya plans to study **anthropology** *to learn how people around the world celebrate the new year.*

PARTS **anthrop** human being + **-logy** study of

SIMILAR study of humankind, ethnology

anthropomorphic an-thruh-puh-**MOR**-fik *adjective*



MEANING giving human form or traits to animals or things

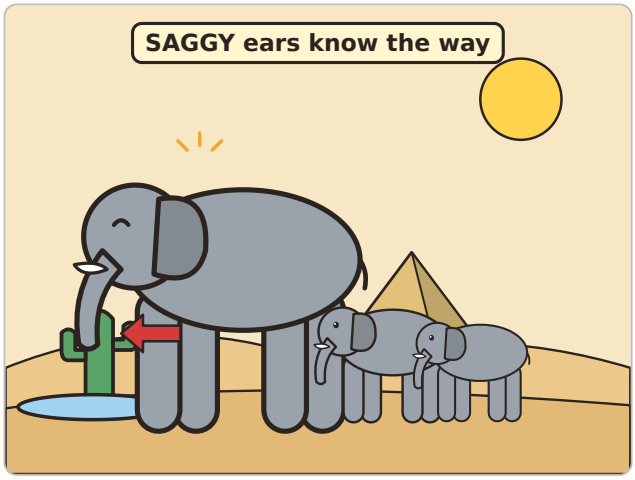
MEMORY HOOK **ANTHROPO + MORPH: in HUMAN shape.** In Lila's picture book, the cat sits at the breakfast table, sips tea and says "Good morning!" just like a person: the cat is **anthropomorphic**.

Fairy tales are full of **anthropomorphic** *animals who talk and wear clothes.*

PARTS **anthrop** human being + **morph** form, shape + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR humanlike, personified

sagacious suh-**GAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING wise, with sound judgment drawn from experience

MEMORY HOOK **SAGGY ears that know the way.** In the dry season, the old elephant with saggy, wrinkled ears leads the herd straight to the hidden water hole: she is **sagacious**.

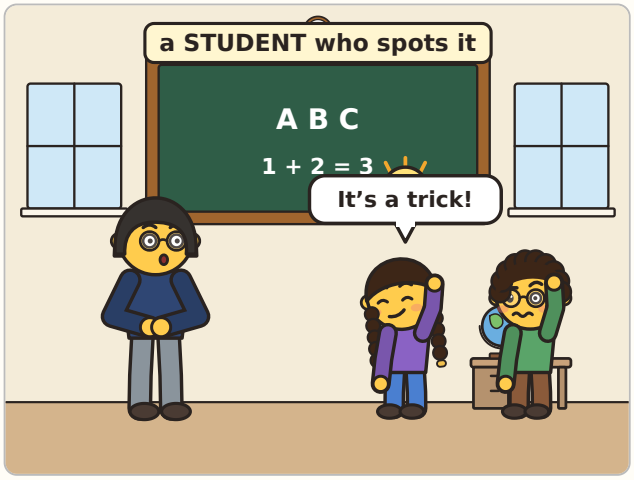
The **sagacious** *old captain could read the coming weather in the clouds.*

PARTS **sagac** keen, quick to notice + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR wise, sage, shrewd, perceptive

OPPOSITE foolish, unwise

astute uh-**STOOT** *adjective*



MEANING quick to see what matters and to use it well

MEMORY HOOK **a STUDENT who spots it: a-STUTE.** The teacher's riddle hides a trick, and Lila spots it in a second: "It's a trick question!" She is **astute**.

An **astute** *reader will notice the clue hidden in the first chapter.*

SIMILAR perceptive, sharp, shrewd, quick-witted

OPPOSITE obtuse, dull, slow

shrewd **SHROOD** *adjective*



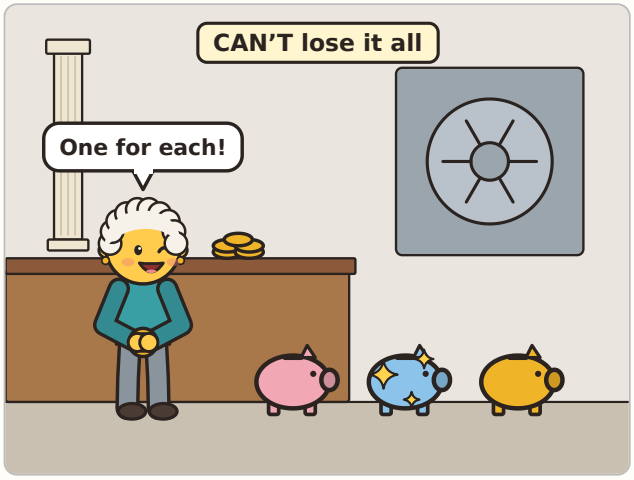
MEANING sharp and clever in practical matters

MEMORY HOOK **the SHREW-d little shrew.** The little shrew sets up his lemonade stand at the top of the hill, right where the hikers are thirstiest: he is **shrewd**.

Grandma is a **shrewd** *bargainer who never pays full price at the flea market.*

SIMILAR astute, canny, clever, sharp
OPPOSITE naive, gullible

canny **KAN**-ee *adjective*



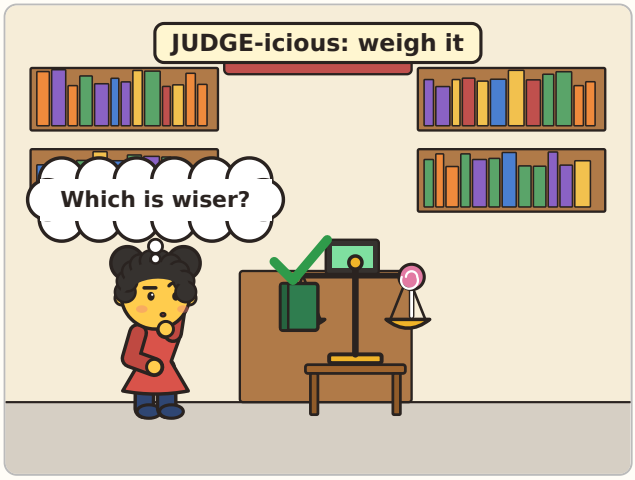
MEANING careful and shrewd, especially with money or business

MEMORY HOOK **she CAN'T lose it all: CAN-ny.** Nana Lou keeps her savings in three different piggy banks, so if one breaks, the rest are safe: she is **canny** with money.

The **canny** *farmer sold her peaches in the city, where they fetched twice the price.*

SIMILAR shrewd, careful, sharp, astute
OPPOSITE careless, naive

judicious joo-**DISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING showing good, sensible judgment

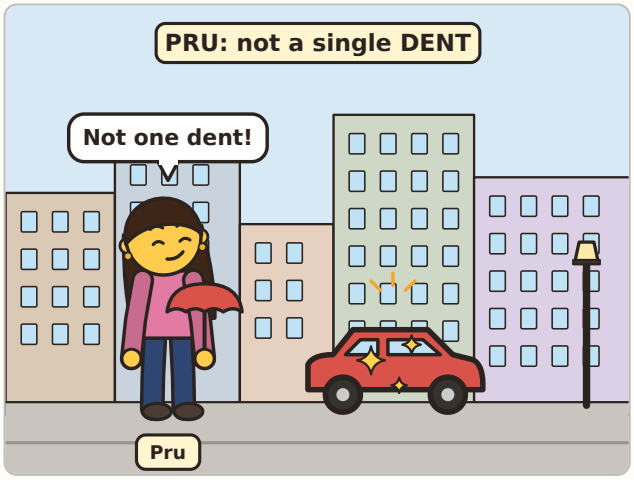
MEMORY HOOK **JUDGE-icious: weigh it like a JUDGE.** Zoe weighs her choices like a fair judge before spending her birthday money, and picks the book she will read a hundred times: she is **judicious**.

A **judicious** *pinch of salt turned the bland soup into a delicious one.*

PARTS **judic** judgment + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR wise, sensible, prudent, sound
OPPOSITE rash, unwise, foolish

prudent **PROO**-dunt *adjective*



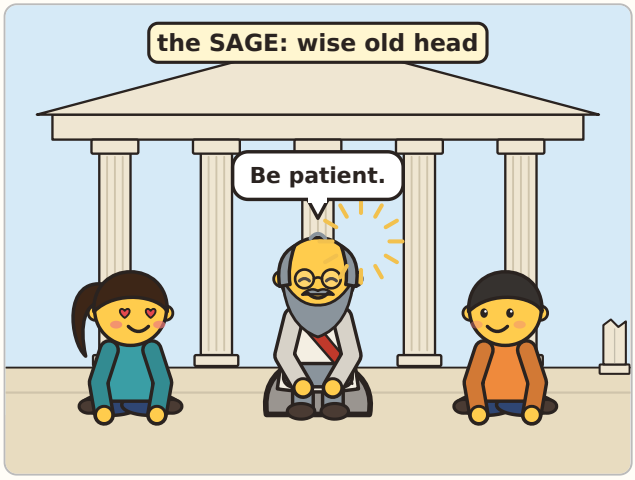
MEANING careful and sensible, especially about the future

MEMORY HOOK **PRU-DENT: Pru's car has no DENT.** Pru checks her mirrors, keeps her distance and slows down in the rain, so her old car has never had a single dent: she is **prudent**.

It is **prudent** *to pack a flashlight before a camping trip.*

SIMILAR careful, sensible, cautious, judicious
OPPOSITE reckless, rash, careless

sage SAYJ *noun*



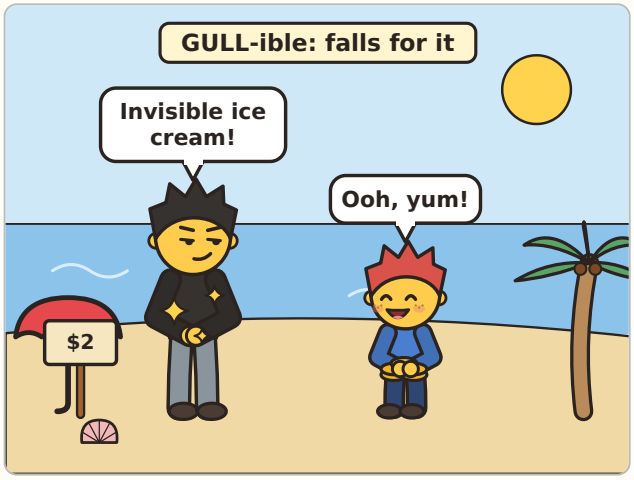
MEANING a very wise person, respected for good judgment

MEMORY HOOK **the SAGE at the top: wise old head.** The children climb all the way up the hill to ask old Edwin their hardest question, because his answers are always wise: he is a **sage**.

The village **sage** *could settle any argument with a few calm words.*

SIMILAR wise person, savant, wise elder
OPPOSITE fool

gullible GUL-uh-bul *adjective*



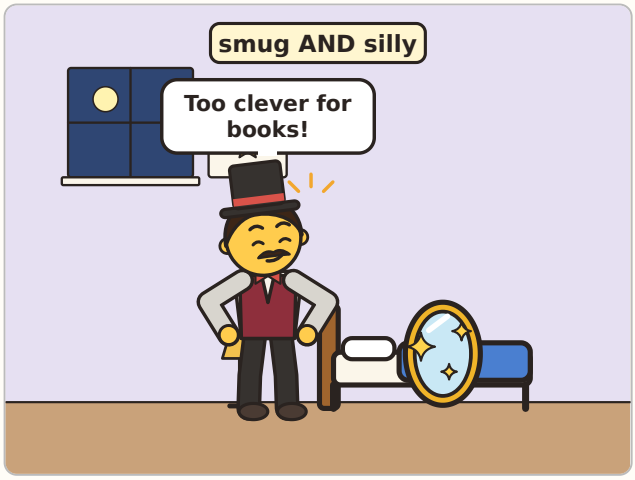
MEANING easily fooled or tricked

MEMORY HOOK **GULL-ible: a GULL swallows anything.** Rex sells Pip a cone of "invisible ice cream" for two dollars, and Pip happily pays: he is **gullible**.

The **gullible** *tourist paid twenty dollars for a "solid gold" ring made of brass.*

PARTS **gull** trick, one easily tricked + **-ible** able to be
SIMILAR naive, credulous, trusting, easily fooled
OPPOSITE skeptical, suspicious, shrewd

fatuous FACH-oo-us *adjective*



MEANING silly and pointless, in a smug way

MEMORY HOOK **a smug grin and a silly idea.** Admiring himself in the mirror, Victor announces, "I am far too clever to need books!" His remark is **fatuous**: silly, and very pleased with itself.

The host kept making **fatuous** *jokes about the weather that no one laughed at.*

PARTS **fatu** foolish + **-ous** full of, having
SIMILAR silly, foolish, inane, vacuous
OPPOSITE wise, sensible, thoughtful

obtuse ub-TOOS *adjective*



MEANING slow to understand or to notice

MEMORY HOOK **an OBTUSE angle: blunt, not SHARP.** Everyone shouts "Surprise!" under a giant banner with Sven's name on it, and he still asks whose birthday it is: he is being **obtuse**.

Sven was being **obtuse**; *everyone else had guessed the surprise.*

SIMILAR slow, dense, imperceptive, dull
OPPOSITE sharp, astute, perceptive

belittle bih-**LIT**-ul *verb*



MEANING to make someone or something seem small or unimportant

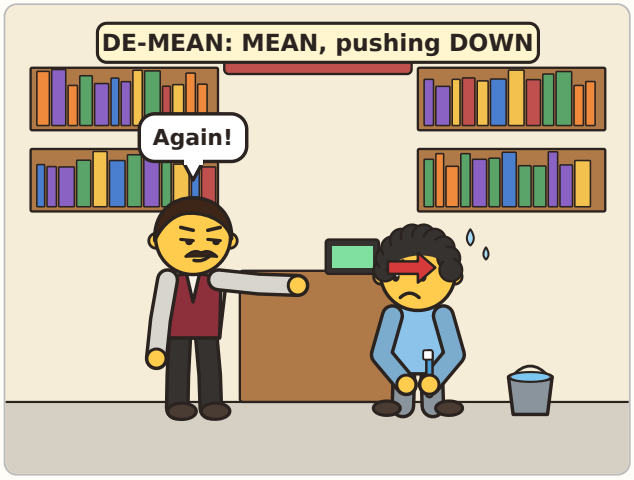
MEMORY HOOK **BE-LITTLE: makes you feel LITTLE.** Rex sneers, “Baby stuff!” at Pip’s drawing, and Pip feels about two inches tall: Rex **belittles** it.

Don’t **belittle** *your little brother’s drawing; he worked hard on it.*

PARTS **be-** make + **little** small

SIMILAR disparage, diminish, put down, minimize
OPPOSITE praise, compliment, exalt

demean dih-**MEEN** *verb*



MEANING to lower someone’s dignity or standing

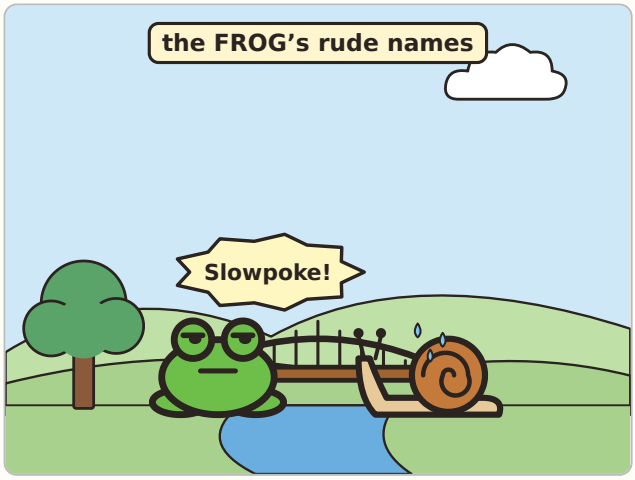
MEMORY HOOK **DE-MEAN: MEAN and lowering.** Just to show who is boss, Victor makes the new worker scrub the whole floor with a toothbrush: the order is meant to **demean** him.

The coach refused to **demean** *his players by yelling insults at them.*

PARTS **de-** down + **mean** low, poor

SIMILAR degrade, humiliate, debase, lower
OPPOSITE honor, dignify, respect

derogatory dih-**ROG**-uh-tor-ee *adjective*



MEANING showing a low opinion; insulting

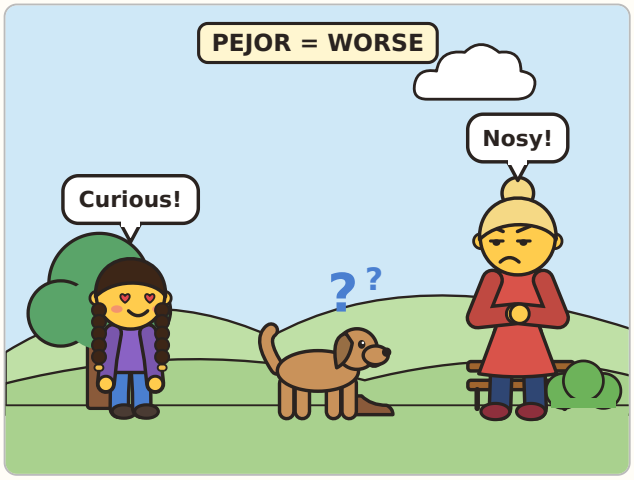
MEMORY HOOK **de-ROG: the rude FROG’s names.** The rude frog croaks a nasty name at every snail that passes: “Slowpoke!” His remarks are **derogatory**.

The referee warned the player to stop making **derogatory** *comments about the other team.*

PARTS **de-** away, down + **rog** ask (Latin rogare) + **-atory** having to do with

SIMILAR insulting, disparaging, disrespectful, pejorative
OPPOSITE complimentary, flattering, respectful

pejorative pih-**JOR**-uh-tiv *adjective*



MEANING showing disapproval; giving a word a negative slant

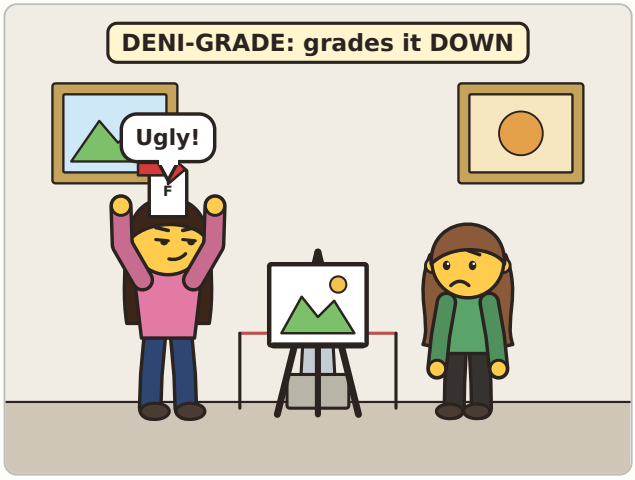
MEMORY HOOK **PEJOR = WORSE: NOSY, not curious.** Lila calls the sniffing puppy “curious”; Aunt Greta calls it “nosy.” Same puppy, but nosy is the **pejorative** word: it makes things sound worse.

“Cheap” is a **pejorative** *way of saying “thrifty.”*

PARTS **pejor** worse + **-ative** tending to

SIMILAR disparaging, derogatory, negative, disapproving
OPPOSITE complimentary, approving, positive

denigrate DEN-ih-grayt *verb*



MEANING to criticize unfairly; to run down

MEMORY HOOK **DENI-GRADE: grades it DOWN.** Whatever the class paints, the jealous judge grades it down: “Ugly. Boring. F!” She **denigrates** their work.

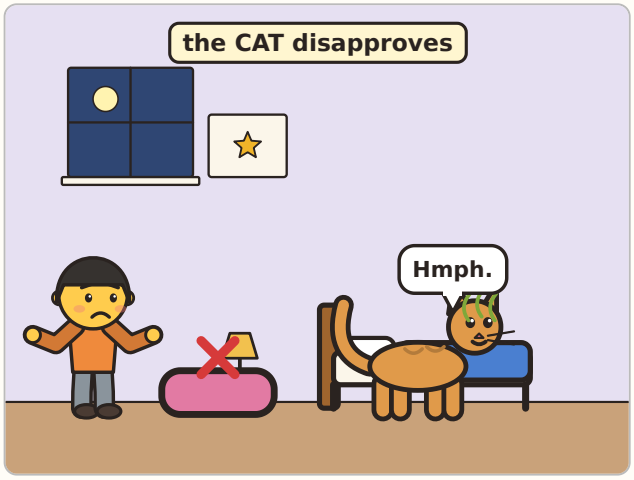
It is unkind to **denigrate** *other people’s work just to make your own look better.*

PARTS **de-** down, completely + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR disparage, belittle, run down, malign

OPPOSITE praise, commend, extol

deprecate DEP-rih-kayt *verb*



MEANING to express disapproval of; also, to play down

MEMORY HOOK **DEPRE-CAT-e: the CAT disapproves.** The cat sniffs the fancy new cushion, wrinkles her nose and stalks away: she **deprecates** it.

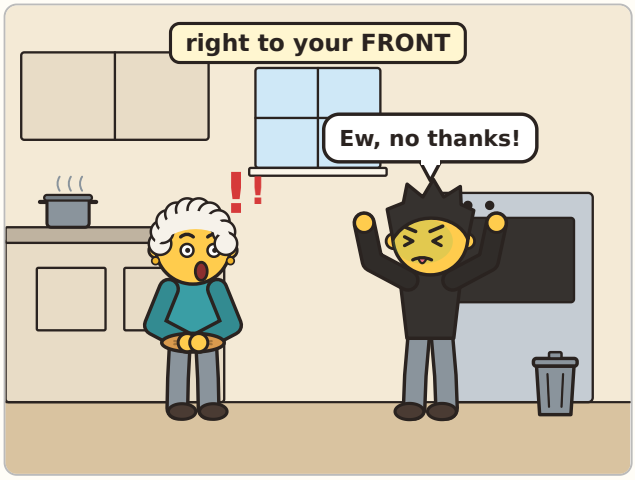
The museum guide politely **deprecated** *touching the paintings.*

PARTS **de-** away + **prec** pray + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR disapprove of, criticize, play down

OPPOSITE approve, endorse, praise

affront uh-FRUNT *noun*



MEANING an open insult; something that offends

MEMORY HOOK **right to your FRONT: af-FRONT.** Right in front of everyone, Rex pushes away Nana Lou’s homemade pie and says, “Ew, no thanks!” It is an **affront**.

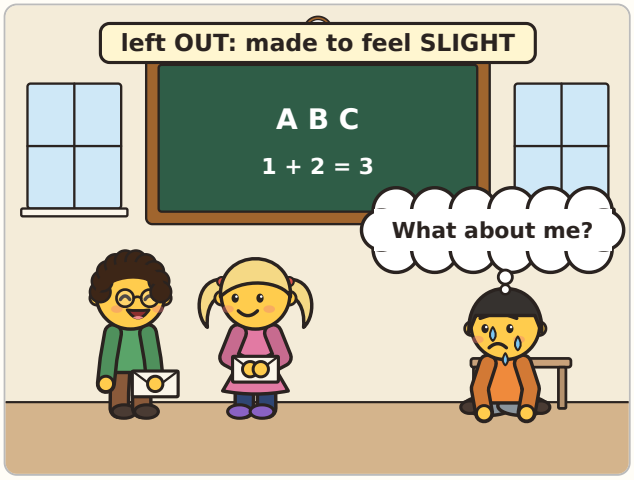
Arriving an hour late to his own party was an **affront** *to his guests.*

PARTS **af- (ad-)** to + **front** forehead, face

SIMILAR insult, offense, slap in the face, outrage

OPPOSITE compliment, courtesy

slight SLITE *noun*



MEANING an act that shows disrespect, often by ignoring or leaving someone out

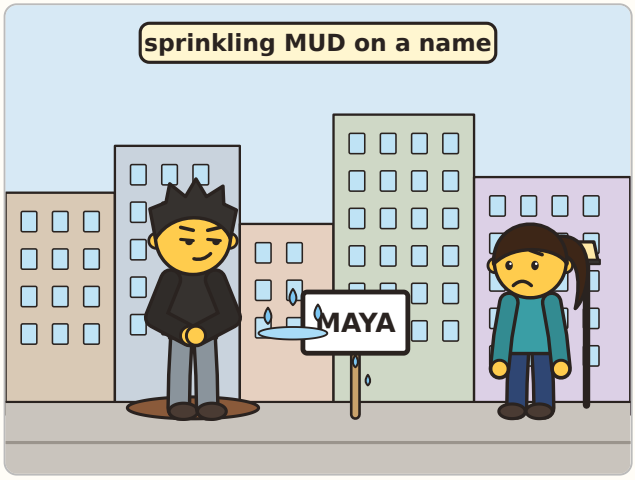
MEMORY HOOK **made to feel SLIGHT (small).** Ivy hands a party invitation to everyone in class except Kai; being left out on purpose makes him feel small. It is a **slight**.

Leaving Kai off the invitation list was a **slight** *he never forgot.*

SIMILAR snub, insult, rebuff, cold shoulder

OPPOSITE compliment, courtesy, honor

aspersion uh-**SPUR**-zhun *noun*



MEANING an attack on someone's good name, usually unfair

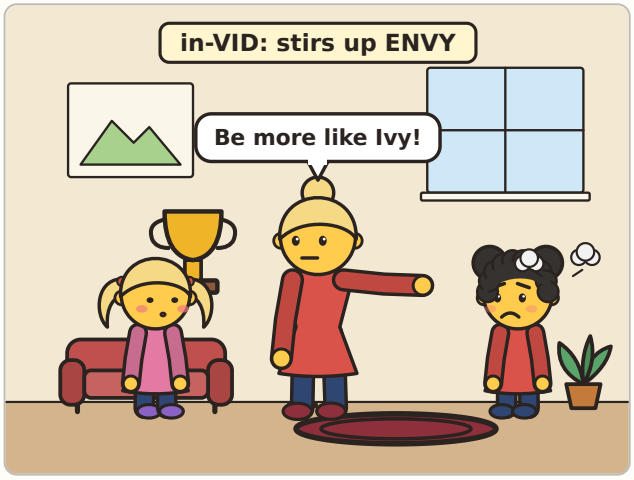
MEMORY HOOK **a-SPERS: SPRINKLING mud on a name.** Rex flicks muddy rumors at the poster with Maya's name on it, splattering her good name: he casts **aspersions** on her.

Rex cast **aspersions** *on Maya's honesty without a shred of proof.*

PARTS **a- (ad-)** on, to + **spers** sprinkle, scatter + **-ion** the act or result of

SIMILAR slander, smear, insinuation, attack
OPPOSITE praise, compliment

invidious in-**VID**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING likely to stir up envy or resentment; unfair

MEMORY HOOK **in-VID: comparisons that stir ENVY.** "Why can't you be more like your sister?" Aunt Greta asks, pointing at Ivy's trophy while Zoe looks on: the comparison is **invidious**.

It is **invidious** *to compare brothers' report cards in front of the whole family.*

PARTS **in-** upon + **vid** see, look + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR unfair, hurtful, resentment-stirring
OPPOSITE fair, inoffensive, harmless

tirade **TY**-rayd *noun*



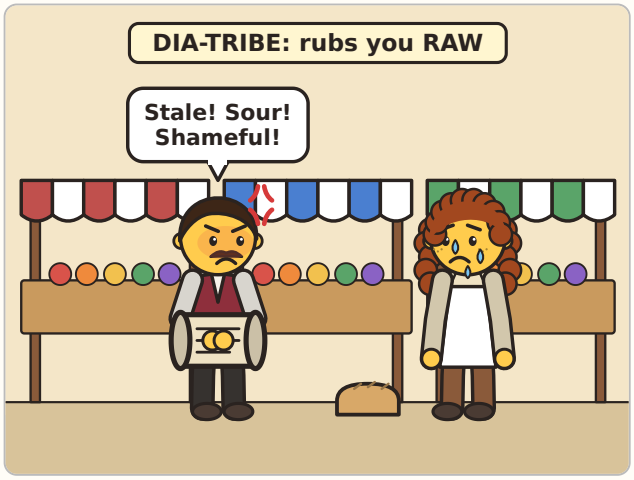
MEANING a long, angry speech, often scolding someone

MEMORY HOOK **TIRE-ade: so long it TIRES you out.** Grandpa Gus rants about the ball in his tulips for so long that the children are worn out just listening: it is a **tirade**.

After the ball broke his window, the neighbor launched into a ten-minute **tirade** *about careless children.*

SIMILAR rant, harangue, diatribe, outburst
OPPOSITE praise, compliment

diatribe **DY**-uh-tribe *noun*



MEANING a bitter, sharply critical attack in speech or writing

MEMORY HOOK **DIA-TRIBE: words that RUB you raw.** The critic reads out his long, bitter scroll about the bakery: "Stale! Sour! Shameful!" His **diatribe** rubs poor Nell raw.

His letter to the editor was a **diatribe** *against the new parking rules.*

PARTS **dia-** through + **tribe** rub (Greek tribein)

SIMILAR tirade, harangue, denunciation, attack
OPPOSITE praise, tribute

harangue huh-**RANG** *noun*



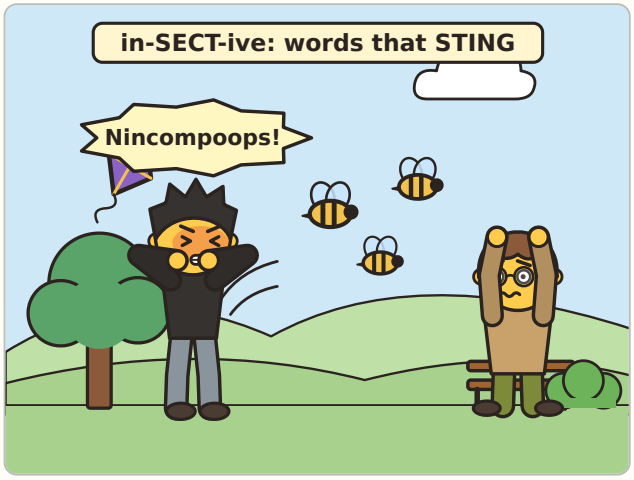
MEANING a long, loud lecture meant to scold or stir people up

MEMORY HOOK **ha-RANG: it RANG in our ears.** Coach Ada lectures the team at the top of her lungs for twenty minutes, and her words rang in their ears all night: a real **harangue**.

The coach's halftime **harangue** *could be heard from the parking lot.*

SIMILAR lecture, tirade, rant, diatribe

invective in-**VEK**-tiv *noun*



MEANING insulting, abusive language

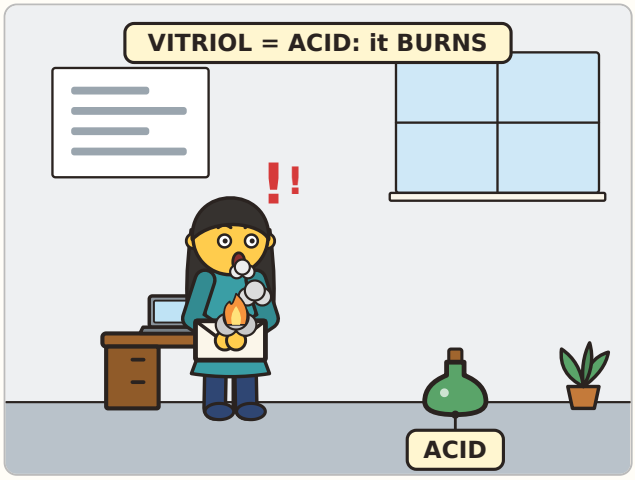
MEMORY HOOK **in-SECT-ive: words that STING.** When his kite gets stuck in a tree, Rex lets fly a swarm of stinging insults at everyone nearby: his **invective** stings like a cloud of bees.

The two rival chefs traded **invective** *across the crowded kitchen.*

PARTS **in-** against + **vect** carry + **-ive** tending to, doing

SIMILAR abuse, insults, vitriol, name-calling
OPPOSITE praise, compliments

vitriolic vit-ree-**OL**-ik *adjective*



MEANING bitterly harsh and cruel in speech or writing

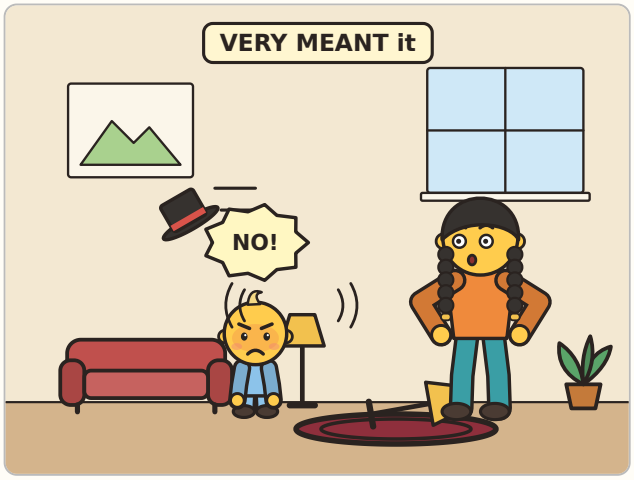
MEMORY HOOK **VITRIOL = acid: words that BURN.** The angry letter is so bitter that it seems to smoke on the page, like acid eating through paper: it is **vitriolic**.

The **vitriolic** *review hurt the young author's feelings for weeks.*

PARTS **vitri** glass + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR bitter, venomous, caustic, scathing
OPPOSITE kind, gentle, mild

vehement **VEE**-uh-munt *adjective*



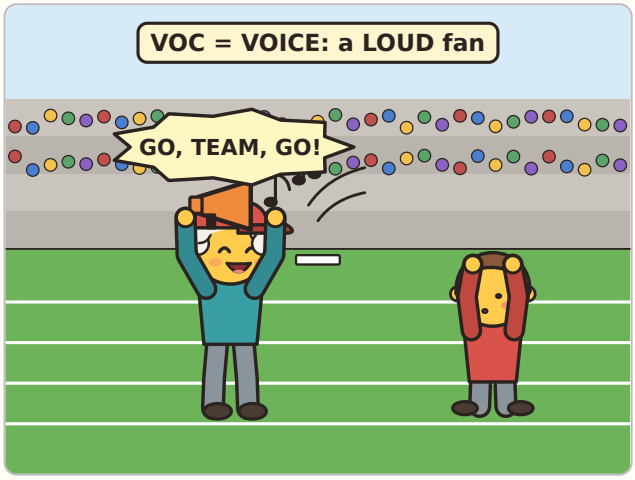
MEANING showing strong, intense feeling; forceful

MEMORY HOOK **VERY-MEANT: he VERY much MEANT it.** Asked whether he broke the lamp, Theo shakes his head so hard his hat flies off: "NO!" He very much means it; his denial is **vehement**.

Despite her **vehement** *protests, Maya was given the early shift.*

SIMILAR forceful, fierce, passionate, intense
OPPOSITE mild, calm, halfhearted

vociferous voh-**SIF**-er-us *adjective*



MEANING loud and forceful in expressing opinions

MEMORY HOOK **VOC = VOICE: a VOICE that carries.** Nana Lou cheers so loudly at every game that the players can hear her from the far end of the field: she is a **vociferous** fan.

*The **vociferous** fans cheered every single point.*

PARTS **voc** voice + **fer** carry + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR loud, outspoken, noisy, clamorous
OPPOSITE quiet, silent, muted

strident **STRY**-dunt *adjective*



MEANING loud and harsh; forceful in a grating way

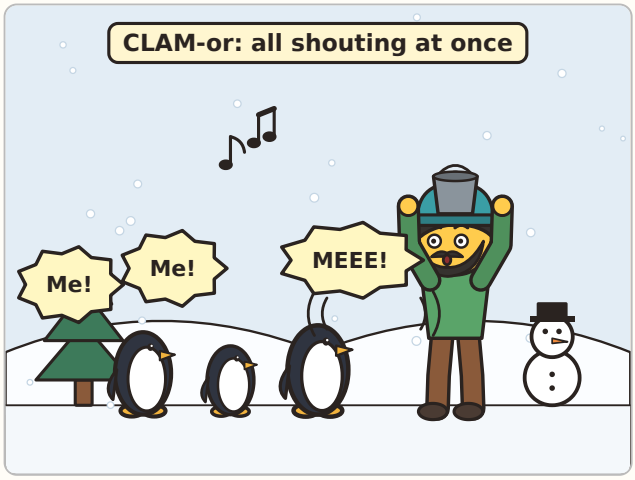
MEMORY HOOK **STRI-dent: a screeching STRING.** Sami saws away at his violin, and the strings shriek so harshly that the dog howls along: the sound is **strident**.

*The **strident** car alarm went off at three in the morning.*

PARTS **strid** creak, shriek + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR harsh, shrill, grating, piercing
OPPOSITE soft, mellow, gentle

clamor **KLAM**-er *noun*



MEANING a loud, confused noise, especially of people demanding something

MEMORY HOOK **CLAM-or: all shouting for CLAMS.** At feeding time, the penguins crowd around the keeper, all squawking at once for clams and fish: what a **clamor**!

*The **clamor** of the crowd outside drowned out the speaker.*

PARTS **clam** cry out + **-or** the act or state of

SIMILAR din, uproar, racket, outcry
OPPOSITE silence, quiet, hush

cacophony kuh-**KOF**-uh-nee *noun*



MEANING a harsh, jarring mix of sounds

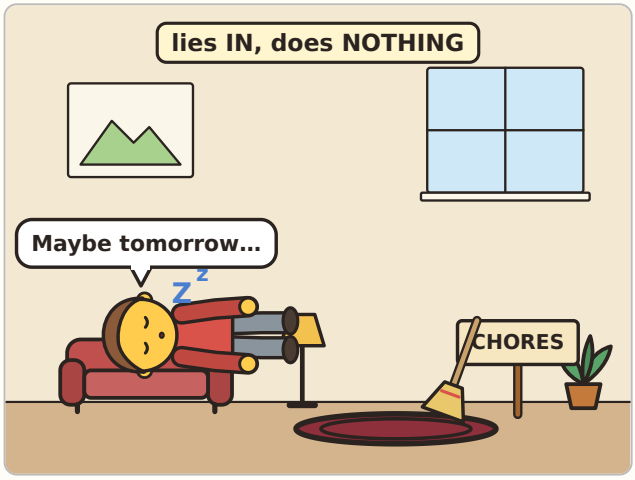
MEMORY HOOK **CACO = bad, PHON = sound.** On the first day of band practice, every beginner plays a different song at once, and Professor Edwin covers his ears: the result is a **cacophony**.

*Car horns, sirens and barking dogs made a **cacophony** outside my window.*

PARTS **caco-** bad + **phon** sound + **-y** state or quality

SIMILAR din, racket, discord, noise
OPPOSITE harmony, euphony

indolent IN-duh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING lazy; unwilling to work or make an effort

MEMORY HOOK **lies IN all day: IN-dolent.** The chore list grows longer every day, but Jonah stays sprawled on the sofa, too idle to lift a finger: he is **indolent**.

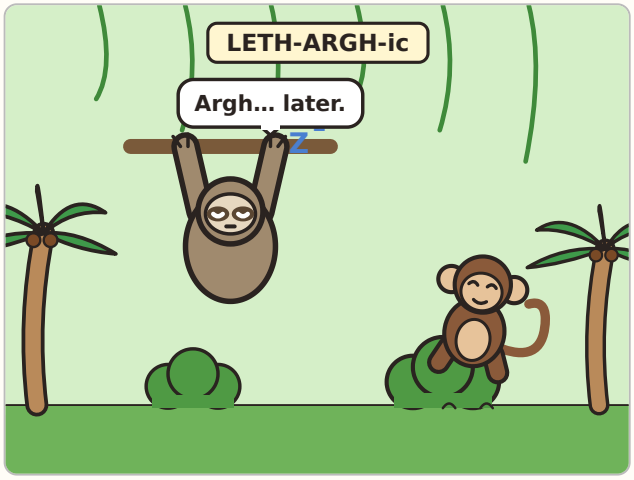
*The **indolent** cat watched the mouse run past without even lifting its head.*

PARTS **in-** not + **dol** feel pain, take trouble + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR lazy, idle, slothful, sluggish

OPPOSITE industrious, diligent, energetic

lethargic luh-THAR-jik *adjective*



MEANING sluggish and drowsy; lacking energy

MEMORY HOOK **LETH-ARGH-ic: "Argh… later".** The monkey bounces around shouting "Come and play!", but the sloth just groans, "Argh… later." The sloth is **lethargic**.

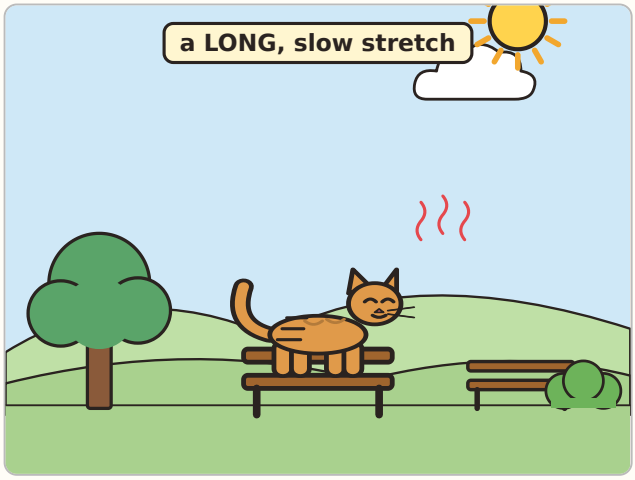
*The heat made everyone **lethargic**, and no one wanted to play outside.*

PARTS **leth** forgetting + **arg** idle + **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR sluggish, drowsy, listless, sleepy

OPPOSITE energetic, lively, vigorous

languid LANG-gwid *adjective*



MEANING slow, relaxed and without energy, often in a graceful way

MEMORY HOOK **LANG-uid: a LONG, lazy stretch.** On a hot afternoon, the cat stretches out long on the sunny bench and moves only to flick her tail: she is **languid**.

*We spent a **languid** afternoon floating on the lake.*

PARTS **langu** faint, weak + **-id** being in a state of

SIMILAR relaxed, unhurried, leisurely, listless

OPPOSITE brisk, energetic, vigorous

listless LIST-lis *adjective*



MEANING without energy, interest or spirit

MEMORY HOOK **LIST-LESS: no wish to do a thing.** When the big game is called off, Lila slumps on the floor with her to-do list still blank; she has no wish to do anything at all. She is **listless**.

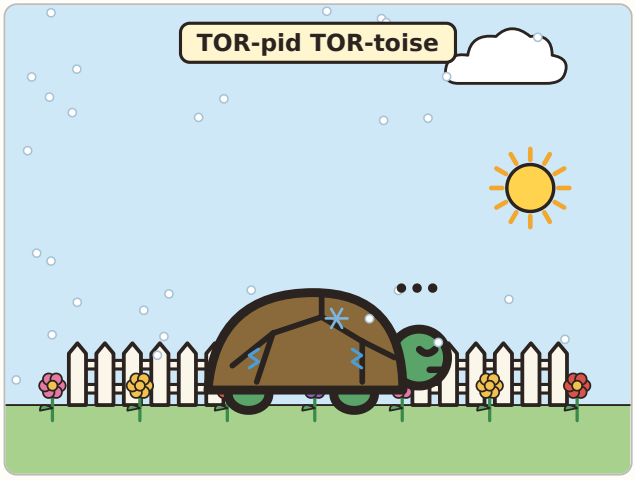
*Without its morning walk, the dog lay **listless** by the door.*

PARTS **list** wish, desire (an old word) + **-less** without

SIMILAR lifeless, lethargic, spiritless, limp

OPPOSITE lively, energetic, spirited

torpid TOR-pid *adjective*



MEANING slow and inactive, as if numb

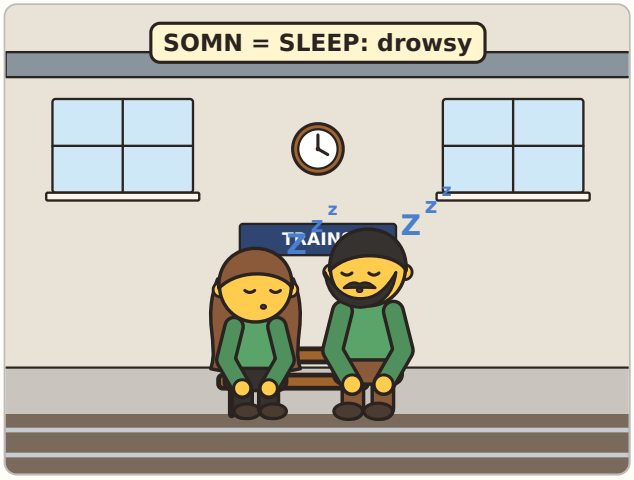
MEMORY HOOK **a TOR-pid TORtoise.** On a frosty morning, the tortoise hardly moves at all until the sun warms its shell: it is **torpid**.

In the cold, the **torpid** *lizard barely moved.*

PARTS **torp** numb + **-id** being in a state of

SIMILAR sluggish, inactive, lethargic, dormant
OPPOSITE active, lively, alert

somnolent SOM-nuh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING sleepy and drowsy; ready to doze off

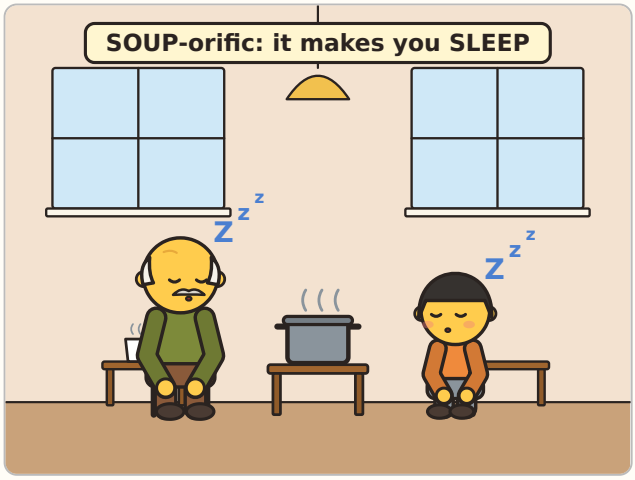
MEMORY HOOK **SOMN = sleep: drowsy on the train.** On the long ride home, Rosa's head keeps nodding toward her shoulder, and her eyes won't stay open: she is **somnolent**.

The **somnolent** *passengers dozed as the train rocked along.*

PARTS **somn** sleep + **-olent** full of

SIMILAR sleepy, drowsy, dozy
OPPOSITE alert, wide-awake

soporific sop-uh-**RIF**-ik *adjective*



MEANING causing sleep or drowsiness

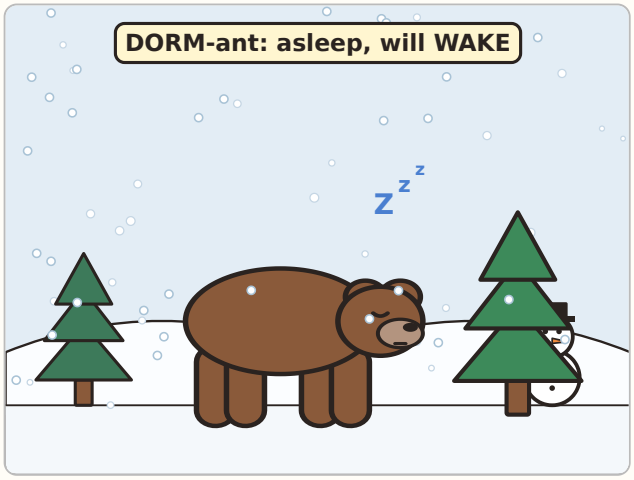
MEMORY HOOK **SOUP-orific: soup that makes you SLEEPY.** Nana Lou's warm soup is so soothing that after one bowl, Grandpa and Kai both nod off at the table: the soup is **soporific**.

The speaker's **soporific** *voice put half the class to sleep.*

PARTS **sopor** deep sleep + **-ific** making, causing

SIMILAR sleep-inducing, sedative, dull
OPPOSITE stimulating, invigorating, exciting

dormant DOR-munt *adjective*



MEANING asleep or inactive for a time, but able to wake again

MEMORY HOOK **DORM-ant: asleep, but it will WAKE.** All winter the bear sleeps under the snow, quiet and still, but in spring it will wake up hungry: through the winter it is **dormant**.

The **dormant** *volcano has not erupted for three hundred years.*

PARTS **dorm** sleep + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR inactive, asleep, resting, latent
OPPOSITE active, awake

lassitude LAS-ih-tood *noun*



MEANING a heavy tiredness of body or mind

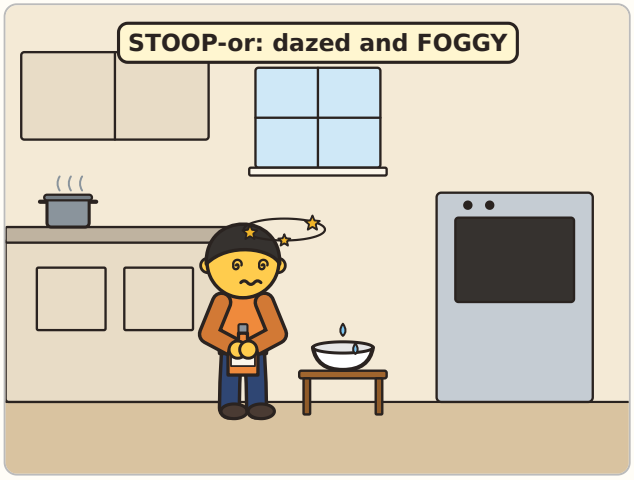
MEMORY HOOK **the tired LASS: LASS-itude.** After a week of exams and late nights, the lass drags her heavy backpack home, weary in every bone: she is full of **lassitude**.

A strange **lassitude** *came over him after the long trip.*

PARTS **lass** weary + **-itude** the state of

SIMILAR weariness, fatigue, tiredness, exhaustion
OPPOSITE energy, vigor, vitality

stupor STOO-per *noun*



MEANING a dazed state in which one can hardly think or act

MEMORY HOOK **STOOP-or: stooping, dazed and foggy.** Half asleep at dawn, Dev stoops over the table and pours orange juice onto his cereal: he is in a **stupor**.

Woken at five in the morning, Dev stumbled around in a **stupor**.

PARTS **stup** be stunned + **-or** the state of

SIMILAR daze, trance, torpor, fog
OPPOSITE alertness, awareness